

Citizens can file grievances via jan sunwai portal, says CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday said citizens will no longer have to make repeated visits to government offices or stand in long queues for their everyday issues and instead can register their grievances on the "CM Jan Sunwai portal."

The mobile app is a unified platform where complaints related to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), Delhi Development Authority (DDA), Delhi Police and all departments of the Delhi Government can be registered in one place.

Citizens can also track the progress of their complaints through the portal. If a person is not satisfied with the resolution, the system automatically escalates the matter to higher authorities (appellate authority), she said.

Giving this assurance



during her interaction with citizens during a public grievance hearing session, Rekha Gupta said public satisfaction remains the Government's ultimate benchmark of success.

She also noted that apart from the online system, citizens can register their grievances through the call centre helpline (1902) or by visiting the Chief Minister's Office (CMO) in person and submitting their concerns offline.

The Chief Minister further

said the Delhi government has expanded the Common Service Centre (CSC) network to bridge the digital divide.

Over 7,000 centres across the city are now providing 75 key e-District services, including income, caste and residence certificates, birth and death certificates, and pension-related services. A nominal fee of ₹30 has been fixed for these services to curb exploitation by middlemen and cyber cafes.

Rekha Gupta said that listening to citizens and addressing their problems effectively is the true measure of good governance. "This reflects Delhi's new work culture, where the government is reaching out to the people at their doorstep," she said, adding that the Government is committed to strengthening the administrative system on the pillars of service, transparency and public participation. During the session, the Chief Minister patiently listened to the concerns raised by people and issued strict instructions to the concerned officials present on the spot to ensure their prompt and time-bound resolution.

Delhi's ongoing digital transformation, she added, will ensure that the era of running from one government office to another becomes a thing of the past and that access to public services becomes a simple and basic right for every citizen.

DU teachers flag concerns over fourth year research component under UGCF 2022

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University (DU) teachers affiliated to the Democratic Teachers' Front (DTF) wrote a letter to the vice chancellor on Wednesday raising concerns regarding the research component that had been introduced in the fourth year of undergraduate programmes under the revised Undergraduate Curriculum Framework (UGCF) 2022.

This comes after a recent university notification, dated January 22, regarding the "approved rates of remuneration for evaluation-related activities."

The notification mentioned that a remuneration of ₹1,500 shall be paid to the teachers for evaluation of the projects in the final semester of the UG courses.

Calling the DU notification an "unacademic approach to the research component", DTF further



said in its letter that while the Semester VIII evaluation keeps extremely steep and unrealistic goals for students in the form of Scopus publications, books, book chapters, patents or presentations at recognised national or international conferences, the university is falling short in recognising what it takes to conduct academic research.

While the concerns raised by DTF are not new and have been spoken about by faculty members repeatedly

since the start of the first batch of UG fourth years in 2025 under the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, a fresh wave of concerns has been highlighted in the letter regarding how overburdened students have become with "unrealistic heavy-duty papers along with UG research".

"Students are finding themselves in a bind as they find themselves at the same crossroad as they were after completing 3 years of the UGCF. The 4th year as such

does not guarantee them next-level mobility.

"The crossroads for students of the 4th year remain the same as those for 3rd-year students," the letter says, adding problems like lack of time available to students for self-study and library work, student-teacher ratio, current teaching and administrative workload of teachers and infrastructure requirements which remain unmet.

Among the concerns raised regarding the evaluation process, DTF said that a previous notification dated January 8 had asked colleges to appoint one expert per eight to ten students, which is academically unviable. "Furthermore, remuneration for experts is to be provided for their input on a batch of 15 students, which is irrational. Also, the notification is silent about any remuneration for the VII semester evaluation, which is also for 240 marks."

Ex-serviceman declared dead to claim ₹3 lakh Army insurance found alive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A former Indian Army jawan, along with two others, has been booked for making a fraudulent death claim to secure insurance benefits worth ₹3 lakh from the Army Group Insurance Fund.

According to an FIR registered on March 6, the case pertains to a claim made in 2011 under the Extended Insurance Scheme of the Army Group Insurance Fund (AGIF).

Police said the accused include ex-sepoy Akhilesh Kumar, his wife Gyanti Devi and Sohan Pandit, the then sarpanch of Kako in Bihar's Jehanabad district, who allegedly issued and attested a fake death certificate.

The FIR has been registered under Sections 420 (cheating) and thereby dishonestly



inducing delivery of property, or the making, alteration or destruction of a valuable security), 468 (forgery for the purpose of cheating) and 471 (using as genuine a forged document or electronic record) of the IPC.

According to the complaint, Kumar was enrolled in the Bihar Regiment of the Indian Army on January 2, 1998, and was discharged from service on October 5, 2010. He had completed 12 years and eight months of service and was not entitled to a service pension.

Kumar had nominated his wife Gyanti Devi and later his

son Deepak Kumar to receive insurance benefits in the event of his death.

In November 2011, Devi submitted an extended insurance certificate, claiming that her husband died on September 17, 2011, due to an electric shock.

Police said she later submitted supporting documents, including a death certificate issued by the village sarpanch (Pandit), an affidavit, an indemnity bond, family details and bank account details, to the Army Group Insurance Fund Directorate in May 2013 to process the claim.

Based on these documents, the AGIF released the insurance amount of ₹3 lakh in June 2013 to Devi's bank account. An amount of ₹21,750 was later paid as interest for delayed payment, the FIR read.

Govt to introduce specialised medical programmes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is planning to introduce two new specialised medical programmes at major government hospitals in the capital to strengthen medical education and improve specialised healthcare services.

The proposed courses include a Gynecological Oncology Fellowship at Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital and a DNB Primary Course in Family Medicine at Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital.

According to the Delhi Health Department, the new programmes aim to expand specialised training opportunities for doctors while improving access to advanced medical care for patients.

Delhi Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh said the initiative reflects the Government's commitment to strengthening both healthcare services and



medical education in government hospitals.

He said expanding specialised training programmes will help build a stronger healthcare workforce while ensuring that patients receive better treatment and specialised medical care in the capital. Under the proposal, a Gynecological Oncology Fellowship will be started at Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital with one seat.

The programme will be conducted under the aegis

of the Association of Gynecologic Oncologists of India.

The fellowship will focus on developing specialised expertise in diagnosing and treating gynecological cancers, which include cancers of the uterus, ovaries, and cervix. Health officials said such specialised training has become increasingly important as tertiary care hospitals treat a growing number of complex cancer cases.

Doctors undergoing the

fellowship will receive advanced training in surgical procedures, diagnosis, and treatment strategies related to gynecological oncology. Officials said this will help improve specialised cancer care services in government hospitals. In addition to the fellowship programme, the government is also planning to introduce a DNB Primary Course in Family Medicine at Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital.

The programme will offer four post-MBBS seats and will be launched after obtaining accreditation from the National Board of Examinations. Officials said the family medicine programme is aimed at strengthening the availability of trained doctors in primary healthcare. Family medicine specialists play an important role in community healthcare systems because they provide comprehensive medical care for patients of all age groups.

Delhi teen Aayush set for Para Athletics Grand Prix

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Eighteen-year-old Aayush from Delhi is all prepared to represent India at the upcoming World Para Athletics Grand Prix 2026, scheduled to be held at Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium from March 11-13, 2026.



Competing in the F20 category for athletes with intellectual impairment, the young shot put athlete is preparing for the biggest moment of his sporting journey, one he has been working towards for the past 3 years.

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, P.W.D (BORDER ROADS & NEC WORKS), ASSAM, CHANDMARI, GUWAHATI-03. Email- lbrcocbr2021@gmail.com

No. CE/BR/4/2026/6

SHORT NOTICE INVITING TENDER

The Chief Engineer P.W.R.D.(Border Roads& NEC Works), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3 invites Bids on behalf of Governor of Assam for 21 (Twenty one) nos. of Packages for Construction of CRIF (State Road) 10 (Ten) nos. & CRIF (Setu Bandhan) 11 (Eleven) nos. under CRIF & CRIF (Setu Bandhan) Schemes for the year 2025-26 in **Baksa, DhemaJI, Dibrugarh, Golaghat, Kamrup, Lakhimpur, Morigaon, Nagaon, Darrang, BIswanath, Hojai, Sivsagar, BIswanath, Tinsukia & Hojai Districts** of Assam from APWD (Roads) registered & eligible Contractors for a total amounting to **Rs. 68167.00** Lakh (approx) including GST(18%) and Labour Cess (1%) etc.

Details of the bid may be seen shortly at e-procurement portal website i.e. **www.assamtenders.gov.in** and also in the office of the undersigned during office hours from **11:00 AM to 5:00 PM**. Amendment /Addendum to the SBD, if any, and further notifications shall appear in this website and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours.The contractor/bidder must be registered with the Electronic Tendering System (ETS) of PWD, Assam website **www.assamtenders.gov.in**. Schemes are being approved by the competent authority. In the event of non-sanction of the Schemes, the bids may be cancelled and no claim what so ever on this account shall be entertained from the bidders.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer PWD (Border Roads & NEC Works)
Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3.

DIPR/C/PIO/962/12-Mar-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER: PWD: H&E: ASSAM: CHANDMARI: GUWAHATI-3

No. CE/TB-IV(H&E)/45/2024/8

PRESS NOTICE

The Chief Engineer, P.W.D. (Health & Education), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3 on behalf of the Governor of Assam, invites fresh Bids online e-tenders in two bid system (Eligibility and Financial) from eligible firms / contractors of repute having experience in similar nature of work, for the following works.

Details of the bid may be seen at e-procurement website i.e. **www.assamtenders.gov.in**. The bidders must be enrolled with e-tendering web-portal **www.assamtenders.gov.in**.

This work will be allotted after accordance of Administrative Approval.

All terms and conditions will be as per the Bidding Documents. The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Documents.

Sl. No.	Name of work	Bid Value (Rs in Lakhs)	Completion Period	Bid Security	Cost of Bid
1.	Construction and upgradation of Infrastructure for Sualkuchi Ballok Mojolia Vidyalaya, Sualkuchi, Kamrup, Assam	Rs.233.36404	3+15 (Eighteen) months	2% of Bid value for General, 1% of Bid Value for Reserve category	Rs. 4668.00

The Bid price may vary at the time of detail tendering for which no claim will be admissible.

Sd/-
Addl Chief Engineer (Health & Education),
(PW(H&E) Deptt., Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DIPR/C/PIO/961/12-Mar-26

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE						
SR. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP./ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) INRUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	HSIIDC	CLEANING OF STORM WATER DRAIN AT VARIOUS LOCATIONS IN SECTOR-07, INCLUDING UNDER ROAD CROSSING AND PERMANENT SLABS, AT HSIIDC INT MANESAR	11.03.2026 17.03.2026	Rs. 14.93 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9910728120 ia.manesar@hsiidc.org.in
2	HSIIDC	RE-SURFACING OF 60 MTR. AND 30 MTR. WIDE ROADS (BALANCE ROADS) AND THEREAFTER DEFECT LIABILITY PERIOD (DLP) OF 36 MONTHS IN SECTOR-8 AT INT MANESAR	12.03.2026 27.03.2026	Rs. 811.39 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9910728120 ia.manesar@hsiidc.org.in
3	HSIIDC	CLEANING AND SWEEPING OF METTLED ROAD AND THEREAFTER DISPOSAL OF WASTE IN APPROVED SITE BY MC IN INDUSTRIAL AREA SECTOR-2 IN DISTT. KURUKSHETRA	10.03.2026 16.03.2026	Rs. 13.52 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0184-2221175 ia.karnal@hsiidc.org.in
4	HSIIDC	CLEANING OF METALLED ROAD AND DISPOSAL OF SOLID WASTE FROM ROAD BERMS IN SECTOR-17, INDUSTRIAL ESTATE, BAHADURGARH	13.03.2026 20.03.2026	Rs. 13.67 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416767348 ia.bahadurgarh@hsiidc.org.in
5	HSIIDC	LIFTING AND DISPOSAL OF INDUSTRIAL WASTE FROM GREEN BELTS AREA AT MIE PART-A, BAHADURGARH	13.03.2026 20.03.2026	Rs. 14.75 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416767348 ia.bahadurgarh@hsiidc.org.in
FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in				RO 43722-I-27-7		

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform to all concern that Shri Vipin Mohan S/o Shri Col. A.C.Mohan R/o Flat No.1255, Sector-37, Noida (U.P.) who is the original owner of Flat No. 57-A, Block-U-3, Dhalwai Gali, Sector-11, Noida (U.P.) Shri Vipin Mohan expired on Dt. 11.07.2006.

The WILL was executed in favour of Shri Rajeev Kohli S/o Shri Bansil Lal Kohli R/o 57-A, Dhalwai Gali Apartment Sector-11, Noida, which is registered in Sub Registrar Delhi Dated 07.12.1990. So it is informed to all concern that the said Property Flat No. 57-A, Block-U-3, Dhalwai Gali, Sector -11, Noida (U.P.) is going to be transferred in favour of Shri Rajeev Kohli S/o Shri Bansil Lal Kohli R/o 57-A, Dhalwai Gali Apartment Sector-11, Noida U.P., if anyone has/have any objection he/she may file his/her objection alongwith the sufficient proof in the Residential (Housing) Department of the Noida Authority within 30 days from the date of publication of this notice.

Shri Rajeev Kohli

PUBLIC NOTICE

My Client Mukesh Kumar, Son of Dharum Dev Singh Aged about 45 years, and Indu Devi W/o Mukesh Kumar Aged about 43 years R/o Plot A 30 /B.A. -30/B -1, And A-30/ B-2, Gali No -8 Block B, Katyani Vihar, Rajeev Nagar Extension, Begumpur, North-West Delhi- 110086 have disowned /debarred their son Alok UID 9046-7350-9339 from all relations with him, if anybody deals with him at his/her own risk and consequences in future.

Bittu Kumar (Advocate)
Office :- C-5/88, 1st Floor, Sec-6
Rohini, Delhi-110085

NORTHERN RAILWAY TENDER NOTICE

Invitation of Tender through E-Procurement Systems

Sr. DMM, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
1	93265265	HAND HELD SCANNER LAN EXTENDER HAND HELD MINI PRINTER BAR CODE PRINTER ELECTRONIC WEIGHING MACHINE Please Check Detailed Specification in Tender	42 Nos. 10 Nos. 42 Nos. 11 Nos. 30 Nos.	06.04.2026

Note:- 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No manual offer will be entertained.

No.: Sr. DMM/NS/LP/93265265/2026 Date: 11.03.2026 822/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PUBLIC NOTICE

To be known to all that I, Ashish Dhiman S/o Sh. Dharmal Dhiman, resident of 202A T-6, Panchsheel Wellington, Crossing Republic, Ghaziabad, (U.P.) 201016 owner of the property of Flat No. 202-A, T-6, Panchsheel Wellington, Crossing Republic, Ghaziabad-201016. I have lost/misplaced the Original Allotment Letter and Builder Buyer Agreement (BBA) of the said property. A report to this effect has been lodged and acknowledged at Police Station Crossing Republic, Ghaziabad, vide General Diary (GD) / Receipt dated 25.02.2026. Any person claiming any right, title or interest or having any objection regarding the same may write/contact the undersigned at the above address or call at 9915680696 within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice.

Public Notice

This is to inform general public that Mr. Priyansh Aggarwal has acquired Residential Vacant Plot of land measuring 220 sq. Yds., out of Khata No. 00211, Kharsa No. 449, situated at Village Gulawati, Pargana Dankaur, Tehsil and District Gautam Budh Nagar, U. P. vide by way of Sale Deed dated 18.12.2025 registered as Document No. 38914. Documents related to the above said property has been misplaced i.e. Original Sale Deed (Doc. No. 1229) dated 30.06.2011 and Original Sale Deed (Doc. No. 1349) dated 14.07.2011. If anyone who find the above said documents shall handover the same to the Manager of Truhome Finance Limited (earlier known as Shriram Housing Finance Ltd. Now, Mr. Priyansh Aggarwal availing a loan on above said property from Truhome Finance Limited (earlier known as Shriram Housing Finance Ltd) in case anyone has any objection, the same may be raised within 7 days of this publication to Mr. Ajit Sharma (Advocate), Partner of Acculaw Source LLP, Unit No. S-241, 2nd Floor, built on Plot No. 4 and 5, Ansal Utility Commercial Center, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110063 or contact : +91 9890309909 (M).

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that the Certificate (s) for the undermentioned Equity Shares of M/s Chambal Fertilisers & Chemicals Ltd. have been lost/misplaced and the holder(s) Purchase(s) of the said Equity Shares have applied to the company to issue duplicate Share Certificate(s).

Folio No.	Name of Shareholder	No of Shares
E0044804	SANJEEV GOEL	1000
Dist Nos. Fm. To	Cert No Fm. To	
101204425-101205424	522048-522057	
Folio No.	Name of Shareholder	No of Shares
E0044804	SANJEEV GOEL	1400
Dist No. Fm. To	Cert No Fm. To	
101205525-101206924	522059-522072	

Any person who has a claim in respect of the said Shares should lodge the same with the company at its Registered Office within 15 days from this date else the Company will proceed to issue duplicate Certificate (s) to the aforesaid applicants without any further intimation.

Place : New Delhi Dated: 12.03.2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

Subject : Legal Heir Certificate
I, Sharda Devi W/o Late Horam R/o H.No. 408, Ward No. 42, Azad Nagar, Ballabgarh, Faridabad, Property ID No. 18RRNR43 hereby declare that my husband Horam S/o Late Munshiram died on 08.12.2013 & left behind following legal heirs: Sharda Devi (Wife), Rajesh (Daughter), Bhimsen (Son), Sunita (Daughter), Pramod Kumar (Son), Neetu (Daughter), Basant Kumar (Son). If any person, legal heir or institution etc. has any objection regarding transfer of the said property in the name of the above mentioned legal heirs respectively, then he may submit the objection in writing along with the relevant documents to the ZTO/Joint Commissioner/Municipal Corporation Zone Ballabgarh, Faridabad within 30 days from the date of publication of this notice. If no objection is received from anyone within this period, then this property will be transferred in the name of the above mentioned legal heirs.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Mr. Navin Chaudhary has approached ICICI Bank Ltd., Sector-16, Faridabad, Haryana. (Bank) to avail a loan for purchase of Property No. 578, (449.5 sq. mtrs.), Sector-21C, Urban Estate, Faridabad, Haryana from Mr. Victor Gambhir, who has represented that he is the absolute owner of the said property by virtue of Sale Deed dated 31.08.2022 (Document No. 3709) executed by Mrs. Shyama Gera d/o Late Mrs. Vimla Ahuja. If anybody, person, body corporate has any right, lien or claim whatsoever on the said Property by way of inheritance, mortgage, sale or otherwise, then he/she/it may contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 15 days of publication of this notice, otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same have been waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.

Amit Kumar, Advocate
GNA & Associates
D-28, Jangpura Extension,
New Delhi-110014.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF D.O.B.

I, Mohini Pal D/o Sh. Ashok Kumar R/o B-1/149 Nand Nagri Delhi-93 declare that my DOB wrongly written in my School Records 16.06.2004 instead of 15.06.2004 my actual DOB is 15.06.2004.

PD(441)C

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Alimuddin Malik S/O Sageer R/o 882, Deepak vihar, khora Ghaziabad U.P. 201001 that I have changed my name from Alimuddin Malik to Changed my Aleemuddin. That in the future I will be called as Aleemuddin & may above Said statement tome & Correct.

PD(442)C

I, Saira Malik W/o Aleemuddin R/o 882, Deepak vihar, khora Ghaziabad, U.P. 201001 that I have changed my name from Saira Malik to Sayra Bano. That in the future I will be called as Sayra Bano & may above Said Statement true & correct.

PD(443)C

I, Vinod Kumar Bajaj S/o Shri Pooran Chand Bajaj R/o H. No. 40, New No. 32, B.M. Compound, Bazaria Sarki, Ghaziabad (U.P.) hereby declare that I have changed my name from Vinod Bajaj to Vinod Kumar Bajaj for all future purposes.

PD(444)C

I, Mani, Mother of No.16028866N Rfm Ramesh Kumar R/o- Chak Sardarpura, Teh- Nohar, Dist- Hanumanagarh, Rajasthan- 335523, declare that in my Son's service record my name is wrongly recorded as Manni Devi whereas my correct name is Mani, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(445)C

I, Ramjee Mahto, Father of No. 15812182Y Hav Mithilesh Kumar, R/o- Vill- Hemjapur Chand Tola, Post- Shivkunt, Teh/Dist - Munger, Bihar- 811202, have changed my name from Ramjee Mahto to Ramji Mahto, vide affidavit dated 11/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(446)C

I, Pancho Devi, Mother of No. 15812182Y Hav Mithilesh Kumar, R/o- Vill- Hemjapur Chand Tola, Post- Shivkunt, Teh/Dist- Munger, Bihar- 811202, have changed my name from Pancho Devi to Pachiya Devi, vide affidavit dated 11/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(447)C

I, Chinnammadu, Mother of No.15780432Y Hav(OCC) Satyanarayana V, R/o- Vill- Nayuralavalasa, PO- Peddasirlam, MO- Regidi Amadalavalasa, Dist- Vizainagaram, A.P. have changed my name from Chinnammadu to Vavilapalli Chinnammalu, vide affidavit dated 11/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(448)C

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the public at large that Mr. Abhinav Jain has acquired agricultural land measuring 0.6730 hectare, out of Khata No. 70 and Kharsa No. 10, situated at Village Khaspur, District Bagpat, Uttar Pradesh, vide Sale Deed dated 13.09.2024, executed in favour of M/s Abhinav Paper Products Private Limited, duly registered as Document No. 9959 in the office of Sub-Registrar Office (SRO), Bagpat. Mr. Abhinav Jain now intends to create an Equitable Mortgage of the aforesaid property with SIDBI. It is further notified that the original Gift Deed dated 14.10.2013, in favour of Mrs. Neelam Aggarwal and Mrs. Rajni Aggarwal, registered as Document No. 7159, Book No. 01, Volume No. 5131, Pages 157-180, in the office of SRO Bagpat, has been lost/misplaced and could not be traced despite best efforts. In this regard, an FIR dated 09.03.2026 has already been lodged with the concerned Police Station. Any person who finds the above-mentioned original Gift Deed is requested to kindly return the same to the undersigned. Any misuse of the said document shall attract legal action under the provisions of the BNS. Any person having any claim, objection, right, title, or interest in respect of the said property or the aforesaid document is hereby requested to make the same known in writing within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which no claim shall be entertained thereafter.

Mr Abhinav Jain
(Mob.No 989990609)
Through Anil Pathak Adv
Mob. No.9654780108
email: anil12pathak@gmail.com
Office: S-553-54, Gautam Complex, School Block, Shakarpur, Delhi-110092

Taranjit Singh Sandhu takes oath as Delhi Lieutenant Governor

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Veteran diplomat Taranjit Singh Sandhu took the oath as the 23rd Lieutenant Governor of Delhi in a ceremony held at Lok Niwas, marking a new administrative chapter in the national Capital after a major reshuffle of governors and lieutenant governors across the country.

Sandhu replaces Vinai Kumar Saxena, who has been appointed the Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh. The oath of office and secrecy was administered by Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyay, Chief Justice of the Delhi High Court, during a formal ceremony attended by senior political leaders, officials, and a large gathering of guests.

Unlike previous LG swearing-in ceremonies, which usually witness a limited gathering of dignitaries and media personnel, this event saw a much larger crowd. A

significant number of Sandhu's relatives, friends, and well-wishers were present to congratulate him. The ceremony also drew prominent leaders, diplomats, and senior bureaucrats.

Among those present were the Union Finance Minister, Nirmala Sitharaman, Minister of External Affairs, S. Jaishankar, Minister of State for Corporate Affairs, Harsh Malhotra, Chief Minister of Delhi, Rekha Gupta, along with Delhi ministers Parvesh Sahib Singh, Kapil Mishra, Manjinder Singh Sirsa, and Ashish Sood. Delhi BJP president Virendra Sachdeva and Chief Secretary Rajeev Verma were also present at the ceremony.

The Diplomatic Corps was present at the ceremony in large numbers. Those present included the US Ambassador to India, Sergio Gorr, and the High Commissioner of Australia to India, Philip Green.



(Left) Delhi High Court Chief Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyay, newly sworn-in LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Delhi CM Rekha Gupta during the swearing-in ceremony of Mr Sandhu at Lok Niwas in New Delhi; (right) External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar and Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman during the swearing-in ceremony at Lok Niwas in New Delhi

Soon after taking the oath, Sandhu said Delhi faces many challenges but stressed that these challenges should be converted into opportunities. He said the development of the national capital requires collective effort from all stakeholders. "Delhi has many stakeholders. We all must work together for its

development," he said. Sandhu also noted his long personal association with the city, saying Delhi has been his place of education and work in earlier years.

The new Lieutenant Governor stated that the development of the capital is a key national priority and added that he would work



PANKAJ KUMAR

towards achieving that goal. Referring to the rapid growth of the city's population and infrastructure needs, he said challenges will continue to arise, but effective governance can turn them into opportunities for progress.

Born on January 23, 1963, Sandhu is a career diplomat who joined the Indian

Foreign Service in 1988. He studied at The Lawrence School, Sanawar, followed by St Stephen's College in Delhi, and later Jawaharlal Nehru University. Throughout his diplomatic career, he represented India in several key international roles. Sandhu comes from a family with a strong academic and social

background in Punjab. He is the grandson of Teja Singh Samundri, a Sikh reformer who was among the founders of the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta welcomed Sandhu and expressed confidence that Delhi would progress with his cooperation and support. She said coordination between the elected government and the Lieutenant Governor's office will help accelerate development initiatives in the city.

Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta also congratulated Sandhu on assuming office. He said the new LG's vast diplomatic experience and dedication to public service would contribute significantly to governance and development in the capital. The Speaker expressed hope that Sandhu's tenure would be distinguished and productive while serving the people of Delhi.

Following his appointment,

Sandhu also expressed gratitude to Narendra Modi, Prime Minister of India, for giving him the opportunity to serve as Lieutenant Governor. He also thanked Union Home Minister Amit Shah for his guidance and support. Sandhu later met Amit Shah and discussed issues related to governance and public service.

Sandhu's appointment is seen as notable because he is only the second former diplomat to become the Lieutenant Governor of Delhi. Earlier, Romesh Bhandari had served in the role after a diplomatic career in the late 1980s. Observers say the appointment signals a shift in approach by bringing diplomatic experience and global exposure to the administrative leadership of the national capital. Sandhu's experience in international engagement and governance is expected to play a role in shaping Delhi's development and administrative priorities in the coming years.

No fuel shortage in Delhi: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Wednesday said there is no shortage of petrol, diesel, LPG, or piped natural gas in the national capital and urged residents not to believe rumours about fuel scarcity. Officials said supplies of all major fuels remain normal and adequate stocks are available across the city.

The clarification came after reports and rumours circulated about a possible disruption in LPG supplies due to war-like developments in the Middle East. The Delhi government said such claims are unfounded and appealed to the public not to panic or engage in unnecessary hoarding.

A high-level review meeting was held under the chairmanship of the Chief Secretary of Delhi to assess the situation. Senior officials from the Department of Food, Supplies, and Consumer Affairs, Delhi Police, the Revenue Department, Indraprastha Gas Limited, and oil marketing companies attended the meeting.

During the meeting, officials



reviewed the fuel supply situation in detail and confirmed that there is no shortage of gas or petroleum products in the capital. Authorities said the supply chain for petrol, diesel, and LPG continues to function smoothly.

Officials from Indraprastha Gas Limited informed the meeting that the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas had issued an order on March 9 providing guidelines for proper and equitable distribution of domestic piped natural gas and compressed natural gas to priority sectors.

They clarified that the availability of domestic PNG in Delhi remains normal. After revising supply priorities,

nearly 80 per cent of the uninterrupted gas supply has also been restored for industrial sectors. This step has helped maintain stability in supply while ensuring that households continue to receive adequate gas.

Representatives from oil marketing companies also assured the government that there is sufficient stock of petrol, diesel, and domestic LPG cylinders in Delhi. They said distribution networks are operating normally, and fuel supply across the city remains stable.

Officials noted that the booking interval for LPG cylinders has been increased from 21 days to 25 days.

Restaurants staring at losses amid irregular LPG supply

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As irregular LPG supplies hit kitchens across Delhi, many restaurants are staring at losses, with some fearing temporary closure after being left with stock for only a day or two. As irregular LPG supplies grip kitchens across Delhi, many restaurants are left with stock for a day or two, fearing temporary closure and concerns over staff wages.

Industry representatives say many eateries in the capital are trying to manage the situation through adjustments. However, if the disruption continues, smaller establishments may struggle to handle rising costs without affecting staff wages.

With the widening West Asia conflict, the government has prioritised the allocation of domestically produced natural gas for LPG production, compressed natural gas (CNG) and piped cooking gas sectors.

Under the revised allocation, the requirements of these sectors will be fully met before being supplied to



LPG cylinder delivery personnel prepare for distribution outside a gas agency in New Delhi

PTI

other industries, according to a gazette notification.

Manpreet Singh, Honorary Treasurer of the National Restaurant Association of India (NRAI), said that many establishments in Delhi are not receiving regular LPG supplies, with several of them shifting to alternatives like piped natural gas and induction cooking.

He said restaurants are promoting dishes that require less gas or are cooking larger quantities using induction appliances. If the situation continues,

the rising costs will affect staff wages and employment, particularly in the unorganised sector. Restaurants may have to reduce the variety of food they offer and rely more on bulk cooking of certain dishes, Singh said.

Small restaurant owners say they are facing operational stress due to irregular supplies. The owner of Shahdara's Urban Kebab said their LPG stock has run out, and irregular supply is making daily kitchen operations difficult.

JNU faculty and students question transparency, validity of JNUSU referendum on VC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A few students and faculty members of Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) have raised concerns over a recent referendum conducted by the JNUSU, which asked students to vote on whether the university's vice chancellor should be removed following her alleged casteist remarks.

A statement, jointly released by independent students and faculty members on Wednesday, also questioned the referendum's legitimacy. This came a day after the Jawaharlal Nehru University Students' Union (JNUSU) called upon university students to vote in a referendum, after which the students' mandate on whether they want Vice Chancellor Santishree Dhulipudi Pandit to resign would be released.

A faculty member, Christhu Doss from the Centre for



Historical Studies, School of Social Sciences, said, "Who was the independent election commission or election commissioner who monitored this so-called referendum to make it transparent, democratic, legal and acceptable?"

Doss also raised questions regarding whether any agenda was passed for the referendum, the validity of the results, and the university statute or act under which a student referendum could remove a serving vice chancellor.

The recent tensions on campus, which culminated in

the referendum, began early February with the suspension of four JNUSU office-bearers, along with former JNUSU president Nitish Kumar, for two semesters. This was followed by protests, clashes among student groups and alleged casteist remarks made by the VC.

The referendum result, released by JNUSU on Wednesday, showed that a total of 2,409 students cast their votes. Of these, 2,181 voted for the Vice Chancellor's resignation, 207 students voted in favour of

the VC's continuation, and 21 votes were invalid.

Responding to some of the questions raised by Doss, Aditi Mishra, president of JNUSU, said, "It is very sad that the legitimacy of an elected student body has been repeatedly questioned. The referendum conducted by JNUSU is absolutely valid, all due process was followed, and instructions for the referendum were released a day before. "We have the signature of every student who cast their vote for transparency, and the entire process was overseen by elected councilors. The students have a right to come together to express a collective opinion," Mishra said.

Meanwhile, a group of students and faculty members stated that they "reject" the JNUSU's referendum, as it is "not legally sound, is not democratic, and takes attention away from real student issues."

Kapil Mishra reviews development works

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Minister Kapil Mishra chaired a high-level meeting with officials to review development works in North-East Delhi and directed authorities to complete surveys and demarcation for road widening and removal of encroachments at the earliest.

The meeting was held at the Delhi Secretariat and was attended by Deputy Speaker Mohan Singh Bisht, the District Magistrate of North-East Delhi, the Deputy Commissioner of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, revenue officials, and other concerned authorities.

During the meeting, the minister reviewed issues related to road widening, encroachments, land acquisition, and the progress of infrastructure projects in the district. Mishra directed officials to conduct a fresh demarcation of encroachments on Karawal Nagar Road, particularly on the stretch between Dayalpur



Chowk and Shiv Vihar T-junction. He instructed revenue officials to complete the demarcation work within the next two to three days.

He also ordered that the survey required for widening the road to 80 metres should be completed within one month. The survey will identify the properties and khasra numbers that may require minimal land acquisition for the road expansion project.

Officials said the widening of Karawal Nagar Road is aimed at improving traffic flow and strengthening road

infrastructure in the area. Mishra said the North-East Delhi and Yamunapar regions are currently witnessing a major phase of development.

He stressed that all development projects must be accelerated so that residents can benefit from them as soon as possible. He also said that the government has given clear directions that development works must meet strict quality standards.

"The government is committed to ensuring that development projects are completed quickly and without

compromising on quality," he said. The meeting also reviewed an issue related to alleged encroachment on a property located in New Chauhan Pura in Sadar Pur Gujran. The minister directed the Revenue Department to conduct a fresh inspection of the site to determine the actual situation on the ground. If encroachment is confirmed, officials were instructed to immediately inform the Municipal Corporation of Delhi so that appropriate action can be taken.

In another decision, Mishra directed officials to start the process of land acquisition for widening Kali Ghata Road. According to the proposal, the road will be expanded to a width of 60 feet. The Revenue Department was instructed to conduct the necessary site survey at the earliest.

Officials were also asked to ensure that the Municipal Corporation of Delhi submits the required proposal to the ward committee for approval without delay.

Govt to mandate electrification of 30% of entire school bus fleet by 2030

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Under its new EV policy, the Delhi Government may mandate 30 per cent of all school buses shift to electric by the end of March 2030, a government document said.

According to the document, under the new EV policy likely to be tabled during the upcoming budget session of Delhi Assembly, a complete road tax and registration fees exemption is also likely for all electric cars below ₹30 lakh.

The education department of the Delhi government shall ensure implementation of the school bus electri-

fication scheme.

"After two years since notification of the EV policy, 10 pc of the school bus fleet shall be electric; in three years, 20 pc, and by March 31, 2030, 30 pc of the entire fleet shall be electric," the document said.

The direction will apply to the total school bus fleet, whether owned, leased, or hired by schools. Further, the entire fleet of government vehicles will also be electrified as soon as the policy is notified.

The new policy would also mandate that from January 1, 2027, only electric three-wheelers shall be allowed new registration in the city, and only electric two-wheel-



ers shall be permitted new registration from April 1, 2028.

In order to incentivise adoption of electric vehicles (EVs), the new policy would

provide exemption from road tax and registration fees.

"All electric vehicles registered in Delhi shall be granted a 100 per cent

exemption from road tax and registration fees till March 31, 2030," another proposal said. Electric cars with an ex-factory price above 30 lakh will not be eligible for exemption from road tax and registration fees, it added. The move is likely to bring down the vehicle prices.

As per the plan, to manage the battery waste generated by the large numbers of electric vehicles, the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) shall be responsible for setting up battery collection centres across the city.

"DPCC shall, through an appropriate policy framework, facilitate the deploy-

ment of battery collection centres across Delhi under a public-private partnership model, in collaboration with authorised recyclers and other eligible entities, to enable convenient, accessible, and environmentally sound collection of waste batteries," the document added.

Under the new EV policy, DPCC may also notify a set of standard operating procedures for equipment manufacturers to ensure safe collection, storage, transportation, and transfer of waste batteries to authorised recyclers or in compliance with existing waste management rules.

Union minister honours Delhi Metro enthusiast

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister of State for Housing and Urban Affairs Tokhan Sahu on Wednesday honoured a Delhi Metro enthusiast who has travelled on the first train of every corridor since the system began operations in 2002.

Anil Marwah has maintained the tradition for 24 consecutive years, travelling on the first train of each new corridor since the launch of the Delhi Metro on December 24, 2002.

Recalling his first metro ride in 2002, Marwah said

the launch of the metro marked a turning point in urban transport in India by improving connectivity and easing road congestion in the national capital.

He said that before the metro network expanded, commuters often had to wait long hours for buses, while the metro's punctuality and efficiency have helped reduce travel-related stress for millions of passengers.

Appreciating Marwah's dedication, Sahu said such stories reflect the strong connection citizens have developed with the metro system.

IN FOCUS



Adult rose-ringed parakeet attends to a juvenile in Ahmedabad PTI

12 die in suspected milk adulteration in Andhra

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Rajamahendravaram

Twelve people have died in a suspected milk adulteration case in East Godavari district, while eight others are undergoing treatment at various hospitals here.

According to the health department, the cluster was first identified on February 22, when several elderly persons were admitted to hospitals with symptoms including anuria, vomiting, abdominal pain and acute renal dysfunction requiring dialysis.

Those affected were residents of Chowdeswaranagar and Swaroopnagar areas of Lalacheruvu. "Strong epidemiological evidence indi-



cates milk adulteration as the probable cause, and coordinated action has been initiated across departments," a press release said.

Clinical findings showed elevated blood urea and serum creatinine levels, suggesting toxic exposure, it said. Preliminary investigation indicated that milk sup-

plied to 106 families from Varalakshmi Milk Dairy in Narasapuram village of Korukonda mandal could be the source. The supply was immediately stopped.

Emergency medical camps have been set up in affected areas, with round-the-clock deployment of doctors and ambulance services, it added.

Rapid Response Teams comprising district surveillance officer, general medicine specialists, microbiologists, paediatricians, forensic experts, and epidemiologists were constituted immediately.

Meanwhile, the Food Safety Department inspected the dairy unit and collected samples of milk, paneer, ghee, drinking water and

vinegar, along with samples from affected households. These samples have been sent to laboratories -- JNTU Kakinada and VIMTA Labs in Hyderabad -- for microbial, physico-chemical and toxic adulterant analysis.

In addition, blood and urine samples have also been forwarded for advanced toxicological examination, officials said.

The suspected milk vendor, Addala Ganeswararao (33), has been taken into custody, and the dairy unit linked to the supply has been sealed.

CLUES and forensic teams inspected the premises, and post-mortem samples have been sent to the Regional Forensic Laboratory in Vijayawada.

RN Ravi reaches Kolkata, to be sworn Bengal Guv

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Hours after former West Bengal Governor CV Ananda Bose left for New Delhi, his successor RN Ravi arrived on Wednesday evening.

Ravi, who will be sworn in as the 22nd governor of the state, was accompanied by his wife, officials said.

"The swearing-in ceremony of the new governor will take place tomorrow morning. Chief Justice of Calcutta High Court will administer the oath of office," a senior official said. Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, and other senior officials of the state Government are scheduled to be present at the programme, he said. Ravi was appointed Bengal governor following the resignation of Bose on March 5. He had earlier served as the gov-



ernor of Nagaland, Meghalaya, and Tamil Nadu.

Born in Patna in 1952, Ravi joined the Indian Police Service in 1976 after a brief stint as a journalist.

He served in the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and the Intelligence Bureau (IB), and was appointed chairman of the Joint Intelligence Committee in 2014.

In 2018, he became Deputy National Security Advisor. After retiring from his bureaucratic career, Ravi was appointed Nagaland governor in August 2019 and served until September 2021.

Monitor LPG supply, black marketing: Centre

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Wednesday advised all the states and Union territories to monitor LPG supplies daily, take strict action against the violators, quell rumour mongering and maintain law and order in the wake of public apprehensions about restricted supply of LPG cylinders in the domestic market due to the widening crisis in West Asia, officials said.

At a meeting chaired by Home Secretary Govind Mohan on Wednesday, it was conveyed that an LPG control order dated March 8 directed the refineries and petrochemical complexes to maximise LPG production and prioritise domestic supply for household consumers, they said.

At the meeting attended by the secretaries in the ministries of petroleum and natural gas, information and broadcasting, and consumer affairs, along with chief secretaries and DGPs of states and UTs, it was conveyed that restrictions have been imposed on the distribution of LPG cylinders to commercial establishments, including hotels and restaurants, but "not to hospitals or educational institutions".

The home secretary advised the chief secretaries and DGPs to keep an eye on LPG supply in their respective jurisdictions daily and prevent any hoarding or black marketing of cylinders, the officials said.

The states and UTs were also advised to ensure protection of the LPG supply chain by ramping up security arrangements, they said.

They were also told to take strict action against the violators, and maintain law and order on the ground, besides undertaking sufficient aware-



ness drives -- both directly and through the oil marketing companies -- to quell fears of LPG shortage and counter rumour mongering. The Centre is taking active measures to ensure adequate availability of LPG for households, the meeting was told.

The states and UTs have also been advised to closely monitor social media and take prompt action to remove fake news and check the spread of false narratives by circulating old or unrelated material.

The Ministry of Home Affairs has set up a 24x7 control room with nodal officers from the information and broadcasting, and petroleum and natural gas ministries. The control room will enable fact-checking and the issuance of immediate clarifications to states and UTs on any matter on the current situation.

India consumes about 31.3 million tonnes of LPG annually. As much as 87 per cent of this is in the domestic sector, i.e., household kitchens, and the rest in commercial establishments such as hotels and restaurants.

Of this total requirement, 62 per cent is met through imports. The US-Israel attacks on Iran and Tehran's retaliation have shut the Strait of Hormuz, a key sea route through which India gets 85-90 per cent of its LPG imports from West Asian nations, including Saudi Arabia and Qatar.

AI-controlled toys serious threat for safety of children, action being taken: Vaishnaw

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

AI-controlled toys pose a serious threat to children's safety, and immediate actions are being taken in consultation with the consumer affairs and home ministries, Union Electronics and IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said on Wednesday. During the Question Hour in the Lok Sabha, the minister said that the Government has made provisions under the Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023 to ensure children's safety.

"AI-controlled toys are a serious threat to the safety of



Union Ministers Rajnath Singh, Kiren Rijiju, Ashwini Vaishnaw, Pralhad Joshi, Arjun Ram Meghwal, G Kishan Reddy, and others in the Lok Sabha during the second part of Budget session of Parliament in New Delhi

People fed up with DMK's false promises: Palaniswami

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Tiruchirappalli

AIADMK General Secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami said on Wednesday that people of Tamil Nadu are fed up with the ruling DMK's "false and tall promises."

Launching a scathing attack on the DMK Government during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's rally here, Palaniswami said people are not going to believe Chief Minister M K Stalin anymore.

"He hasn't fulfilled his previous poll promises yet." Addressing a massive



NDA poll rally, the Leader of Opposition alleged that the ruling DMK gave over 500 promises during the 2021 assembly elections.

"I ask the chief minister, how many (promises) have actually reached the people? Whether it is the

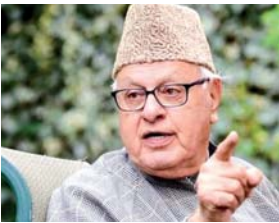
complete waiver of jewel loans or the reduction in fuel prices to the promised extent, this Government has consistently betrayed the trust of the electorate," Palaniswami said.

The former chief minister further claimed that the current administration was merely "rebranding" AIADMK-era schemes while failing to maintain law and order in the state. He highlighted the rising prices of essential commodities and the "deteriorating" fiscal health of Tamil Nadu as evidence of the DMK's "mismanagement."

National Conference President Farooq Abdullah escapes unhurt in firing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

National Conference President and former Chief Minister Dr Farooq Abdullah escaped unhurt in a firing incident during a marriage function in the



Greater Kailash area of Jammu Wednesday night.

The firing incident was reported near Royal Park banquet hall where former CM Farooq Abdullah and Deputy CM Surinder Choudhary were also present to attend a

wedding function. An accused, identified as Kamal Singh Jamwal, was overpowered by security personnel and taken into custody.

Surinder Choudhary sustained minor injuries while Farooq Abdullah escaped

unhurt. Local police authorities cordoned off the entire area and escorted Dr Abdullah from the spot.

Meanwhile, investigations have been launched to ascertain the motive behind the firing incident.

JD(U) is family, pledge to serve people: Nishant



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Patna

JD(U) leader and Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar's son Nishant Kumar on Wednesday described the party as a family and said its members would collectively strive to serve the people.

The engineering graduate, in his late 40s, joined the party on Sunday in the presence of top leaders, including Union Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh 'Lalan' and JD(U) national working president Sanjay Jha. Talking to reporters here, Nishant Kumar said, "I wish to take along the party as a family unit. The legislators and workers associated with JD(U) are all members of one family."

Opposition motion against Birla fails in LS

Birla was not present in the House during the entire period of the debate.

The Opposition objected to Shah's remarks and disrupted the proceedings seeking an apology from him. Leader of Opposition (LoP) Rahul Gandhi said he was stopped from speaking in the Lok Sabha on multiple occasions and asserted that the House does not represent one party but the whole country. Opposition MPs claimed only "no, no, no." is the oft-repeated refrain that they get from Birla when they want to raise important issues in the Lok Sabha. While speaking during a debate in the lower house on the resolution to remove Birla as Speaker, several Opposition MPs claimed that they were not getting the protection that they should from the chair and disruption of their speech by treasury benches had become the norm.

Interjecting in the debate Rahul Gandhi alleged that Prime Minister Narendra Modi "has been compromised" and everybody knows the result of that. Responding to BJP's Ravi Shankar Prasad, who cited parliamentary procedures to say that the LoP should measure his words carefully, especially on issues of national security, Rahul said that his name was being raised during the debate multiple times and "vile things" were being said about him. Participating in the debate on the resolution against Birla, Ravi Shankar Prasad had earlier said that the motion to remove the speaker from his post should not be weaponised to "satisfy" the ego of a leader. He said it was painful that the House is discussing the resolution, which is the result of the ego of a leader. Quoting Practice and Procedures of Parliament, Prasad said the leader of opposition should measure his words carefully, especially on issues of national security, and that he

should eschew partisan politics. This led to an uproar from the Opposition.

SC says NCERT chapter rewrite needs expert...

The bench was hearing a suo motu case concerning NCERT's class 8 social science book, which contained "offending" contents on corruption in the judiciary. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta assured the bench that the chapter would not go into textbook unless the committee of domain experts examines not only this chapter but everything.

He said the chapter was drafted by textbook development team under the chairmanship of professor Michel Danino and consisting members Suparna Diwakar and Alok Prasanna Kumar. "I state and submit that the above referred individuals shall not be associated with any activity of NCERT hereafter," the NCERT affidavit said.

PM attacks Opposition at south India rallies

"Be it saving the nurses stranded in Iraq or freeing Father Tom from the clutches of terrorists in Yemen, India now does not abandon its citizens in their time of crisis. Father Alexis Premkumar was safely rescued and brought back from Afghanistan. Even today our aim is to ensure that Indians stranded in West Asia amidst the war are safe and receive all possible facilities," the PM said in Ernakulam, where he also conducted a roadshow.

Modi said the crisis in West Asia had once again highlighted the importance of becoming Atmanirbhar. "To reduce dependence on petrol and diesel, electric vehicles are being promoted. Hundred percent electrification of railways is also being carried out," he said.

FROM PAGE - 1

He alleged that during their rule the Congress and the Left parties made the country more dependent on foreign nations and were now spreading rumours about the war in the Gulf region. During his Kerala visit, the PM also inaugurated several projects, including trains.

Earlier in the day at a rally in Tamil Nadu, Modi urged people not to panic over LPG supply disruption and asked them to rely only on verified information. At a rally in Tiruchirappalli, he criticised the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam, saying people wanted a Government that worked for every family, "not just for one family." He alleged the party was known for a "scientific corruption model."

Modi also inaugurated, dedicated and laid the foundation stone for development projects worth about Rs 5,650 crore across Tamil Nadu, saying they would create thousands of jobs for the state's youth.

Ships attacked near Strait of Hormuz as...

The Strait of Hormuz, located between Iran and Oman, is one of the most strategically significant maritime chokepoints in the world. Nearly 20 percent of the global oil supply passes through this narrow waterway each day, making any disruption a serious concern for international energy markets and trade.

Earlier this month, the IIRC announced that passage through the Strait of Hormuz would be closed to vessels linked to the United States, Israel, European nations, and their Western allies. However, on March 10 the group indicated that certain countries might still be granted transit rights under specific conditions. Iranian authorities said that safe passage through the waterway

would be allowed only to those Arab or European countries that expel Israeli and American ambassadors from their territories. The move has added a new diplomatic dimension to the maritime crisis and raised concerns among international shipping companies and Governments reliant on the route. Security agencies have advised ships transiting the region to exercise heightened caution while passing through the Strait of Hormuz and nearby waters.

Union Bank tops with ₹9.96 lakh crore stuck...

The list also includes Sai Renewable Power Limited (₹3,139 crore); MBS Jewellers (₹1,005 crore); and Delhi-based PC Jeweller (₹6,773 crore). Anil Ambani and his companies received eight loans totaling ₹8,675 crore, including loans to Reliance Communications, Reliance Naval and Engineering Limited and Reliance Telecom. Supertech Limited received 11 loans totaling ₹3,234 crore, while debt-ridden Punj Lloyd took seven loans totaling ₹947 crore before being taken over by Adani Group through the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code process.

Other defaulters include Jay Polychem (India) Limited (₹ 5,148 crore), Alok Industries (₹ 1,247 crore, besides ₹ 6,299 crore owed to SBI), Bhatia Global Trading Ltd (₹3,054 crore), Sadbhav Engineering Limited (₹ 940 crore), Biotar Industries Ltd (₹1,070 crore loans), Gayatri Projects (Rs. 1,024 crore), and Yojaka India Private Limited (₹1,493 crore).

Additional dues include Ramakrishnan Spintex Private Limited (₹ 1,193 crore), SEL Textiles (₹ 1,557 crore), Diamond Hut India Private Limited (₹ 1,453 crore), IVRCL Ltd (₹ 900 crore), Harish Chandra (India) Limited (₹ 1,275 crore), Shakti Bhog Food Limited (₹ 1,040 crore), and Nafto Gaz Indo Private Limited (₹ 1,479 crore). Most of these companies

are now in insolvency, and the pledged shares have little or no value. Banks may only recover money later by claiming on ED-attached land assets after chargesheets are filed and courts allow such claims.

LPG shortage hits hotels, temples weddings

The Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation advised catering units at railway stations in its western zone to shift to microwaves and induction plates and maintain ready-to-eat stocks for passengers, warning, "You must switch over to alternate cooking modes to offset any potential LPG shortage."

In cities like Bengaluru, hotels and restaurants are operating under strain due to an acute shortage of commercial LPG cylinders. Rajasthan businesses-including hotels, factories, wedding caterers, and tourism establishments-are facing operational difficulties as domestic and commercial users rush to gas agencies. No fresh bookings of commercial cylinders are being accepted, further hitting industries.

Restaurant owners warn that kitchen operations are already affected and wedding expenses are likely to rise. Some eateries are considering coal furnaces, diesel burners, or induction cooktops as alternatives. Long queues at LPG agency offices and auto-dispensation centers were seen in Kolkata and other West Bengal towns on Wednesday. The National Restaurant Association of India's Kolkata chapter head, Piyush Kankaria, said supply to eateries has "completely stopped," with some roadside vendors buying cylinders at nearly double the retail price. Petroleum dealers confirmed petrol and diesel supplies remain normal across the state.

Euthanasia to restore his dignity: Family of comatose man in SC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

The family of the 32-year-old Ghaziabad man who has been comatose for more than 12 years, in their plea to the Supreme Court, had said that allowing withdrawal of artificial life support will restore his dignity after years of irreversible suffering.

The top court allowed passive euthanasia for Harish Rana, who has been in a permanent vegetative state since 2013 after suffering severe head injuries from a fall from the fourth floor of his paying guest accommodation on August 20 that year.

Shortly after the Supreme Court pronounced its judgment, a crowd — consisting mainly of journalists and television cameramen — gathered outside the Brahm Raj Empire society in Ghaziabad, where the family currently resides.

Security personnel at the residential complex tightened access and prevented outsiders from entering the premises.

Rashmi Nandakumar, the lawyer who represented the family in the Supreme Court, told media over the phone that the family members were not in a position to comment on the development before the media.

When media attempted to contact Ashok Rana, father of Harish Rana, the call was picked up, but there was no response from the other side. Even as the family was



reluctant to open up on this emotive issue, local residents confirmed how the family had gone out of their way to get their son treated.

Ashok Rana and his wife, Nirmala Rana, had sold their house in Delhi to meet the medical expenses of their son, some locals told the media. They added that Ashok Rana, who earlier worked in the catering department of a large hospitality chain, now receives a pension of about ₹3,600 a month.

Claiming anonymity, another resident said that Ashok Rana sells sandwiches at the nearby cricket grounds in the mornings to make ends meet. The resident also urged the media to give the family some privacy and personal time after the court's judgment.

In written submissions before the court, the family said Harish Rana has remained in an "irreversible and incurable permanent vegetative state" with 100 per cent disability for more than 12 years and survives

only with clinically assisted nutrition and hydration administered through a percutaneous endoscopic gastrostomy tube.

They said the artificial feeding system merely sustains his biological survival and has no therapeutic benefit or possibility of reversing the severe brain injury. The family argued that continuing such treatment would only prolong life artificially without any prospect of recovery.

Referring to the constitutional principle of the Right to Live with Dignity under Article 21, the submissions said the law permits withdrawal of life-sustaining treatment in cases where a patient is in an incurable and irreversible condition, and medical intervention only prolongs suffering.

The family pleaded that passive euthanasia and the withdrawal of life-support systems are legally permissible when medical experts certify that the patient has no chance of recovery. According

to the submissions, two medical boards constituted at the direction of the Supreme Court found Rana's condition to be irreversible and confirmed that he has remained in a permanent vegetative state for more than a decade.

The secondary medical board also noted that the feeding tube being used in his case only provides sustenance for survival and cannot restore his cognitive function or reverse the underlying brain damage.

The family told the court that their request was not motivated by a desire to cause death but by the belief that it was not in Rana's best interests to continue living in such a condition.

They said the decision sought from the court was whether it was appropriate to prolong life artificially through continued medical intervention rather than whether death itself was desirable.

The submissions also pointed out that Rana had been cared for at home by his parents for several years, which had delayed the formal medical board process envisaged under the Supreme Court's guidelines for withdrawal of life support.

The Supreme Court on Wednesday allowed passive euthanasia and directed the All India Institute of Medical Sciences to admit Rana for palliative care and prepare a tailored plan for withdrawal of treatment while ensuring dignity in the process.

Oppn making false allegations against Speaker, says Anurag



BJP MP Anurag Thakur speaking in the Lok Sabha during the second part of the Budget session of Parliament in New Delhi on Wednesday

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

BJP MP from Hamirpur Anurag Thakur on Wednesday accused the Opposition of making false allegations and described Om Birla as an impartial speaker who gave all the members chance to speak in the House.

Participating in a debate in Lok Sabha on the resolution to remove Birla from the Speaker's post, the former Union minister alleged that Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi was in fact a "Leader of Propaganda" who was tarnishing the image of institutions just to stay in the headlines.

He accused the Opposition of creating a false narrative by stating that Birla targeted their leaders by expunging their remarks. Remarks of several ruling party MPs, including those of his own, have been expunged on multiple occasions, Thakur said, "but we have never objected to the wisdom applied by the Chair".

Alleging that Gandhi has "FOMO" (fear of missing out)

of being in the news, Thakur said he speaks more outside the House than inside.

"Rahul Gandhi thinks the rules are not for him, but he is the rule... One family thinks that it is above the rules and procedures of the House and above the Constitution," Thakur alleged.

Taking a dig at the Opposition leader, he said "some people come to the House without any common sense, civic sense or constitutional sense" and that their only aim was to create "trouble". Likening Birla to a school principal who wants to enforce discipline, Thakur said the Opposition was free to quit the school if they did not like the principal.

Om Birla, he stressed, will remain the Speaker of Lok Sabha.

The Hamirpur MP added that Birla has been impartial, gave more opportunities for Opposition MPs to speak in the House, and always encouraged first-time members to raise issues of urgent matters concerning their constituencies.

Nation Focus



NEW HIGHWAY PROJECT TO SLASH DELHI-CHENNAI TRAVEL

The Government has decided to construct a new Green Express highway between Surat and Kurnool, which will reduce the distance between Delhi and Chennai by 320 kms, Transport Minister Nitin Gadkari informed the Rajya Sabha on Wednesday. Replying to supplementary queries during the Question Hour, the minister said the travel time between Delhi and Mumbai will also be reduced to within 12 hours after this highway is constructed. He was responding to questions relating to the development of road infrastructure in Kolhapur, where there is a lot of traffic and congestion.



OVER 1 LAKH PENSION-RELATED GRIEVANCES RECEIVED IN 2025

More than one lakh pension-related grievances were received online through the CPENGRAMS platform last year, the Lok Sabha was informed on Wednesday. Centralised Pension Grievances Redress And Monitoring System (CPENGRAMS) is an online portal for the registration, tracking and redressal of pensioners' grievances. "On this portal, the total number of pension grievances received during the years 2023, 2024 and 2025 are 78,675, 1,12,215 and 1,07,731, respectively," Union Minister of State for Personnel Jitendra Singh said in a written reply.

₹5.63 CRORE PENALTY IMPOSED ON PERIODICALS: GOVT IN LS

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Penalties amounting to over ₹5.63 crore have been imposed on periodicals through the Press Sewa Portal and 88,315 publications across the country have been cancelled, the Lok Sabha was informed on Wednesday.

In a written reply, Minister of State for Information and Broadcasting L Murugan said all applications for registration of periodicals are now processed digitally through the Press Sewa Portal under the Press and Registration of Periodicals (PRP) Act, 2023.

He said over 1.5 lakh physical records of newspaper registrations created under the Press and Registration of Books (PRB) Act, 1867, which has now been repealed, have been digitised and integrated with the portal.

Murugan said services such as registration of new periodicals, revision of registration of existing periodicals, ownership transfer, filing of annual statements, payment of penalties and circulation verification are being processed through the portal.

"As part of the implementation of the Act, specified authorities of 780 districts have been onboarded on the Press Sewa Portal," he said.

Opposition collects signatures to seek removal of CEC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Signatures have been collected for a notice seeking a motion for the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, sources said on Wednesday, adding that the MPs plan to submit the notice in both Houses of Parliament.

A senior MP familiar with the developments said they have finished collecting signatures, and the notice will be submitted either on Thursday or Friday. The MP also said the notice will be submitted to both Houses.

Around 120 MPs have so far signed the notice to be submitted to the Lok Sabha, and around 60 MPs have signed the notice to be submitted in the Upper House, the source said.

According to rules, at least 100 MPs must sign a notice seeking the removal of the CEC in the Lok Sabha, and the required strength in the Rajya Sabha is 50. The notice has been signed by members from all INDIA bloc parties, the source added. This is the first time a notice has been given seeking the removal of the CEC.

Opposition parties have accused the CEC of aiding the ruling BJP on several occasions, especially over the ongoing Special



Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar

Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, which they have alleged is aimed at helping the ruling party at the Centre. Concerns have especially been expressed over the conduct of the exercise in West Bengal, with Trinamool Congress (TMC) supremo and Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee accusing the poll panel of deleting genuine voters.

The process for removing the CEC is similar to that for the removal of a Supreme Court or high court judge, and only grounds of proven misbehaviour or incapacity can lead to impeachment.

A motion for removal may be introduced in either House of Parliament and must be passed by a special majority — a majority of the total membership of the House and a two-thirds majority of the members present and voting.

House doesn't represent one party but whole country: Rahul

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday said he was stopped from speaking in the Lok Sabha on multiple occasions and asserted that the House does not represent one party but the whole country.

Interjecting in a debate in Lok Sabha on the resolution to remove Om Birla as speaker, Gandhi alleged that Prime Minister Narendra Modi "has been compromised" and everybody knows the result of that.

Responding to BJP's Ravi Shankar Prasad, who cited parliamentary procedures to say that the leader of opposition should measure his

words carefully, especially on issues of national security, Gandhi said that his name was being raised during the debate multiple times and "vile things" were being said about him. "The discussion here is about the democratic process and the role of the speaker. But multiple times, my name is being raised, vile things are being said about me. This House is the expression of people's will. This House does not represent one party; it represents the whole country," the former Congress president said.

"Every time we get up to speak, we are stopped. The last time I spoke, I raised fundamental questions about the compromises made by our prime minister. Multiple



Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi speaking in the Lok Sabha during second part of the Budget session of Parliament in New Delhi

times, I have been stopped from speaking. Just a few days ago, for the first time in India's history, the leader of opposition was not allowed

to speak during a debate," Gandhi said.

The Congress leader said that the last time he spoke in Parliament, he raised the

issue of "the prime minister being compromised".

"I raised the issue of Mr (MM) Naravane, I raised the issue of Epstein, I raised the issue of Adani, and I was silenced. These issues are fundamental to the people of India," he said. "Our prime minister has been compromised; everybody knows the result of that," Gandhi said.

Participating in the debate on the resolution against Birla, Ravi Shankar Prasad had earlier said that the motion to remove the speaker from his post should not be weaponised to "satisfy" the ego of a leader.

He said it was painful that the House is discussing the resolution, which is the result of the ego of a leader.

82% of rural homes now have tap water, says President

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu on Wednesday said that 82 per cent of rural households now have tap water connections, against 17 per cent in 2019 when the Jal Jeevan Mission was launched.

Addressing the Jal Mahotsav programme, the President said water is not merely a basic facility in India but is deeply connected to the country's culture, traditions, livelihoods and community life.

"It is a matter of great satisfaction that currently about 82 per cent of rural house-



President Droupadi Murmu during the Jal Mahotsav programme

holds have access to tap water, whereas in 2019, when the Jal Jeevan Mission was

launched, this figure was only 17 per cent.

For this extraordinary

success, I congratulate Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil and his entire team," she said. "Water is the basis of life. In our traditions, water has been revered as a remedy for many ailments.

In our national song Vande Mataram — whose 150th anniversary of composition we are commemorating — the very first word is 'Sujalam', which means 'abundant in good water resources'.

Thus, in India, water has never been merely a basic facility; it is deeply connected with our culture, traditions, livelihoods and community life," she added.

Pointing out that earlier rural households had to struggle for access to drinking water, and that women and children often had to travel long distances to fetch it, the President said that today, clean and safe water reaches homes, reflecting the success of the Jal Jeevan Mission.

The President also emphasised the role of technology in improving water governance, noting that platforms such as the Sujalam Bharat App, real-time dashboards and decision support systems are ensuring transparent monitoring and effective planning.

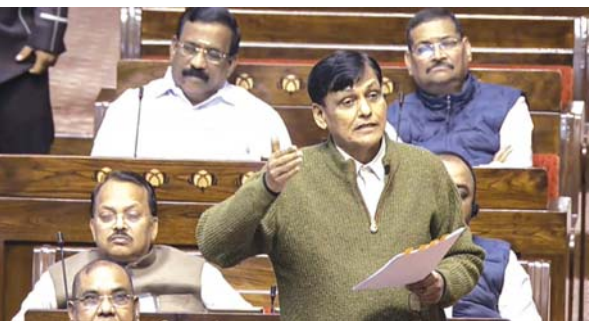
Census 2027 to include transgender-headed households

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The upcoming Census will collect data on the sex of the head of household — Male, Female and Transgender, the Rajya Sabha was informed on Wednesday.

Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai, in a written response, said Census 2027 will be conducted in two phases. The questions for the first phase, which covers Houselisting and Housing Census, have been notified.

"Information on housing conditions, Household particulars including name and sex of the head of the household, amenities available and assets possessed by the household will be collected in this phase. Three categories of sex of the head of household, viz



Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai

Male/Female/Transgender will be collected," Rai said.

Questions for the second phase, which is Population Enumeration, where information of each individual will be collected, will be notified in due course, he added.

The minister said enumerators shall undertake house-to-house field visits in the entire enumeration area for

the collection of Census data to avoid any exclusion on any ground.

"Provision of self-enumeration is an additional facility for the respondents to submit data. Enumerators will confirm self-enumeration data before final submission. Further, FAQs, necessary 'Tool Tips' and validation checks for questions are pro-

vided in the self-enumeration Portal itself to ensure accuracy of data," he said.

The minister said all suitable measures have been taken for data security while collecting data on mobile, during data transmission and at the server level.

"Adequate training is being provided to all field functionaries appointed for Census work, including enumerators and supervisors. Validation rules are incorporated in the mobile app itself to ensure data consistency and accuracy. Further, Data collected by enumerators will also be monitored and checked by supervisors," he said.

The Union Cabinet has approved ₹11,718 crore for conducting the Census of India, 2027, which would include the caste enumeration for the first time.

93,000 vacancies in CAPFs, Assam Rifles: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 93,000 posts remain vacant in the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) and the Assam Rifles, the Government informed the Rajya Sabha on Wednesday.

In a written reply to a question, Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai presented vacancies data in the paramilitary forces, showing that the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) has the highest number of vacancies at 27,400, followed by the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) with 28,342 vacant posts.

The Border Security Force (BSF) has 14,531 vacancies, the Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) has 12,333, and the Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB) has 6,784 vacant positions.



The Assam Rifles has 3,749 vacancies, taking the total to 93,139 posts. Responding to concerns about whether the vacancies have affected law enforcement, internal security and disaster response capabilities, Rai said the forces are continuing to perform their responsibilities effectively.

"Forces are discharging all duties in a highly professional manner through optimal

utilisation of available resources," he said.

The minister added that filling vacancies in CAPFs and Assam Rifles is a continuous process, with recruitment being carried out through agencies such as the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) and the Staff Selection Commission (SSC).

He said several measures have been taken to expedite recruitment, including annual

recruitment for Constable (General Duty) posts through the SSC, nomination of a nodal force to coordinate recruitment for key ranks, and the use of radio frequency identification (RFID) technology during physical tests to streamline the selection process. The Government has also reduced the time taken for medical examinations and lowered cut-off marks for shortlisting candidates in categories facing shortfalls to ensure adequate recruitment, Rai said.

Regular meetings of departmental promotion committees are also being conducted to fill promotional vacancies and accelerate the manpower augmentation process, he added.

In response to another question, Minister Rai laid out the resignation data for the CAPFs.

States Focus



RSS' TOP DECISION-MAKING BODY TO MEET IN HARYANA

The expansion of Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh's work over the last year and plans for the future will be discussed at a key three-day meet of its top decision-making body in Haryana's Samalkha from March 13, a senior RSS functionary said on Wednesday. RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat, along with other top Sangh leaders, BJP chief Nitin Nabin and presidents and other senior functionaries of its 32 sister organisations, among others, will attend the Akhil Bharatiya Pratinidhi Sabha (ABPS). Addressing a press conference in Samalkha, Panipat, Sunil Ambekar, RSS's Akhil Bharatiya Prachar Pramukh, said the meeting will review the activities of the Sangh during 2025-26 and present reports on significant initiatives carried out across various regions.



FORMER UNION MINISTER SAMBASIVA RAO DIES AT 82

Former Union minister K Sambasiva Rao died at a private hospital here on Wednesday. He was 82. Rao was admitted to the hospital on March 6 with drowsiness followed by unresponsiveness. The hospital, in a statement, said following initial evaluation and neuroimaging, he underwent emergency neurosurgical intervention. "Despite maximal medical and surgical treatment, the patient's condition remained extremely critical. During the course of treatment, he developed sudden cardiac arrest, and immediate resuscitative measures were initiated by the medical team. Unfortunately, despite all possible efforts, K Sambasiva Rao could not be revived and was declared dead at 11.10 am on March 11," it said. Rao was a Congress veteran, but joined the BJP later. Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu and Union Minister for Coal and Mines G Kishan Reddy were among those who expressed their condolences over the demise of Rao. Born in Dosapadu in the Krishna district of Andhra Pradesh, Rao got his engineering degree from the Regional Engineering College in Warangal. He was first elected as an MP in 1984 and was re-elected in 1989, 1998, 2004 and 2009 on behalf of Congress. He was serving as Union Minister of textiles for some time during the second UPA Government led by Manmohan Singh.

108 Naxalites with ₹3.95 cr bounty surrender in Chhattisgarh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jagdalpur (Chhattisgarh)

In the fight against Left Wing Extremism, 108 Maoists carrying a collective reward of ₹3.95 crore surrendered in Chhattisgarh's Bastar district on Wednesday, officials said. Besides a huge stock of weapons, ₹3.61 crore in cash and one kg of gold valued at about ₹1.64 crore were recovered from Maoist dumps, the highest seizure of cash and valuables from a single location in the history of anti-Naxal operations in the country, Inspector General of Police, Bastar Range, Sundarraaj Pattilingam said. Union Home Minister Amit Shah has set a deadline of March 31, 2026, for the eradication of Naxalism from the country. Among the surrendered Naxalites, six were divisional committee members carrying a reward of '8 lakh each, as per officials. The cadres, belonging to the Dandakaranya



Special Zonal Committee (DKSZC) of Maoists, turned themselves in at Jagdalpur, the Bastar district headquarters, Pattilingam said. DKSZC formation of outlawed CPI (Maoists) orchestrated several deadly attacks in south Bastar in the past. Information provided by the surrendered cadres helped security forces achieve significant successes, including the recovery of weapons, cash and other materials from Maoist dumps, the official said. A total of 101 weapons were seized, including AK-47, INSAS and SLR rifles,

light machine guns, 303 rifles and barrel grenade launchers, dealing a significant blow to the already weakened military capability of the Maoist organisation, Pattilingam said. Among those who surrendered were several key cadres, including divisional committee members Rahul Telam, Pandru Kovasi and Jhitrु Oyam from the West Bastar division, Ramdhar alias Biru from the East Bastar division and Mallesh from the North Bastar division. Others included Muchaki, commander of the People's Liberation Guerrilla Army (PLGA) battalion, and Kosa Mandavi, a divisional committee member from the Andhra-Odisha Border area of Maoists, the official said. The large-scale surrender indicated that Maoist ideology was weakening and even members within the organisation were questioning its relevance, Pattilingam said. He said many cadres were influenced by the "Poona Margem — Rehabilitation to

Yoga leading the way in preventive healthcare



Over the past decade, Yoga has evolved from being widely appreciated as a traditional wellness practice to being increasingly recognised as an evidence-based approach to health and well-being. Scientific research, digital innovation, and global collaboration are now helping us understand Yoga not only as India's cultural heritage but also as a powerful public health intervention. The Morarji Desai National Institute of Yoga (MDNIY) has been designated as a WHO Collaborating Centre for Traditional Medicine (Yoga) and re-designated for the period 2025-2029, further reinforcing India's leadership in Yoga research. This recognition reflects the Institute's growing role in promoting evidence-based Yoga interventions for Non-Communicable Diseases (NCDs). Key partners in this endeavour include the Ministry of Ayush, AIIMS Delhi, Lady Hardinge Medical College, Central Council for Research in Unani Medicine, and Institute of Nuclear Medicine & Allied Sciences, Delhi. Through these collaborations, the Centre is developing technical guidelines and advancing research on Yoga-based interventions for non-communicable diseases such as diabetes, obesity, and stress-related disorders. International organisations are also partnering in these efforts, further strengthening the scientific foundations of Yoga



and demonstrating its potential as a scalable, cost-effective, and evidence-backed tool for preventive healthcare. At the institutional level, MDNIY continues to strengthen the scientific foundations of Yoga. Through research laboratories in physiology, biochemistry, biomechanics, and psychology, the Institute examines the psycho-physiological and biochemical effects of Yoga, its role in ageing, and its impact on lifestyle-related disorders. This work reflects India's commitment to integrating traditional knowledge with modern scientific validation. Digital platforms have further expanded Yoga's reach, bringing evidence-based practices directly into people's daily lives. Initiatives such as the m-Yoga mobile application and the Y-Break protocol demonstrate how Yoga can be delivered at

scale while maintaining its authenticity and therapeutic value. The m-Yoga platform, developed in collaboration with the World Health Organisation, has recorded over 1.1 lakh downloads, reflecting a growing interest in accessible digital wellness tools while the Workplace Yoga program Y-Break -a simple 5-10 minute Yoga Break during work hours has already benefited over 33 lakh Government officials. Research findings and engagement analytics from these initiatives are highly encouraging. Regular Y Break practices have been shown to reduce perceived stress by up to 40 percent within a few weeks. Studies also indicate improvements in mental alertness, emotional resilience, and decision-making, along with positive changes in physiological indicators such as cortisol levels.

Physical benefits include reduced neck, shoulder, and lower back discomfort, improved respiratory efficiency through breathing practices, and enhanced overall vitality-outcomes that are especially relevant in today's sedentary, screen-driven workplaces. Y-Break has also contributed to lower absenteeism, improved employee morale, and healthier work-life balance, underlining Yoga's potential to strengthen both individual and organisational well-being. The importance of scientific validation was also emphasised during the National Conference on Naturopathy-2026, jointly organised by MDNIY and the Central Council for Research in Yoga & Naturopathy. Experts highlighted that rigorous research, interdisciplinary collaboration, and robust

digital engagement are essential to integrating Yoga into modern healthcare systems and ensuring measurable health outcomes. These developments reflect a significant shift in the global perception of Yoga. It is no longer viewed merely as a personal wellness practice but increasingly as a pathway for public health, skill development, and wellness-based employment opportunities. By combining tradition with science and technology, Yoga is emerging as a driving force behind the Global Yoga Kranti and strengthening India's leadership in the international wellness sector. As we approach 13 March, which marks the 100-day countdown to the upcoming International Day of Yoga on 21 June, it provides an opportunity to reflect on how Yoga continues to evolve from an ancient practice to a globally recognised, evidence-based pathway to health and well-being. Let these hundred days serve as a gentle reminder to begin or renew daily Yoga practice and inspire our families, friends, and communities to embrace Yoga as a way of life. By integrating Yoga into daily living, we not only strengthen individual health but also foster collective well-being, organisational efficiency, and societal harmony. Today, through research, technology, and international collaboration, India is taking the next decisive step-transforming the timeless wisdom of Yoga into a scientifically validated and universally accessible pathway for global health, balance, and well-being.

Author is a Minister of AYUSH

₹590-crore IDFC bank scam: ED searches 19 locations in Haryana

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate conducted searches at 19 locations on Wednesday in connection with alleged embezzlement of ₹590 crore from the Haryana Government's accounts maintained with IDFC First Bank in Chandigarh, sources said. The agency conducted searches in Haryana and Chandigarh against various business entities that helped the accused persons get accommodation entries to conceal the money trail and proceeds of crime, they said. The funds were supposed to be deposited by various Government departments of the State in the bank, but instead of being deposited in the FDs, these were allegedly diverted by the various accused persons for their personal purposes, the



sources said. In its investigation, the ED conducted searches on various business entities that have given accommodation entries to the main accused persons, ex-bank officials, certain beneficiaries of the alleged scam and real estate agents where the proceeds of crime have been dissipated, they said.

‘Ensure disposal of complaints registered by Kashmiri Pandits’

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Secretary Atal Dulloo has directed deputy commissioners to ensure proper and timely disposal of complaints registered by Kashmiri Pandits on the dedicated portal regarding their immovable properties and assets left behind in the valley. He also directed departments to ensure there is no delay in granting promotions to Kashmiri Pandit employees appointed under the prime minister's relief package, stressing that eligible employees must receive their benefits. Dulloo was speaking at a high-level review meeting convened here to assess the progress achieved in the implementation of key welfare measures for the rehabilitation and resettlement of migrant populations of Jammu and Kashmir on Tuesday, an official spokesman said. During the meeting, the chief secretary took a comprehensive review of the range of measures undertaken by the Government from time to time for the rehabilitation of different migrant categories, including Kashmiri Pandits, West Pakistani Refugees and displaced persons who migrated from Pakistan-occupied Kashmir. The spokesman said a detailed assessment was made regarding the implementation of the Prime Minister's Development Package (PMDP 2015) and the steps being taken to improve the delivery of services to Kashmiri migrants, Jammu migrants and other displaced persons residing in the Union Territory. The chief secretary reviewed the status of the construction of transit accommodation being developed across various districts of Kashmir for migrant employees recruited under the relief package. Principal Secretary, Department of Disaster Management, Relief, Rehabilitation and Reconstruction, Chandraker Bharti said out of a total of 6,000 flats planned under the project, 4,128 flats have already been completed, while the remaining 1,872 flats have been phased for completion in stages with 584 flats to be completed by the end of March, 832 by June and 456 by September this year.He apprised that the two-storey commu-



J&K Chief Secretary Atal Dulloo

nity hall at Jagti is nearing completion with approximately 90 per cent of the work already executed. Regarding the PoJK Bhawan project, he said the complex comprising an administrative block, amphitheatre and Balidan Stambhis is expected to be completed by January next year. The meeting was also informed that land has been identified at Purkhoo in Jammu for the construction of additional flats for migrant families. Taking a location-wise appraisal from the executing agencies, he directed them to ensure completion of these projects within the stipulated timelines and with all required facilities in place. Dulloo also reviewed the status of Departmental Promotion Committees (DPCs) in respect of employees appointed under the relief package.He observed that necessary clarifications and directions have already been issued to address procedural bottlenecks faced by departments and stressed that there should be no further delay in granting employees their rightful benefits as per the rules in force. Emphasising the importance of responsive grievance redressal, the chief secretary directed the deputy commissioners to ensure quality disposal of complaints registered by migrants on the dedicated portal regarding their immovable properties and assets left behind in the valley. He instructed the relief commissioner to deploy officers to districts to monitor the grievance disposal process, stressing that affected individuals should be taken into confidence while resolving such issues on merit.

India moving to proactive deterrence: Army Chief

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Citing key lessons from Operation Sindoor, Army Chief General Upendra Dwivedi has said India is shifting from a reactive approach to a proactive deterrence posture. Addressing the participants of the 21st Higher Defence Management Course at the College of Defence Management (CDM) on Tuesday, also said the Indian Army stands at the cusp of a new era defined by technological prowess, organisational agility and self-reliance. "Highlighting key lessons from Operation Sindoor, the Chief of the Army Staff underscored India's shift from a reactive to a proactive deterrence posture," a defence release said here on Wednesday. General Dwivedi



Army Chief General Upendra Dwivedi

stressed the need to effectively harness multi-domain operations, data-centric warfare and unmanned systems in future conflicts, it said. He underlined the importance of developing "battlefield equalisers" (technologies, etc., that negate a superior force's advantage) alongside traditional battlefield winners, saying adaptation and innovation are critical to sustaining operational advantage. He also emphasised

that 'Change Management' is a strategic necessity and not an option. He urged officers to develop and apply five dimensions of thinking — creative, critical, systems, cognitive and imaginative - to enhance institutional adaptability and foster innovative problem-solving, it said. The Army Chief noted that all "five generations of warfare" (evolution of combat from traditional warfare to modern conflict) must be fought in unison through an integrated, multi-domain approach. He also highlighted the need for a holistic understanding of 'grey-zone warfare' (not a full scale war)- from the level of the Commanding Officer to the Chief of Army Staff — to effectively counter evolving threats.

Himachal Governor stresses good relations between HP, J&K

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Himachal Pradesh Governor Kavinder Gupta on Wednesday stressed the need to maintain good relations between Jammu and Kashmir and Himachal Pradesh. He also thanked the country's leadership for entrusting him with the responsibility and said he would work for the overall development of the state while ensuring that all sections of society are taken along. On his maiden visit to Jammu after he was sworn in as the Governor of Himachal Pradesh in a ceremony held at Raj Bhavan in Shimla, Gupta received a red carpet welcome in his home state. Interacting with the media persons in Jammu, Himachal Pradesh Governor expressed gratitude to President Droupadi Murmu and PM Narendra Modi for allowing him to serve. "I thank the President and the Prime Minister for giving me this



Himachal Pradesh Governor Kavinder Gupta talking to media upon his arrival in Jammu PTI

opportunity. After seven months, I have been given a chance to work in a large state. Their wishes and expectations would be that everyone in society is taken along and that work is done for the betterment of Himachal," Gupta said. Responding to a question about reports of people from Jammu and

Kashmir allegedly facing harassment in Himachal Pradesh, the governor said, "Absolutely. I have not had much time yet, but good relations should exist between Jammu and Kashmir and Himachal." He said Jammu and Kashmir and Himachal Pradesh share deep cultural and historical links and that

mutual respect and goodwill should be preserved. "Our language, culture and civilisation are similar. During the rule of the Dogra rulers, Himachal was also part of their state. Even today, songs here mention places like Chamba and Kangra. That mutual love and affection should be maintained," Gupta said. Gupta earlier on Thursday resigned from the post of Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh after serving the Union Territory for over eight months. The 66-year-old Gupta was appointed as the LG of the Union Territory on July 18, 2025. He was the third LG since it was carved out of the erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir in August 2019. A senior BJP leader from Jammu, Gupta has previously served as deputy chief minister of the erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir and as Speaker of the Legislative Assembly. He has also been the Mayor of Jammu.



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Order Order

HC summons DM, SSP Bareilly on plea over offering prayers



The Allahabad High Court has directed the district magistrate and senior superintendent of police of Bareilly to appear before it on March 23 after a petitioner alleged denial of permission to perform namaz inside his house. The order was passed by a two-judge bench comprising Justice Atul Sreedharan and Justice Siddhartha Nandan while hearing the plea by Tarik Khan of Bareilly. On February 12, the court had granted time to counsel for the State to respond to the plea and had issued notices to the DM and SSP of Bareilly. In the petition, it is alleged that authorities did not permit the offering of 'namaz' inside the house of Khan on January 16.

Earlier, in another case related to Maranatha Full Gospel Ministries, the court had observed that the petitioner has right to conduct the prayer as per his convenience in his own private premises without any permission from the State Government. "However, if any occasion arises where it has to spill over the public road or public property, in such a situation, this court mandates that the petitioner shall at least intimate the police and take any requisite permission under the law, if so required," the HC had said.

Uttam Nagar Holi clash: Delhi HC restrains MCD from action



The Delhi High Court on Tuesday restrained the MCD from carrying out demolition action for a week against the houses belonging to certain individuals allegedly involved in the Uttam Nagar Holi clash case in which a 26-year-old man was killed. Justice Amit Bansal allowed Jarina, the mother of accused Imran, and Shahnaz, whose children were interrogated by police as part of the probe, to file a fresh petition during the period against the demolition of their residential premises and said that the civic body would take no action in the meantime. During the hearing, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) maintained that its demolition drive was against encroachment by eight houses and was not selective.

Homebuyers agony can't be prolonged, SC pulls up CBI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday pulled up the CBI for its investigation into the "unholy nexus" between banks and developers to allegedly dupe homebuyers in Delhi-NCR and other parts of the country, saying prolonging the probe will lead to more agony for the flat buyers.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi took exception to CBI's statement that some of the cases where homebuyers have been defrauded under the subvention scheme be transferred to State agencies for investigation.

The bench, which refused to transfer those cases to the State agencies, asked the CBI to probe all cases and convert the preliminary enquiries into regular cases.

"This court cannot wait for an indefinite period for the conclusion of the investigation," the bench said, adding, "delay or prolonging of the investigation will only lead to more agony for the homebuyers who have already been harassed by the builders and developers, apparently in collusion and connivance with financial institutions and banks."

The top court was hearing a batch of pleas of more than 1,200 homebuyers, with the lead petition filed by Himanshu Singh through advocate Akshay Srivastava, who had



booked flats under the subvention plans in various housing projects in the NCR, especially in Noida, Greater Noida and Gurugram. They allege that they were being forced by banks to pay instalments despite not having possession of flats.

The bench had ordered CBI probes into "unholy nexus" banks and builders to allegedly dupe homebuyers through subvention schemes.

Under the subvention scheme, banks disburse the sanctioned amount directly to the accounts of builders, who are then required to pay EMIs on the sanctioned loan amount until flats are handed over to homebuyers.

After builders started defaulting on EMIs to banks, in line with the tri-

partite agreement, banks demanded the EMIs from homebuyers — the third party in the agreement.

The bench observed that if this remains the approach of the CBI, then it may set up a committee to oversee the investigation by the agency. The top court said that if the CBI is facing staff shortage to probe the cases, it can write to state DGPs and take the help of their Economic Offence Wings.

While expressing displeasure that bank officials were not being investigated by the CBI, the bench asked a "responsible officer" from the CBI to file an affidavit by next date of hearing on the pace of probe in all the cases. It said that CBI should consult a report filed in the matter

by amicus curiae Rajiv Jain on April 29, last year, and directed the agency to indicate a probable timeline for the completion of the probe. Advocate Pranav Sachdeva, appearing for another petitioner, said that the requirement of prior prosecution sanction under the Prevention of Corruption Act against erring bank officials, who are public servants, should be dispensed with since it was a court-monitored investigation.

Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for the CBI, said that the agency will take care of any such impediment.

The bench said that all affected parties, including homebuyers, banks and builders, should submit their claims, suggestions and recommendations to the amicus curiae, who would then examine them and place appropriate material before the court.

"Homebuyers, financial institutions or builders shall be at liberty to submit their claims, suggestions and recommendations to the learned amicus curiae for his consideration. No such claims shall be directly entertained by this court unless it is screened through the amicus," it said.

On January 20, the top court asked a special CBI court here to take cognisance within two weeks of three chargesheets filed by the federal agency in the cases related to the "unholy nexus" between

banks and developers in the NCR region and proceed with the trial.

In September 23, last year, the apex court had allowed the CBI to register six more regular cases into the "unholy nexus" between banks and developers to dupe homebuyers in real estate projects in Mumbai, Bengaluru, Kolkata, Mohali and Prayagraj.

Two months prior to that, the court had allowed the CBI to register 22 cases in which homebuyers were duped in the National Capital Region (NCR) by using the subvention scheme.

On April 29, 2025, the apex court directed the CBI to register seven preliminary enquiries against builders in NCR, including Supertech Limited. Frowning upon the collusion of development authorities' officials, banks and builders to dupe homebuyers, the court said it has found a prima facie nexus between renowned banks and builders in Noida, Gurugram, Yamuna Expressway, Greater Noida, Mohali, Mumbai, Kolkata and Allahabad.

Jain had called Supertech Limited the "main culprit" in defrauding homebuyers, whereas the Corporation Bank had advanced more than ₹2,700 crore to builders through subvention schemes.

The amicus' report has revealed that Supertech Limited alone has secured a loan of ₹5,157.86 crore since 1998.

Kejriwal writes to Delhi HC Chief Justice to transfer excise policy case from Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) National Convenor Arvind Kejriwal, along with senior leader Manish Sisodia and several other accused in the Delhi excise policy case, has written to the Chief Justice of the Delhi High Court seeking transfer of the matter from the court of Justice SwaranaKanta Sharma to another bench.

In the letter, they have argued that the case should be heard by an impartial bench to ensure fairness and protect public confidence in the administration of justice, while pointing out that several orders passed by the judge in the same excise-related matter have been overturned by the Supreme Court.

In a letter written on March 11, Kejriwal expressed apprehension that if the matter stays with Justice Sharma, the "matter may not receive a hearing marked by impartiality and neutrality".

Kejriwal stated the request was made due to a serious and genuine concern that the matter may not receive a completely impartial hearing. They requested the case titled "CBI v. Kuldeep Singh & Ors."



Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma, Kejriwal

be placed before another bench to ensure fairness and maintain public confidence in the justice system.

The letter notes that Arvind Kejriwal was named as Accused No. 18 in the CBI FIR registered on August 17, 2022 and was arrested on June 26, 2024. The trial court heard arguments on charges for nearly two months across five charge sheets involving 23 accused persons before reserving its order on February 12, 2026. On February 27, 2026, the Special CBI Court passed a detailed order discharging all 23 accused.

Referring to the proceedings before the Delhi High Court, Kejriwal stated that the CBI filed a revision petition of about 50 pages challenging the discharge order. However,

according to the letter, the petition did not point out any specific errors in the trial court's findings or evidence that would justify setting aside the discharge order.

He further stated that during the first hearing on 9 March 2026, the High Court issued notice and recorded a prima facie view that the trial court's detailed order was erroneous without hearing the discharged accused.

The High Court also stayed the trial court's observations and directions against the investigating officer, including directions related to possible departmental action, even though the CBI had sought only a limited stay.

Kejriwal also pointed out that the High Court directed the trial court dealing with the related Enforcement

Directorate (ED) case to adjourn proceedings until the High Court considered the CBI revision petition. The letter states that the ED was not a party to the revision proceedings and that the CBI had not sought such relief.

The letter also points out that although some of these cases arose from Enforcement Directorate proceedings, those proceedings were based on the same CBI FIR and involved the same underlying allegations that are now central to the CBI's revision petition against the discharge order.

The applicants stated that the request for transfer is aimed at ensuring that the case is heard with neutrality and to protect public confidence in the administration of justice. They also noted that the Chief Justice, as the Master of the Roster, has the authority to allocate matters and assign them to appropriate benches.

The former CM of Delhi and 22 other accused were recently discharged in the excise policy case by a CBI court. On Monday, the Delhi HC sought the stand of Kejriwal and other accused in the case on a petition by the CBI challenging their discharge by the trial court.

IAF personnel acquitted in POCSO case after minor says 'assault' was in a dream

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Kanpur

A special court here has acquitted an Indian Air Force personnel accused of molesting his minor sister-in-law after the complainant revealed that the alleged incident was only a dream and her raising an alarm was a misunderstanding, officials said.

The case was registered at the Naubasta Police Station on August 3, 2019, based on a complaint by a 15-year-old girl who alleged that her brother-in-law, Anurag Shukla, had molested her earlier that year while she was asleep.

According to the FIR, the alleged incident took place on the night of March 8, 2019, when the girl was staying at her sister-in-law's house in Khadepur under Naubasta police station limits.

During the trial, however, the girl told the court that she had been on antibiotics and was in a semi-conscious state that night and had "felt in a dream" that Shukla had grabbed and molested her, following which she woke up frightened and raised an alarm, defence counsel Karim Ahmad Siddiqui told PTI on

Tuesday. Her father, Vijay Tiwari, and elder sister, Shivani Tiwari, who is married to Shukla, also told the court that the complaint had been filed under a misunderstanding.

Shukla had married Shivani Tiwari on February 10, 2019. At the time of the alleged incident, he was living in Khadepur and has since shifted to Bithoor.

Speaking to PTI, Shukla said he was arrested on September 29, 2019, and spent 19 days in jail before being granted bail on October 17 that year. A chargesheet was subsequently filed, and the special court framed charges in November 2019 under provisions of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, including molestation and sexual assault of a minor. During the trial, the complainant retracted her earlier allegations.

Taking note of her testimony and statements of family members acknowledging the misunderstanding, the special court presided over by Judge Rashmi Singh acquitted Shukla of all charges on March 7, holding that the prosecution had failed to prove the case beyond a reasonable doubt.

NIA seeks life term for Kashmiri separatist Asiya Andrabi for waging war against India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

The NIA has sought life imprisonment for Kashmiri separatist and Dukhtar-e-Millat chief Asiya Andrabi following her conviction in a UAPA case, saying she had waged war against India and a stern message is required to be sent that conspiring against the State will invite the harshest penalty.

Submissions were made before the Additional Sessions Judge Chanderjit Singh, who was hearing arguments on the quantum of sentence against Andrabi and her two associates, Sofi Fehmeeda and Nahida Nasreen. They were convicted under the stringent anti-terror law, Unlawful Activities Prevention Act (UAPA), earlier in January.

"The convicts are well-educated

ed women, and their acts were part of a deep-rooted conspiracy to wage war against the Government of India. They were not just part of the conspiracy but were the main perpetrators," the National Investigation Agency (NIA) submitted in its written arguments.

The special public prosecutor representing the NIA submitted before the court that Andrabi and her two associates used social media and seditious gatherings with the support of terrorist entities based abroad to wage a war against India.

"From a reading of posts, imputations made and assertions on Twitter and Facebook posts of convicted persons, it is evident that they were running a concerted war against the Government established by law in India," the SPP said.



Asiya Andrabi

She submitted that they used their proscribed organisation, Dukhtar-e-Millat (DEM), to incite insurrection and seek the secession of Jammu and Kashmir from the Union of India.

The trio was convicted by the court on January 14, 2026, for various offences under the UAPA

and IPC, including conspiracy to commit terror acts and waging war against the state.

The agency highlighted that Andrabi, the chairperson of DEM, has a long history of criminal activities, with 33 FIRs registered against her across various police stations in Jammu and Kashmir.

Her associates, Fehmeeda and Nasreen, are involved in nine and five cases, respectively.

The NIA informed the court that the convicts colluded with Pakistan-based entities and UN-designated terrorist Hafiz Saeed, the founder of Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT).

"This transforms their conspiracy from a domestic matter into a cross-border collusion against the security, sovereignty, and integrity of India," the agency told the court.

The NIA counsel argued that the

convicts' provocative speeches and social media posts radicalised impressionable youth, leading them to join militancy.

She cited several major terror attacks, including those in Pulwama, Uri, and at the Red Fort and noted that such radicalisation often results in the loss of innocent lives and public property. The prosecution also pointed to a specific instance where Andrabi slaughtered a cow during a protest to defy the Indian legal system and promote enmity between communities, an act the NIA termed "prejudicial to national integration".

Responding to this, the defence counsel representing all three convicts argued that the agency did not provide any evidence to prove its claim.

Seeking the harshest penalty, the NIA argued that any leniency

would undermine public confidence in the efficacy of the law.

"The social impact of the crime, where it relates to terrorism and waging war against India, requires exemplary treatment. A stern message is required to be sent that conspiring against the State will invite the harshest penalty," the agency said.

The NIA has requested the court to award life imprisonment under IPC Section 121A and relevant sections of the UAPA, further praying that the sentences for different counts should run consecutively.

Opposing the life term punishment, the defence counsel argued that the prosecution failed to show any evidence that the speeches or posts of the convicts ever instigated people to violence.

The judge also gave Asiya and two others an opportunity to

speak as they attended the hearing virtually.

After hearing arguments from both sides, the court listed the matter for March 24 for pronouncing the sentencing order.

Andrabi and her associates were convicted under the offences of UAPA sections 20 (punishment for being a member of a terrorist gang or terrorist organisation), 38 (offence relating to membership of a terrorist organisation) and 39 (supporting a terrorist organisation).

The court also convicted the three under IPC sections 153 A (promoting enmity between different groups), 153B (imputations, assertions prejudicial to national integration), 120B (criminal conspiracy) and 505 (statements conducing to public mischief) and 121A (conspiracy to commit offences against the State).

Supreme Court strikes down Bihar law on heritage Patna library's acquisition

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has struck down a law in Bihar allowing the State Government to take over a heritage Patna library, saying the provision for token compensation of ₹1 for such acquisition was "illusory" and lacked the basic attributes of fairness. Setting aside the 2024 order of the Patna High Court, which had previously upheld the State's takeover, a bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said, "The Srimati Radhika Sinha



Srimati Radhika Sinha Institute and Sachchidanand Sinha Library

Institute and Sachchidanand Sinha Library (Requisition & Management) Act, 2015 is declared unconstitutional and is accordingly struck down."

The bench directed that the management and administration of the library be restored to the original trust. Located in the heart of the

Bihar Capital, the two-storey structure is commonly known as 'Sinha Library'.

The top court said that there was not a single communication from the state Government to the trust or its trustees, bringing to their notice any allegation of mismanagement, financial irregularity, neglect, or failure to discharge the objects of the trust. The apex court underlined that before passing the Act, the state also did not provide any reasons for the proposed acquisition.

It said, "A measure of such sweeping consequence, including complete divestiture of an institution that has functioned for nearly a century, cannot rest on assumptions that were never put to the very persons sought to be displaced.

This itself is a powerful indicator of the arbitrary character of the legislative action." In a stinging criticism of the Act, the top court noted that Section 7 of the Act authorised the state to pay compensation up to a maximum of one rupee, and said that besides aggravating the arbitrariness,

it vested "unguided discretion in the legislature" and reduced compensation to "a nominal and illusory figure". It said that a statutory provision that enabled the acquisition of property while reducing compensation to a token amount lacked the basic attributes of fairness.

"While Article 300A of the Constitution permits deprivation of property by authority of law, such law must nevertheless be just, fair and reasonable, and not arbitrary or confiscatory in effect," the court said.



Editor's
TAKE

ESMA invoked as LPG crisis looms

Disruptions in global energy supplies triggered by the US-Israel conflict with Iran have exposed India's heavy dependence on imported LPG

The Iran war is now spreading far and wide. Its impact on the geoeconomy is now visible here in India. India imports almost 80 per cent of its gas, most of which passes through the Strait of Hormuz. With billows of barrels stuck as Iran decides to choke the oil artery of the world, the Indian kitchen is starting to face the heat. Though the crisis may not be here yet, one can see it coming should the war prolong for a month or more. With reports of LPG supply being restricted, if not completely cut, in Mumbai and Bengaluru, the fear of uncertainty is gripping people. Reportedly, even in Delhi the online gas booking lines are not working, adding to the panic. Meanwhile, the Government has invoked ESMA, a right move, to ration supply, and strict action against hoarding is a move in the right direction. India may not officially be facing a gas shortage as yet, but the warning signs of a brewing LPG crisis are everywhere. India's deep dependence on imported liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) is beginning to expose a critical vulnerability. The government's decision to invoke the Essential Services Maintenance Act (ESMA) to ensure uninterrupted distribution reflects the seriousness of the situation.

For India, the implications of stalled supply are severe. About 50-60 per cent of India's crude oil imports pass through the Strait of Hormuz, making it one of the country's most critical energy supply routes. The dependence is even higher for liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), with around 80-85 per cent of India's LPG imports transiting through this narrow maritime corridor. India is the world's second-largest LPG importer after China. Most of India's oil and natural gas supplies come from Gulf nations such as Qatar, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Kuwait.

The most immediate impact is being felt by small businesses and the hospitality sector. If the disruption continues, temporary shutdowns could become unavoidable, adding to the losses to the economy and distress to workers who might be laid off. Reports from cities like Bengaluru and Delhi suggest that the grey market is booming, and LPG is being sold at much higher rates than its original price.

Recognising the potential fallout, the government has moved to prioritise domestic consumers and essential services. The gap between LPG cylinder bookings for households has been increased from 21 to 25 days to manage distribution.

Invoking ESMA can only offer temporary relief. The crisis highlights a deeper structural issue - India's overwhelming dependence on imported cooking gas and its concentration of supply routes. Strategic reserves for LPG remain limited, with analysts estimating that existing stocks may cover only two to three weeks of demand. It is a wake-up call. Diversifying energy supply routes, expanding LPG storage infrastructure, and accelerating the shift to alternative cooking fuels such as piped natural gas, electric induction, and biofuels must be prioritised. The push towards renewable energy must also extend to household and commercial cooking. Every crisis offers a lesson: energy is a pillar of nation-building. Without energy self-sufficiency, no country can truly claim power and will remain vulnerable to external pressures.

The dangerous gamble in Iran

History shows that external attacks on Iran often strengthen national resolve rather than weaken it. Instead of bringing stability, this move risks triggering retaliation, regional turmoil, and deeper global uncertainty



NILANTHA
ILANGAMUWA

The world is hurtling toward a geopolitical abyss, and Iran has become the latest arena of a reckless and deeply misguided experiment in decapitation and coercion. War was not a surprise; it was foreseen. The assassination of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei by the combined machinations of U.S. and Israeli forces is being hailed in some quarters as a surgical strike against tyranny. In reality, it is the latest episode in a playbook as old as the Iran-Iraq War itself, yet dressed in 21st-century technologies and executive hubris. Trump's decapitation project is neither novel nor subtle; it continues a century of covert interventions, from the CIA's orchestration of the 1953 coup against Mossadegh to the entanglements of Iran-Contra, from arming militias to pitting Kurds against fellow Iranians, and now to globalised narratives of chaos framed as "strategic advantage".

To understand the current conflagration, one must remember that Iran has endured far worse. During the eight years of the so-called Holy Defence against Iraq, millions poured into the streets, armed with resolve rather than sophistication, singing patriotic anthems and marching for survival against a far better-equipped adversary. Today, those streets are alive again, but with a new overlay of fear, uncertainty, and international interference. Whether one accepts it or not, the global order is no longer an order; it is disorder veiled as governance.

The assault on Iran, as detailed by multiple analyses, has followed a predictable arc of overreach and miscalculation. Trump and Netanyahu, emboldened by decades of proxy wars and intelligence manipulations, assumed that eliminating Iran's leadership would create political pliability. They underestimated the robustness of the Islamic Republic's institutional architecture: a system of overlapping authorities, including the Supreme Leader's office, the Revolutionary Guards, and parallel clerical networks, all designed precisely to withstand decapitation and disorientation. The very mechanisms the U.S. claims to exploit-the ethnic diversity, border minorities, and internal fissures-are now being leveraged by Tehran to consolidate loyalty rather than fracture the state.

The shadow of the Iran-Iraq War looms over this conflict. That war, long remembered as a futile slog of attrition, demonstrated that foreign interference-whether through Saddam Hussein's aggression, U.S. intelligence, or covert arming-can stiffen, rather than weaken, national resolve. Today, the ghosts of that war are alive in the streets, in the militias, and in the minds of mili-



IRAN HAS LONG BEEN A THEATRE FOR INFILTRATION AND INFORMATION WARFARE, RANGING FROM THE PLACEMENT OF INFORMANTS WITHIN GOVERNING BODIES TO THE COMMANDEERING OF CCTV NETWORKS AND COMMUNICATION INFRASTRUCTURE

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tary planners who know that Iranians fight best when existentially threatened. Arming Kurdish groups and other militias, a strategy pursued clandestinely by the CIA and other agencies since the 1980s, may once again set co-ethnics and compatriots against one another, yet it is unlikely to deliver the control envisioned by external manipulators. Uncle Sam may cheer from a distance, but the reality on the ground is far more unpredictable. Iran has also been accused by external actors of arming and facilitating groups such as Hamas in Palestine, Hezbollah in Lebanon, and the Houthis in Yemen, suggesting that the stage of proxy conflict extends far beyond its borders.

The assassination of 87-year-old Khamenei reflects overconfidence in technological and military superiority, yet the attack has paradoxically elevated him as a beleaguered leader remembered for defending his nation rather than being overthrown by protests. By targeting him, the U.S. has ironically recreated echoes of 1979. Israel and the United States have reportedly dropped more than 5,000 bombs in the opening stages of the conflict, striking military and civilian infrastructure and causing casualties ranging from the verified to the conjectural.

Iran has long been a stage for infiltration and information warfare, from informants within governing bodies to the manipulation of CCTV networks and communication infrastructure. The decapitation strategy ignores a core lesson of asymmetric warfare: removing individuals does not dismantle systems, particularly when they are deeply institutionalised.

Iranian expatriates, numbering in the millions, have been invoked by Western and Israeli actors as proxies of legitimacy or opposition. Reza Pahlavi, the exiled son of the last Shah, has emerged as a symbolic figurehead in opposition

narratives abroad. Yet his support remains fragmented, reflecting desperation more than a coherent political vision, while many in the diaspora remain sceptical of foreign manipulation.

Meanwhile, European powers have been marginalised in the U.S.-Israeli partnership, caught between realpolitik, economic ties, and domestic inertia. France, Germany, and the U.K. have issued statements of defensive readiness, even as European assets have reportedly been targeted by Iranian drones. BRICS, where Iran holds membership, has remained conspicuously silent, highlighting the limited influence of traditional alliances in a conflict shaped by technological overmatch and asymmetric capability.

Iran's geostrategic leverage remains its strongest deterrent. The Strait of Hormuz, through which about 20 per cent of global oil exports pass, has been partially closed, demonstrating the power of geography against external pressure. Disruptions here ripple across markets, supply chains, and the credibility of American global hegemony.

At the same time, Iran faces serious political and economic pressures. Poverty, unemployment, and factionalism persist under sanctions. Yet external pressure can strengthen cohesion rather than weaken it. Tehran now faces a crucial task: consolidating competing factions and reshaping governance structures while pursuing strategic negotiations not as capitulation, but as a means of survival and long-term agency in global affairs.

Israel reportedly maintains approximately ninety undeclared nuclear warheads, yet there is no international scrutiny comparable to that faced by Iran. Tehran's nuclear capability, limited and largely defensive, is cast as a threat in the

narrative constructed by external powers, while Israel's strategic opacity remains unchallenged. This imbalance exemplifies the double standards underpinning contemporary interventionist logic: power exercised by the strong is legitimacy, whereas defensive capacity exercised by the weak is aggression.

The war on Iran is a manifestation of a broader pathology of intervention: a reliance on decapitation, manipulation, and coercion, divorced from the realities of institutional resilience, asymmetric capability, and popular mobilisation. If Tehran is the next Gaza, it is not because of weakness; it is because the architects of chaos have underestimated the very forces they sought to control. History, strategy, and geography converge to create a paradox: the attempt to dismantle Iran may yet consolidate it, transforming a targeted campaign of decapitation into a narrative of survival, resilience, and renewed strategic agency. The question is not whether Tehran will fall-it is whether the architects of chaos are prepared to confront the consequences of their own hubris. Is this what we have gained in the name of the guardians of democracy?

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

Connected to screens, disconnected at Home



SAKSHI
SETHI

2ND OPINION

In the silence of the modern home, family time has slowly been replaced by screen time. Families return to the same room, but not always to each other. Instead of conversation, the space is filled with the blue light of scrolling parents and gaming children. A parent checks emails or social media while a child watches videos or plays games on a tablet. Physically, they are together, yet emotionally they may be miles apart.

The technological age has transformed nearly every aspect of modern life, including family relationships. Technology has undoubtedly made communication faster, information more accessible and learning more dynamic. At the same time, it has quietly entered the heart of the home, introducing subtle challenges to the bond between parents and children. The real question

today is not whether technology is good or bad, but how it shapes the quality of relationships within families.

Traditionally, parent-child relationships were built through shared experiences-family meals, storytelling, evening walks or simple conversations about the day. These moments helped children feel heard, valued and emotionally secure. Today, many children are growing up in a world where digital interaction often replaces real-world human connection. A child may spend hours communicating with friends online but hesitate to open up to parents sitting just a few feet away.

One of the most important differences in the digital age is the gap between being available and being present. Parents today can easily track, text and call their children through various applications, ensuring their safety. Yet connection requires something deeper-undivided attention, empathy and genuine listening. Children do not simply need supervision; they need emotional connection. Even a few minutes of distraction-free conversation can mean more to a child than hours spent together while both remain absorbed in separate screens.

Another challenge is the widening generational gap in technology use. Children today are digital natives who navigate online platforms with remarkable ease, while many parents struggle to keep pace with rapid techno-

logical change. This gap can create misunderstandings. Parents worry about online safety, while children may feel their digital world is misunderstood. Instead of treating technology as a barrier, families can transform it into a bridge. Showing interest in a child's digital interests-whether games, videos or online communities-can create opportunities for communication and trust.

At the same time, healthy boundaries remain essential. Simple practices such as device-free dinners, technology-free time before bedtime and shared family activities without screens can restore balance. Equally important is the example parents set themselves. Children imitate behaviour

more than advice. When parents put their phones aside and focus on family interaction, they send a powerful message about priorities. The strength of parent-child relationships has never depended on the era in which families live. The core needs of children remain unchanged: love, attention, understanding and guidance. In a world filled with constant digital distractions, the most meaningful gift a parent can offer a child is genuine presence. In the end, the true measure of parenting is not how connected we are to our devices, but how deeply we remain connected to our children.

The writer is an educator

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

SAFEGUARDING ELECTORAL INSTITUTIONS IS ESSENTIAL FOR DEMOCRATIC STABILITY

Recent discussions about a possible no-confidence motion against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar reflect growing tensions between opposition parties and constitutional institutions.

While scrutiny of electoral authorities remains a legitimate and necessary democratic practice, such actions must be guided by credible evidence and a clear respect for institutional integrity.

The Election Commission occupies a central role in protecting the credibility of India's democratic process. Repeated political confrontations surrounding this institution risk undermining public confidence in the electoral system. When doubts are raised in a highly polarised environment, they can quickly erode trust among

citizens who depend on impartial institutions to ensure fair elections.

At the same time, concerns expressed by opposition parties regarding voter roll revisions and electoral procedures deserve transparent clarification. Questions relating to electoral processes should not be dismissed lightly. Instead, they should be addressed through open dialogue, detailed explanations, and appropriate parliamentary oversight.

A mature democracy requires both accountability and institutional independence. Neither should be sacrificed for short-term political advantage. Constructive engagement between political parties and constitutional bodies is therefore essential.

VIJAYKUMAR HK | RAICHUR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

AP THIRUVADI | CHENNAI

KV CHANDRA MOULI | MYSORE

ABHIJIT ROY | JAMSHEDPUR

West Asia: India’s strategic clarity amid selective outrage

In this intense conflict, there are no saints. Should India back Iran or the US–Israel alliance? The answer is neither. India must prioritise its own national interests, and the Modi government appears determined to do precisely that

FIRST
Column



BALBIR
PUNJ

In politics, memory is often the first casualty of expediency. The present uproar in India over the government’s response to the convulsions in West Asia offers yet another illustration of this familiar phenomenon.

The Congress party has suddenly rediscovered the language of moral indignation. Its leaders now accuse the present government of “silence”, of “abdication”, and of abandoning India’s civilisational ethos in responding to the death of Iran’s Supreme Leader.

Is this judgement driven by concern for high moral values, or by the opposition’s selective memory, amnesia and political pressures? West Asia today stands on the edge of a dangerous precipice. Over the past two weeks, the United States and Israel have launched relentless aerial strikes on Iran.

Tehran, in retaliation, has launched missile and drone attacks across the region-targeting Israel while also striking American military installations and strategic assets across Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Kuwait, Bahrain, Jordan, Syria and Iraq.

The economic ramifications are equally severe. Nearly twenty per cent of the world’s daily oil consumption passes through the narrow maritime corridor known as the Strait of Hormuz. Iran’s decision to close this strategic waterway has effectively paralysed global oil shipments.

In this volatile theatre, one fact stands beyond dispute: none of the actors involved can claim the mantle of moral innocence. The Iranian regime itself has long been associated with repression at home and destabilisation abroad.

The Islamic Republic that emerged after the 1979 revolution institutionalised a doctrine of ideological expansion. Through the Revolutionary Guard’s Quds Force, Tehran nurtured and financed a network of militant proxies such as Hezbollah in Lebanon and Hamas across the region. This strategy enabled Iran to project power across West Asia while retaining plausible deniability.

Nor does Washington’s record inspire moral confidence. The United States has often behaved as a self-appointed global arbiter whose commitment to principle fluctuates with strategic convenience.



IS THIS JUDGEMENT DRIVEN BY CONCERN FOR HIGH MORAL VALUES, OR BY THE OPPOSITION’S SELECTIVE MEMORY, AMNESIA AND POLITICAL PRESSURES? WEST ASIA TODAY STANDS ON THE EDGE OF A DANGEROUS PRECIPICE

The writer is an eminent columnist, former Chairman of the Indian Institute of Mass Communication (IIMC), and the author of ‘Tryst with Ayodhya: Decolonisation of India’ and ‘Narrative ka Mayajal’

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 The Pioneer

From the devastation of the Vietnam War to its equivocal conduct during the Bangladesh Liberation War of 1971, from the invasion of Iraq to the two-decade military experiment in Afghanistan, American policy has frequently subordinated moral consistency to geopolitical calculation.

In the 1980s, Washington famously nurtured militant jihadist networks as instruments against the Soviet Union in Afghanistan. Decades later, the same networks evolved into the violent forces that haunt the world today.

Even today, this pattern persists. If President Donald Trump, transactional in nature, genuinely believed in liberating the Iranian people from the excesses of their theocratic rulers, one might reasonably ask why his administration continues to embrace Pakistan’s military establishment with such warmth.

Against this turbulent international backdrop, political debate in India has acquired an oddly theatrical tone. Sonia Gandhi has criticised the government for failing to condemn the assassination of Iran’s Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

Writing in a newspaper column, Sonia argued that the Modi government’s response represented not neutrality but abdication. According to her, India’s silence

signalled tacit endorsement of a grave rupture in international relations.

Such claims, while rhetorically dramatic, collapse under the weight of facts. India did not remain silent. India’s External Affairs Minister held discussions with his Iranian counterpart to maintain diplomatic communication at a moment of extraordinary tension. These actions reflect a deliberate attempt to preserve dialogue rather than inflame passions.

At the same time, Prime Minister Narendra Modi engaged extensively with leaders across the region—from the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia to Jordan and Bahrain. His conversations emphasised the need for restraint, de-escalation and the protection of civilian lives.

For India, whose nearly ten million citizens live and work across the Gulf, such caution is not timidity; it is responsibility.

Yet the most striking element of the present controversy lies not in what the Congress says but in what it chooses to forget. Sonia Gandhi invokes India’s civilisational ethos of ‘Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam’-the belief that the world is one family. The phrase is indeed a profound element of India’s philosophical her-

itage. The same moral urgency is rarely heard when Hindus in neighbouring Bangladesh face persecution and violence at the hands of radical groups or when, closer to home, in Kashmir during the 1980s.

The irony deepens when one recalls the record of the very Iranian leader whose death has inspired such passionate commentary. Ayatollah Khamenei was hardly

a sympathetic observer of India’s internal affairs. On multiple occasions, the Ayatollah publicly criticised India on issues ranging from Kashmir to the Citizenship Amendment Act. In 2017, he urged the Muslim world to support what he described as the “oppressed Muslims of Kashmir”, echoing narratives long propagated by Pakistan.

After the abrogation of Article 370 in 2019, the Ayatollah again called upon India to adopt what he termed a “just policy”. During the riots in Delhi in 2020, he accused India of persecuting Muslims and warned of isolation from the Islamic world.

Such statements did not reflect friendly engagement; they were overt attempts to influence India’s internal discourse. Yet those who now mourn Khamenei as a mis-

The untold environmental cost of clothing



SHARMILA
DAS

We have a curious relationship with our clothes. We buy them with optimism. We wear them with personality. We fold them with varying degrees of discipline. And eventually, we part with them, sometimes tenderly, sometimes ruthlessly. But here is the uncomfortable truth: the life of a garment does not begin when it enters our wardrobe, and it certainly does not end when it leaves it.

For most of us, clothes exist in a neat little bubble between “I like this” and “I’m done with this.” Everything before and after feels distant, almost abstract. Yet the hidden life of garments is where the real environmental story unfolds.

And it is far more complex than we imagine.

Before It reaches you

Long before a shirt hangs in a store, it has travelled an extraordinary journey. Fibres are grown or manufactured. Yarns are spun. Fabrics are woven or knitted. They are dyed, finished, cut, stitched, assembled, packed, and transported, often across multiple countries.

Having spent many years working within global garment supply chains, particularly in trims and components, I have seen first-hand how intricate this ecosystem truly is. A single garment can involve dozens of suppliers, each contributing a small but essential piece.

Here is where it becomes interesting. When we think of sustainability, we usually think of fabric-organic cotton, recycled polyester, linen. Rarely do we think of the zipper, the elastic, the thread, the label, the humble button.

Yet these small components often determine whether a garment can be recycled, how long it lasts, and how much environmental impact it ultimately carries.

A beautifully sustainable fabric combined with poorly considered trims is a little like eating a healthy salad topped with deep-fried croutons. The intention is good. The execution... slightly compromised.

The complication of mixed materials

Modern garments are marvels of engineering and also sustainability puzzles.

A single jacket might contain:

- Polyester lining
- Cotton/woollen outer fabric
- Plastic/metal buttons
- Metal zippers
- Elasticated cuffs



- Synthetic thread
- When such a garment reaches the end of its life, separating these materials is not simple. Recycling systems struggle with complexity. Many facilities are not equipped to dismantle garments component by component.
- So where do they go?
- Often, landfills.
- Or incineration.
- Or, in some cases, they are shipped to other countries under the hopeful label of “second-hand clothing”, where only a fraction may actually be resold.
- The rest still becomes waste, just elsewhere.

The donation myth

We have all felt virtuous placing unwanted clothes into donation bags. It feels responsible. It feels generous.

Sometimes, it genuinely is. But the reality is more nuanced. Charitable organisations can only resell garments that are in good condition and suitable for demand. The sheer volume of discarded clothing globally far exceeds resale or reuse capacity. In other words, donating is helpful, but it is not a magic eraser for overconsumption. This is not a call for guilt. It is a call for awareness. Because awareness changes behaviour far more effectively than shame ever could.

Durability: The quiet hero

One of the most powerful sustainability strategies is surprisingly unglamorous: making clothes that last. Quality components matter enormously here. A strong zipper. A resilient button. Elastic that retains its shape. Stitching that withstands wear, washing, and the torturous ironing, over and over again.

In my professional experience working with garment trims, I have seen how seemingly minor cost decisions can dramatically affect durability. A slightly cheaper component may save pennies in production, but cost years in reduced garment life.

When a zipper fails or a button snaps, the garment is often discarded long before its fabric has truly worn out. And so we return to

the idea that sustainability lives in the details. The hidden parts.

The things no one notices-until they fail.

After We Let Go. When we finally decide we are “done” with a garment, we rarely consider what happens next. Globally, millions of tonnes of textiles are discarded every year. Recycling infrastructure is improving, but it is not yet universal, nor simple. Clothing made from single materials is easier to process. Mixed-material garments are more complicated. Trims can interfere with recycling streams. Dyes and finishes add another layer of challenge.

In other words, the afterlife of our clothes depends heavily on decisions made long before we ever see them.

Design decisions. Material choices. Component selections.

This is where responsible manufacturing plays a critical role. And this is where consumers-even unknowingly-influence the system through what they choose to support.

So what can we do?

The solution is not to panic and wear the same sweater forever (although if you love it, why not?).

Instead, perhaps we can:

- Buy fewer, better-made garments
 - Pay attention to construction, not just price
 - Repair when possible
 - Support brands that are transparent
 - Ask questions about materials and durability
 - Encourage brands to consciously display if the garment has been flown by air from the manufacturing hub-a silent but huge disruption to the environment just to catch fashion on time
- Mindfulness does not belong only on the yoga mat. It belongs in our wardrobes too.

When we become more aware of the hidden life of our clothes, we shift from passive consumption to conscious participation.

And that shift matters.

The Bigger Picture

Sustainability in fashion is not about perfection. It is about progress. It is about understanding that the shirt on our back is connected to farmers, factory workers, designers, transport networks, and waste systems. It is about recognising that small components influence big outcomes. And it is about realising that every garment carries a story far longer than its time in our wardrobe. The hidden life of our clothes may not be visible, but it is real.

And once we see it, we cannot entirely unsee it. Perhaps that is the beginning of change.

The writer is a trained Sivananda Yoga teacher

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AI is setting the bar for skill: Can humans keep up?



ROHIT
YADAV

Artificial intelligence has crossed a decisive threshold. What once assisted human effort is now beginning to coordinate, plan, and manage complex tasks independently. Tools such as Claude Cowork are already being used in ways that resemble human decision-making workflows rather than simple automation.

This shift signals more than a technological upgrade. It represents a structural change in how organisations define productivity, skill, and value. The growing influence of AI is not driven by technological curiosity alone; it is increasingly shaped by economic incentives. When Microsoft announced that it had saved around \$500 million after adopting AI widely across its operations, it highlighted how organisations are beginning to redefine efficiency and productivity. AI is no longer viewed as an experimental add-on. It is becoming central to how work is designed and delivered.

Academic research reinforces the scale of this transformation. In their study, “The Latent Role of Open Models in the AI Economy,” MIT researchers Frank Nagle and Daniel Yue estimate that organisations could save up to \$25 billion by transitioning to AI-based models. Such potential gains are influencing investment strategies, operational structures, and workforce planning across industries.

The broader implications of this shift were evident at the recent India AI Impact Summit 2026, held in New Delhi. The summit, inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, brought together leaders from government, industry, and academia to discuss the responsible and inclusive deployment of AI technologies. As the first global AI summit hosted in the Global South, the event highlighted a key concern: preparing economies and workers for an AI-augmented future.

The discussions reflected a broader reality. AI adoption is no longer a distant possibility—it is becoming an immediate competitive requirement. Industries that historically depended on scale and labour intensity are already witnessing structural changes. The IT sector, for example, has long relied on billable hours, hierarchical expertise, and large project teams. AI is beginning to compress these structures by automating repetitive cognitive work and flattening traditional experience hierarchies.

For India, the implications are particularly significant. The country’s IT sector employs nearly

six million professionals, making it one of the largest concentrations of digital talent in the world. As AI transforms how software is developed, tested, and maintained, the central question is shifting. The issue is no longer simply about the number of jobs available, but about the nature of human contribution in an economy where intelligent systems increasingly handle execution. This does not mean that human workers are becoming obsolete. Instead, the definition of skill itself is evolving. AI systems excel at pattern recognition, speed, and large-scale execution. Human capability, on the other hand, will increasingly lie in defining the problems machines should solve, exercising judgement in complex contexts, and ensuring that technological outcomes align with social and ethical priorities.

One of the most profound aspects of the AI transition is the reversal of an old assumption.

In earlier technological revolutions, machines had to prove their usefulness to human workers. Today, the opposite is beginning to happen. Workers increasingly need to demonstrate how their contributions add value alongside machines that already perform core tasks efficiently and at scale.

This shift is redefining how organisations evaluate talent, productivity, and expertise.

India has historically shown an ability to adapt to global technological change. The discussions at the India AI Impact Summit suggest that policymakers and industry leaders are aware of the importance of inclusion, governance, and workforce readiness in the AI transition.

However, adaptation cannot

rely on rhetoric alone.

Sustaining relevance in the AI era will require deliberate investment in education, continuous upskilling, and deeper forms of human-machine collaboration. Institutions, organisations, and governments will need to rethink how skills are taught, updated, and applied throughout professional careers.

If AI is becoming the benchmark for efficiency and innovation, then human capability must be redefined in terms that machines cannot easily replicate. Adaptability, contextual judgement, creativity, ethical reasoning, and leadership will become central to how human talent is valued.

In a world where machines increasingly function as capable co-workers, human skill will not be measured simply by effort or technical execution. It will be measured by the ability to guide, evaluate, and complement intelligent systems.

The future of work will therefore depend not on competing with AI, but on learning how to work alongside it.

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NARCOTICS GALORE



Over the past few years, India has evolved from a “transit hub” to “significant manufacturing base” for synthetic narcotics and illegal medicines. Although the nation remains a route for distribution of traditional products like heroin, it houses illegal factories that make drugs such as methamphetamine, mephedrone, and alprazolam. In 2025 and 2026, Indian investigating agencies such as Narcotics Control Bureau, Directorate of Revenue Intelligence, and Central Bureau of Narcotics have discovered, raided, and dismantled large industrial hubs that make illegal synthetic drugs in states such as Gujarat, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, West Bengal, and Madhya Pradesh. More importantly, the illicit drug makers operate under the garb of legitimate medicine production or chemical manufacturing, as they leverage the vast and growing local pharma infrastructure. The quantities of seizures have increased; methamphetamine seizures doubled in 2024, and those of mephedrone were even steeper.

Over the past decade or so, thousands of crores of rupees worth of illegal chemical narcotics were apprehended by the investigating agencies. The figure was up by more than 50 per cent to more than ₹25,000 crore in 2024 compared to the previous year. The drugs included more harmful and addictive synthetic and pharma drugs, apart from the traditional ones like cocaine and heroin. The Government has adopted a dual approach, both top-to-bottom combined with bottom-to-top ones to manage the growing menace, which has afflicted not just the richer sections, but middle-class and even lower-class sections. Anecdotal reports from north, west, and east India indicate that even the poor sections have access to the cheaper, but more dangerous and live-threatening synthetic drugs, which are mixed with chemicals in unique ways. For example, the slightly-expensive pharma tablets are mixed with extremely-cheap and easily available allergy solutions which, according to experts, provides better ‘kicks,’ but claims more lives.

Some of the seizures and operations in narcotics reveal shocking trends, and hint at the growing size of the illegal market. In a joint operation, Sagar Mantan-I, which was conducted by the Narcotics Bureau, Indian Navy, and Gujarat Police, a huge consignment of 3,300 kg of drugs, which included the traditional charas, hashish, and heroin, apart from the synthetic crystalline powdered meth, was seized from a vessel in the Indian Ocean. It was a record in terms of an offshore seizure. According to a media report, the Narcotics Bureau launched Sagar Manthan to “dismantle the large scale drug cartel activities of wanted smuggler Haji Salim, also known as ‘Lord of Drugs.’ According to officials, the operation was launched... to track down Haji Salim aka Haji Baloch, and his trafficking syndicate spread worldwide. As part of this operation, authorities seized 4,000 kg of illicit drugs linked directly to Salim’s cartel, with several Pakistani nationals arrested.”

Even in the heartland of the nation, industrial hubs have emerged as huge manufacturers, with links to worldwide distribution channels like the Haji Salim one. In Kasna Industrial Area in Noida, 95 kg of meth was hauled in solid and liquid forms. “Chemicals like acetone, sodium hydroxide, methylene chloride, ethanol premium, toluene, and others, apart from imported machinery... were found,” according to reports. As India becomes a major producer of legal medicines, and a huge exporter even to the developed world, pharma factories, both large and small, have sprouted across the country. Chemicals, as is evident from some of the seizures are easily available, both legally and illegally, and these can easily be used to make the illegal drugs in cheaper assembly and formulation units. In the past too, India was a major supplier of chemicals used to make heroin in the Pakistan-Afghanistan region. Indians have graduated from chemical suppliers to drug-makers.

Several global reports highlight the increasing role of India as a mass producer of illegal synthetic and pharma drugs. The World Drug Report (2025) “identifies the global expansion of synthetic drugs, and flags India’s growing role in the production and export of synthetic cathinones and precursors.” The International Narcotics Control Strategy Report (2025) “provides a country-by-country analysis, listing India among the major illicit drug-producing, and precursor chemical source countries for 2025-26.” There is another “detailed thematic report that specifically discusses how India’s pharma infrastructure is being exploited for ‘designer drug manufacturing.’ Based on recent findings, international agencies feel that the ‘seizures of synthetic drugs... may soon outpace those of traditional plant-based narcotics, signalling a shift in the global drug trade. Synthetic substances are not only more potent and addictive but easier to manufacture and traffic.’ They can be made in ‘small, concealed labs with minimal expertise. This allows traffickers to quickly adapt, shifting locations, and modifying chemical substances to evade detection.’”

Some of the major centres for the manufacture of synthetic drugs are found in the coastal states of Gujarat, Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana. These are notable manufacturers of legal medicines. Massive quantities of liquid mephedrone were seized in Gujarat, which were being made in units disguised as legitimate chemical factories. According to investigations, “kitchen labs” have sprouted in Hyderabad and Visakhapatnam, which divert ephedrine to make meth. In Maharashtra, Pune, and Raigad, with access to Mumbai coastline and export hubs, have a high density of small-scale pharma units. In Rajasthan, labs are run by drug cartels with access to cross-border groups. In Madhya Pradesh, a huge lab was found in Bhopal.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | MARCH 12, 2026



BUSINESS10

Dwindling \$100-billion-plus stocks

From their peaks, IT majors have lost 30-50 per cent in valuations

There was a time, not too few years ago, when India’s software and IT reigned supreme, not just in the world but the Indian stock markets. According to media reports, in January 2022, coincidentally a month before the Russia-Ukraine war, TCS was possibly the most expensive stock. With a valuation of just over \$200 billion, it was a coveted family jewel, something to be proud of if owned now, if owned sometimes in the past, or if to be owned in the future. If one was, had been, or could be attached to the stock, it was a huge milestone for an investor.

Then, four years later, it hardly mattered. TCS’ stock was battered. The Indian IT illusion had shattered. Indian IT stock universe cratered. Today, the market cap of the Tata-owned IT firm, the largest in the country, is just below \$100 billion. A 50 per cent wipeout in dollar terms, and 45 per cent one in rupee terms. One shudders to think of those who purchased the stock in 2022. Obviously, the price-to-earnings multiple has slumped from nearly 40 in early 2022 to 19 now. Other reports indicate that the stock hit its lowest levels since October 2020.

One cannot blame the Russia-Ukraine war, or the ongoing Iran war for the TCS debacle. This is because although several stocks fell in 2022 and 2023 due to the Ukraine war but many recovered well. The Iran war has subsumed most stocks, but the TCS dismal saga, which started with the Russia-Ukraine war never stopped, and accelerated after the Iran war. In the past month, before the Iran war started, the stock slumped by 17 per cent or more. If you consider year-to-date values, TCS is down by a quarter, against a Nifty decline of eight per cent.

Indeed, the entire IT universe is in a shock, stunned by low valuations. According to a

media report, “Other major IT companies have experienced declines. Infosys, HCL Tech, and Wipro shares have dropped between 32 per cent and 44 per cent from their respective peaks. In contrast, the Nifty IT index has decreased by around 35 per cent, while the benchmark Nifty 50 has seen an eight per cent decline. Over the past 12 months, stated another report, 75 Indian IT firms lost more than \$100 billion in market cap, which is “higher than the IMF’s 2026 GDP estimate for Venezuela,” and GDP of Sri Lanka (2024).

Of the \$100 billion lost in the recent past, TCS was responsible for \$40 billion, Infosys \$21 billion, and Wipro \$10 billion. In effect, the three of the top four Indian IT firms are responsible for more than 70 per cent of the decline. The only optimism that stems out from the top firms is that HCL Tech lost just \$6.5 billion, the lowest among the four. But this may be because HCL’s share price is subdued compared to some of the others. It may be due to the more bread-and-butter work that TCS, Infosys, and Wipro are engaged in, compared to HCL Tech.

Although artificial intelligence (AI) seems to be the most crucial factor for the decline of the IT and software stocks, it cannot be responsible for what happened in 2022 and 2023. AI became important in 2023, and has emerged as a sensitive sore point in the past year or so. So, the story of software decline started before the advent of AI, possibly during the Russian war, and because of the declining and clerical nature of the jobs. Indian firms failed to climb up the software value chain despite claims to do so, and could not adjust to the tech disruptions.

“Citirini Research in a note... outlined a scenario

in which contract cancellations at TCS, Infosys, and Wipro would accelerate through 2027. Jeffries, on the other hand, slashed its target prices on Indian IT names by up to 33 per cent, saying that AI may structurally change IT business mix towards consulting and implementation, while shrinking managed services. This, it said, would not only increase cyclicality but also require a change in talent, and operating model, thus adding risks,” stated a media report. Heightened fears of revenue deflation due to “recent model releases from frontier AI labs, and the growing use of agent-based workflows,” added the same report.

“Model improvements so far look incremental and broadly in line with our expectations, but the sharp stock move reflects deeper concerns about the long-term relevance and longevity of IT services,” stated a note by Kotak Institutional Equities. According to Jeffries, maintaining the long-term revenue growth trajectory in line with the previous decade is the best-case outcome for the Indian IT firms. The worst-case outcome may be three per cent lower revenue growth over the next five years. PE multiples, stated Jeffries, may be 14-22 times for the large IT firms, and 23-42 times for the mid-sized ones in the new re-rating formula.

However, HSBC Global Research sees several positives. The top global clients of the Indian IT firms have reported strong earnings, which may lead to long-term spending. There may be a pause due to rapidly-evolving AI models, and uncertainty around the adoption curve. Over time, business outlook and higher productive gains among the clients will drive “incremental investment” in software. “On a net basis, these (productivity gains in clients’ businesses) should offset AI deflation, and may still lead to mid-single-digit growth for some IT companies.”

ICICI Securities offers hope too. It feels that valuations have turned more supportive after years of corrections. The stocks now trade closer to the long-term historical averages, after the massive declines and, hence, the risk-reward scenario is more in tune with the wishes of the long-term investors. “Large caps (IT stocks) offer stability... (and) select midcaps provide above-industry growth potential,” it stated in a recent note. Other brokerage houses feel that the worst is possible behind Indian IT. These positive trends may lead to “better convergence of deals to revenue in the next few quarters.”

Although IT seems to be one of the worst affected sectors due to geopolitics and other disruptions, the recent Iran war has “reshaped India’s \$100 billion market cap club.

TCS (as mentioned earlier) and ICICI Bank have fallen below this threshold (maybe temporarily), leaving Reliance Industries, HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, and State Bank as the only companies remaining in the \$100-billion-plus league,” stated a media report. Although the \$100-billion-plus club does not have any significance in a falling market, the deep declines in some stocks, and that too consistently over years, is a matter of concern.

The Left-Handed Economist

First for US & RIL in 50 years

Is the US refinery RIL’s best chance to expand its global footprint?

One is not sure how the demand-supply arithmetic will work. There is availability of fuel, this is for sure, there is a demand for the refinery products, this too is sure. But does the US need a large refinery for local demand? Or will the mega refinery look at exports and local sales? These are some of the questions that have rattled the experts, even the investors.

What is more important is that Reliance’s experience with American shale oil and gas is not a happy one. According to Al-driven search, “RIL exited its US shale gas projects between 2017 and 2021 primarily due to sustained low oil and gas prices, which led to poor financial returns, negative equity, and asset devaluation. The projects, acquired between 2010 and 2013 became economically unviable, prompting RIL to divest its

Marcellus and Eagle Ford shale assets....” The sales were at lower valuations compared to the purchase prices. RIL decided to shift to high-growth Indian areas, and exit volatile foreign assets.

According to a media report, “A fall in (oil and gas) price affects shale gas business more than traditional oil and gas as shale assets are economically viable only if crude prices remain at a certain threshold.” Generally, the threshold keeps changing depending on the shale assets, and their complexity. Obviously, at nearly \$90, although it is down from \$120, the global crude prices are quite attractive to explore all kinds of shale oil and gas assets across America. At a price measure, this is the opportune time to enter the refining business based on shale oil.

When the late patriarch Dhirubhai Ambani started his Indian operations as a textile trader in the 1960s, he never imagined that Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL) would construct the largest grassroot refinery. Despite the apocryphal stories that he wanted an oil empire as big as that of British Petroleum, he never thought that RIL would build a mega refinery in the US, the first in the past half-century. Well, even the second dream, which was once hazy and nebulous, will soon turn into reality over the next few years, if everything goes according to the plans concocted by the US president, Donald Trump.

Without hints from RIL, or speculation in Indian media, Trump unleashed an oil bombshell, unlike the attacks on Iran’s oil assets, and Iran’s counter on oil targets in the Middle East. “This is a historic \$300 billion deal, the biggest in US history,” he announced in a social media post. He thanked RIL, India’s largest privately-held firm, “for this tremendous investment.” The new port refinery will be in Texas, and the US president claimed that it will “strengthen our national security, boost American energy production, deliver billions of dollars in economic impact, and will be the cleanest refinery in the world.”

It will be the first refinery in the US in 50 years. Media reports indicate that it will use American shale oil, and will be co-developed between RIL and American First Refining. In a statement, the American firm stated that it received a “9-figure investment from a global supermajor at a 10-figure valuation.” It added that the supermajor, now revealed as RIL, has inked a 20-year-deal to “purchase, process, and distribute shale oil sourced and produced stateside.” The refinery will process 1.2 billion barrels of US light shale oil, valued at \$125 billion, and produce 50 billion gallons of refined products worth \$175 billion.

According to the executives of American First Refining, America has a surplus of light shale oil, apart from prominent shale gas sources, but there is a shortage of refining capacity. The Reliance investment will correct this input-output mismatch. Hence, the new mega refinery will strengthen the domestic petro product supply chain. Over the past decade or so, refining capacity globally has undergone a shift.

Expansions were witnessed in Asia and the Middle East, even as capacities contracted or stagnated in North America and Europe. Over the past two decades, refining capacity was up 15 per cent despite a decrease in the absolute number of refineries since 2011.

Hence, the announcement of a mega refinery in the US is a major one. As Trump admitted, this is the first such deal in 50 years.

But as the past experiences prove, and as RIL’s experiences in the US show, the scenario can change rapidly. What seems lucrative and attractive can become worthless within no time. This mostly happens to non-crude energy assets such as gas and shale-based sources. If the Iran war ends, and crude prices plummet, the whole refinery’s financials and commercials can go for a spin. For RIL to invest in a \$300-billion refinery, and that too based on shale oil, is fraught with risks. These risks raise their heads quite quickly. But then, RIL has managed one of the largest refineries at Jamnagar, and an export-oriented one.

Hence, it understands the dynamics of the oil and refinery products businesses. Over the past few years, despite the volatility in both crude and petroproducts prices, the financials of the Jamnagar refinery were stable and consistent. There were profit fluctuations but not wild ones. There was always something that saved RIL. If crude went up, somehow some other margins improved to bolster and support the profits. Hence, this game of rising and falling input prices is something that RIL has played, and won in most years. Doing this in India is easier than doing it in the US, as the shale gas assets sell-off shows.

Investors are not sure of the American mega refinery proposal. After a spike in prices in the first hour of yesterday’s trading, the stock came down. It ended the day more than 1.5 per cent lower. Maybe after the initial enthusiasm of such a big and unexpected news, and that too from the social post of Trump, numbed the investors into undue excitement and enthusiasm. Possibly, the realisation stuck later. A refinery in the US, which is based on shale oil, has different dynamics and economics compared to an export-oriented refinery in India.

Trump remains upbeat about the refinery, as he is with everything, even if it means nothing. It credited the proposal to “America First Agenda, streamlining Permits, and lowering Taxes that have attracted billions of dollars in deals.” He said that the mega project will generate thousands of jobs in Texas, and bring “long-awaited economic development. It will power global exports, and bring... jobs and growth to a region that deserves it,” Trump said in a social media post.

Sensex, Nifty plunge nearly 2%

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty ended nearly 2 per cent lower on Wednesday after a day's breather as a spike in global crude oil prices amid growing tensions in West Asia unnerved investors.

Besides, sustained foreign fund outflows and selling in blue-chip bank stocks added to the pressure, traders said.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tumbled 1,342.27 points or 1.72 per cent to settle at 76,863.71. During the day, it dropped 1,446.72 points or 1.84 per cent to 76,759.26.

A total of 2,380 stocks declined. While 1,881 advanced and 153 remained unchanged on the BSE.

The 50-share NSE Nifty tanked 394.75 points or 1.63 per cent to end at 23,866.85.

"Investor sentiment remained fragile as escalating geopolitical tensions in the Middle East continued to unsettle global markets and push volatility higher.

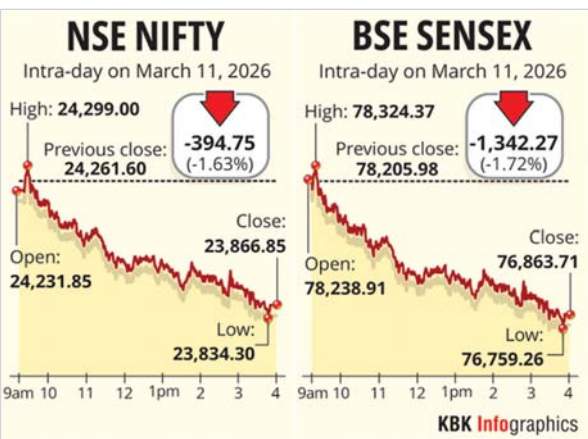
"Concerns over potential disruptions to crude oil

supply, rising inflationary pressures, and the possible impact on economic growth kept participants cautious. Additionally, continued foreign institutional investor selling and weakness in the rupee further dampened risk appetite," Ajit Mishra — SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

Bajaj Finance was the biggest drag in the Sensex pack, sliding 5.01 pr cent, followed by Axis Bank, Bajaj Finserv, Mahindra & Mahindra, Maruti, Trent, Bharti Airtel and Kotak Mahindra Bank. On the other hand, Sun Pharma and NTPC were the only gainers.

"...Markets resumed their downward trajectory after a brief rebound in the previous session, as persistent foreign fund outflows and selling in banking, financial services and automobile stocks weighed on benchmark indices," Siddhartha Khemka — Head of Research, Wealth Management, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd, said.

The BSE midcap select index tanked 1.55 per cent, and the smallcap select



index declined 0.61 per cent. The auto index declined about 3 per cent as the sector continued to face multiple headwinds, including higher raw material costs and persistent supply chain challenges, particularly semiconductor shortages affecting production, Khemka said.

Among BSE sectoral indices, auto tumbled 3.06 per cent, bankex (2.06 per cent), Private Banks index (2.03 per cent), BSE Top 10 Banks (2.03 per cent), financial services (1.99 per cent), consumer discretionary (1.89

per cent) and PSU Bank (1.87 per cent). In contrast, BSE energy, healthcare, utilities, oil & gas and power were the gainers.

"Indian equity markets witnessed a sharp sell-off today as heavy profit-taking wiped out the gains from the previous bullish session, reflecting growing caution among investors amid persistent global uncertainties.

"From a market behaviour perspective, Wednesday's decline appears largely driven by systematic profit-booking after short-covering rallies, rather than fresh long-term selling.

However, the magnitude of the fall indicates that traders remain reluctant to carry aggressive bullish positions in the current uncertain macro environment," Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and Founder, Livelong Wealth, said.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 5.76 per cent to \$92.86 per barrel.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth ₹4,672.64 crore on Tuesday, according to exchange data. Domestic Institutional Investors (DIIs), however, bought stocks worth ₹6,333.26 crore.

In Asian markets, Japan's Nikkei 225 index jumped 1.43 per cent and South Korea's Kospi climbed 1.40 per cent. Shanghai's SSE Composite index also ended in positive territory, while Hong Kong's Hang Seng index settled lower.

Markets in Europe were trading lower in mid-session deals. The US market ended almost flat on Tuesday.

Rupee falls 16 paise to close at 92.01 against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee declined 16 paise to settle at 92.01 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday, weighed down by a sharp rise in global crude oil prices and a stronger greenback as the war in West Asia raged on.

FII outflows and weak sentiments in the domestic equity markets further pressured the local unit, according to forex traders.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 91.92 against the US dollar and traded in the range of 91.85-92.06 before settling at 92.01 (provisional), down 16 paise from its previous close.

The rupee staged a strong recovery from its record low against the US dollar on Tuesday, gaining 36 paise to settle at 91.85.

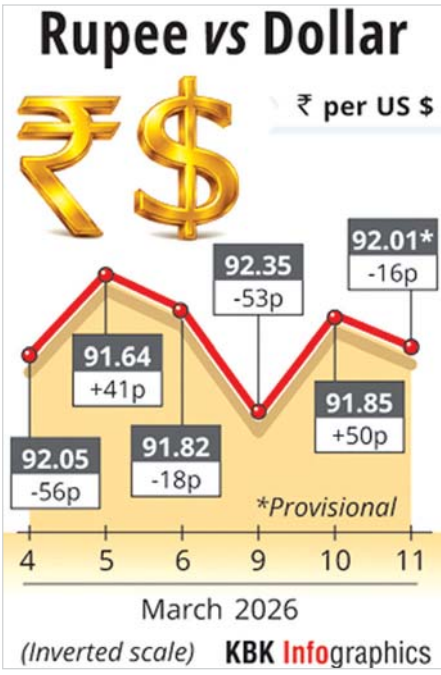
"The rupee declined on weak domestic markets and overnight recovery in crude oil prices. Risk-off sentiments in the global markets and FII outflows may continue to weigh on the rupee. Markets will also watch out for geopolitical developments in West Asia," Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.

"Traders may take cues from CPI data from the US. USD-INR spot price is expected to trade in the range of 91.70-92.40," he added.

The dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading 0.14 per cent higher at 98.96. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading higher by 5.44 per cent at

\$92.58 per barrel in futures trade. On the domestic equity market front, the Sensex tumbled 1,342.27 points to settle at 76,863.71, while the Nifty plummeted 394.75 points to 23,866.85.

Foreign institutional investors sold equities worth ₹4,672.64 crore on a net basis on Tuesday, according to exchange data.



Indian fuel retailers face margin pressure

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's State-owned oil marketing companies — Indian Oil Corporation Limited, Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited, and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited — are

stocks provide around 65 days, leaving OMCs exposed to supply disruptions.

S&P Global Ratings, Moody's Investors Service, and Fitch Ratings, in separate notes, detailed the impact of the widening West Asia conflict, triggered by the US and Israel launching attacks on



under pressure from rising global crude and gas prices, limited domestic fuel price pass-through, and dependence on imported energy, global rating agencies said.

India imports 88 per cent of its crude and nearly half its natural gas, with 30-55 per cent of supplies passing through the Strait of Hormuz. Strategic petroleum reserves cover just 10 days of consumption, while commercial

Iran and Tehran retaliating.

Fitch said a prolonged Iran-related oil or LNG supply shock could pressure near-term credit metrics, although Government backing provides strong support.

Retail fuel prices in India have largely remained unchanged since April 2022, reflecting Government influence and OMCs' dominant market share of nearly 90 per cent of fuel outlets.

Reliance to partner in first new US oil refinery project in 50 years

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Billionaire industrialist Mukesh Ambani's Reliance Industries is set to participate in the development of what could become the first major new oil refinery built in the United States in nearly five decades. The announcement was made by US President Donald Trump, who described the project as the "largest refinery deal in US history."

The refinery is planned at the Port of in Brownsville, Texas, and will be designed to process light crude derived entirely from US shale oil. The project is being led by energy developer America First Refining (AFR), which confirmed that a global energy major has committed significant investment and entered into a long-term commercial agreement tied to the facility's output.

Although AFR did not name its partner directly, President Trump identified Reliance Industries in a post on the social media platform Truth Social, calling the arrangement a "historic \$300 billion deal." Reliance has not yet issued an official statement regarding the announcement. Groundbreaking for



the refinery is expected to take place in the second quarter of 2026. Industry analysts estimate the project could require capital expenditure of roughly \$4-5 billion, though official financial details and completion timelines have not been disclosed.

The facility will be engineered to run entirely on American light shale crude, reflecting the shift in US energy production over the past decade. According to AFR, a binding 20-year off-take agreement has been

signed with the international partner, committing it to purchase and distribute fuels produced at the refinery.

The agreement includes the purchase and processing of approximately 1.2 billion barrels of US shale oil — valued at about \$125 billion — over the contract period. AFR also plans to produce roughly 50 billion gallons of refined petroleum products worth an estimated \$175 billion.

In total, the project is projected to contribute about \$300 billion toward reducing

the US trade deficit through domestic energy production and exports.

If completed, the Brownsville refinery would become the first major US refining facility built from scratch since the Garyville refinery in Louisiana developed by Marathon Petroleum began operations in 1977.

President Trump highlighted the economic and strategic impact of the project, stating that the refinery would strengthen US energy security, increase

domestic fuel production, and generate significant economic activity in South Texas.

The project site was originally proposed by Element Fuels, which completed site preparation and permitting work in 2024 for a hydrogen-powered refinery complex capable of processing around 160,000 barrels of crude per day. John Calce, founder and chief executive of Element Fuels, now leads America First Refining.

For Reliance Industries, the project would represent its first refinery investment in the United States. The Indian conglomerate currently operates the world's largest refining complex in Jamnagar, with a processing capacity of about 1.24 million barrels of crude oil per day.

Reliance already maintains a strong commercial presence in the US through energy trading, crude sourcing, and technology partnerships. The company has previously invested in US shale gas assets and continues to market refined fuels in the American market.

Its broader ties with the US corporate sector have also deepened in recent years. Technology giants Meta Platforms and Google have

invested in Jio Platforms, while private equity firm General Atlantic holds a stake in Reliance Retail Ventures.

The refinery announcement comes at a time of heightened volatility in global oil markets amid escalating geopolitical tensions, including the ongoing conflict involving Israel and Iran. Policymakers in Washington are exploring measures to stabilise energy prices and boost domestic supply.

According to the US Energy Information Administration, the United States currently operates about 132 oil refineries with a combined processing capacity of roughly 18.4 million barrels per day. Most of these facilities were built decades ago and are configured to handle heavier crude imports, particularly from countries such as Venezuela and Canada, rather than the lighter crude produced from US shale formations.

The proposed Brownsville refinery is expected to address this imbalance by focusing specifically on processing domestically produced shale oil, aligning refining infrastructure more closely with the evolving profile of American crude production.

Sebi working to speed up AIF approvals, says Pandey



Tuhin Kanta Pandey

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Capital markets regulator Sebi is exploring a new regulatory framework for Alternative Investment Funds (AIFs) that could speed up the launch of fund schemes, its Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said on Wednesday.

The proposed 'Lodge and Launch' model would allow certain AIF schemes to be launched faster by relying on due diligence certificates issued by merchant bankers, which reduces the time needed for regulatory approvals. Speaking at the IVCA Conclave 2026, Pandey said the framework aims to improve the ease of doing business, accelerate fund launches and facilitate faster mobilisation of private capital.

Under the proposed system, specific AIF schemes may rely on merchant bankers for due diligence certification, while for AI (accredited investors)-only schemes, the AIF manager will be responsible for ensuring disclosure-related due diligence, he added.

The regulator said it will consult with the industry on the proposal.

Cabinet to approve Indian Statistical Institute Bill: Minister

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Union Cabinet is likely to approve Indian Statistical Institute Bill, 2026, which provides for incorporation of Indian Statistical Institute (ISI) as a body corporate and a framework for its effective governance, Parliament was informed on Wednesday.

The draft Indian Statistical Institute Bill, 2026 aims at enhancing ISI's autonomy and accountability, stated Minister of State for Statistics and Programme Implementation Rao Inderjit Singh in a written reply to the Lok Sabha. "The process of Cabinet approval has been initiated.

The matter is under consideration in accordance with the prescribed procedure," Singh said.

The pre-legislative consultation, including inter-ministerial consultation, on the draft ISI Bill has concluded. Legal vetting of the draft has also been completed, he added.

The bill provides more robust and contemporary governance framework which will enable ISI to emerge as a globally recognised centre of excellence in statistical and allied disciplines, he stated.

As per the draft bill, the Board of Governors of ISI will be an empowered body comprising 11 members.



Rao Inderjit Singh

There would be only one Government nominee on the board, five external experts (including Chairperson) and five internal members of the institute including two members of the Academic Council.

This would provide academic and governance autonomy to the institute, the minister stated.

The bill provides for recognition of the centres of the institute and grant them a degree of autonomy.

The centres of the institute will be given adequate financial, administrative and academic powers, so as to enable them to attain autonomy in their decision making and functioning through their respective Management Councils, he stated.

Collectively, the provisions in the bill will strengthen the academic autonomy, the minister stated.

Niti Aayog urges States to adhere to fiscal deficit norms

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Government think tank Niti Aayog on Wednesday urged state Governments to adhere to fiscal deficit norms under the FRBM Act through disciplined expenditure management, broadening the GST base, and enhancing their own tax capacity.

The Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management (FRBM) Act aims to regulate the country's debt level by restricting fiscal and revenue deficits as a percentage of GDP. Niti Aayog's 2026 Fiscal Health Index (FHI) for 2023-24 suggests that states with widening revenue deficits should prioritise aligning revenue expenditure with sustainable revenue growth.

Odisha, Goa, Jharkhand, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Telangana, Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka

and Madhya Pradesh have emerged as India's top 10 fiscally-wise States, according to the latest fiscal health index for the financial year 2023-24. Bihar, Karnataka and Telangana showed a mild recovery, whereas Punjab, West Bengal and Kerala remained at the bottom of the index.

In the FHI of 2025, which ranked states based on their fiscal situation during 2022-23, Odisha was number 1, followed by Chhattisgarh, Goa, Jharkhand and Gujarat.

Overall, higher-ranked states display stronger fiscal discipline and resource mobilisation efforts, while lower-ranked States exhibit higher non-developmental expenditure and less sustainable fiscal patterns, the FHI 2026 report said.

Among north-eastern and Himalayan states, Arunachal Pradesh has



Suman Bery, Vice Chairman, NITI Aayog

topped in the index, followed by Uttarakhand, Tripura, Meghalaya, Assam and Mizoram. The report was released by Niti Aayog Vice Chairman Suman Bery.

"We are seeing at the national level shocks that come from a number of sources. We are talking international shocks, but there are domestic shocks as well. So one important develop-

mental consequence of maintaining strong fiscal health is, of course, to have a buffer when shocks hit," he said.

The FHI is a comprehensive framework for assessing and comparing the fiscal performance of States. It outlines each State's fiscal strengths, weaknesses, and overall profile. "States should prioritise strengthening their

fiscal frameworks by improving revenue mobilisation, primarily through broadening GST bases and enhancing own tax capacity by curbing committed expenditure to restore fiscal flexibility," the report said.

Rationalising subsidies, adopting standard expenditure heads, improving the quality and composition of capital spending, and adopting medium-term fiscal plans can help contain deficits and stabilise debt trajectories.

"States with persistent stress must undertake targeted consolidation measures, including tighter control of off-budget borrowings, and better cash and debt management," it added.

The FHI ranks states on five major sub-indices that include quality of expenditure, revenue mobilisation, fiscal prudence, debt index, and debt sustainability.

CRED gets RBI nod to operate as payment aggregator

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Fintech platform CRED on Wednesday said it has received the final authorisation from the Reserve Bank of India to operate as a payment aggregator.

With this, CRED and its subsidiaries now hold two Reserve Bank of India (RBI) authorisations, including the Prepaid Payment Instrument (PPI) license.

"The RBI has formally authorised CRED (Dreamplug Paytech Solutions Private Limited) to operate a payment system directly under the regulator's supervision. The license enables CRED to onboard merchants, collect payments on their behalf



across instruments, and handle settlement and refunds," the company said in a statement.

The Bengaluru-based firm reported a reduction in operating losses to ₹298 crore in FY25, from ₹609 crore

in FY24, on the back of product portfolio expansion.

It saw its consolidated operating revenue grow by 16 per cent to ₹2,735 crore in FY25.

"Stakeholder trust has been central to how we've built CRED from the get-go; we've operated with a high bar for performance, reliability, transparency, and governance from day zero.

"The authorisation to operate as a payment aggregator reflects the trust we've consistently built across the ecosystem and sets the foundation for the next chapter of enabling financial progress for India's most creditworthy," CRED Founder Kunal Shah said. CRED currently has a member base of over 1.5 crore.

FROM THE WORLD

UK

Trio convicted child sex abuse

A British Pakistani man and his two younger brothers have been convicted 18 years after they sexually abused four children and a woman in northern England, the UK's National Crime Agency has said. Amar, Kamran and Kamar from Sheffield were found guilty of a series of sexual offences, including rapes, during legal proceedings which concluded on Monday. They were arrested in June 2020 as part of Operation Stovewood, the National Crime Agency's probe into child sexual abuse in the UK. While on bail, Amar travelled abroad to Pakistan and failed to appear for his trial and was instead tried in his absence. "Our investigation found Amar targeted his victims opportunistically or groomed them extensively," said Alan Hastings, NCA's Senior Investigating Officer.

PAKISTAN

KPK CM Afridi charged

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Chief Minister Sohail Afridi was on Wednesday formally named in a chargesheet submitted at a court in Pakistan in a case related to the May 9, 2023 attack on Radio Pakistan building here. The charge sheet submitted at the Anti-terrorism Court here against Afridi and several others was in the case related to the attack on the Radio Pakistan Peshawar building during nationwide pro-Imran Khan protests in May 2023. The investigating officer informed the court that the charge sheet was prepared on the basis of forensic reports from the Punjab Forensic Science Agency and data verification by the National Database and Registration Authority (NADRA). According to the reports, the presence of the nominated suspects at the scene during the May 9 attack on Radio Pakistan was confirmed.

Iran is using cluster munitions, says Israel

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Tel Aviv

Israel says Iran has been firing cluster munitions throughout their 10-day war — adding a complicated and deadly challenge to Israel's already-stretched air defences. The warheads burst open at high altitudes, scattering dozens of smaller bomblets across a wide area. The smaller bombs, which at night can resemble orange fireballs, are difficult to intercept and have proven lethal.

Normally restrictive about releasing information on Iranian hits and damage, Israeli authorities in recent days have sought to educate the public about their dangers, which can persist as unexploded bombs on the ground even after civilians leave shelters. At least three people have been killed, including two at a construction site in central Israel on Tuesday.

Over 120 countries have signed an international convention banning the use of

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Shri Kailash Chander to inform the public at large that Shri Kailash Chander is purchasing the PLOT NO. B-120, AREA 50 SQ. YDS. OUT OF RECT. NO. 9, KILLA NNO. 11, SITUATED IN THE AREA OF VILLAGE MATIALA, DELHI STATE DELHI COLONY KNOWN AS SANIK NAGAR ON NAJAFGARH ROAD, NEW DELHI., from of Smt. Surjeet Kaur w/o Shri Jaginder Singh who became owner through General Power of Attorney, Agreement to Sell & Will dated 15.10.2002 which was executed by Smt. Chanchal Khurana w/o Shri Mukesh Khurana and same to be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birta Housing Finance Ltd., So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, liens etc. Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Speculation over the health of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei grew Wednesday after the son of Iran's president mentioned hearing news about him "being injured". Mojtaba, 56, is the son of the late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. He long has been a secretive figure within Iran. His father and wife both were killed in an Israeli airstrike Feb 28 that started the war. Mojtaba has not been seen since, nor has he given any statement since becoming supreme leader on Monday. In an overnight post on the app Telegram, Yousef

Can not mediate for Iran while under attack: Qatar

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Doha

Qatar said it won't serve as a mediator for Iran as it remains under attack from Tehran. Mohammed bin Abdulaziz al-Khulaifi, Qatar's minister of state for foreign affairs, made the statement to the Qatari-funded satellite news network Al Jazeera in an interview aired Wednesday. He noted both Qatar and Oman had been attacked even though they worked to "build bridges between Iran and the West". "We will not be able to fulfill that role under attack, and that's something the Iranians need to understand," al-Khulaifi said. "The region-

Drone strike hits Sudan school, medical centre, killing 17

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Cairo

An explosive-laden drone blamed on Sudanese paramilitaries struck a secondary school and a health care centre in southern Sudan Wednesday, killing at least 17 people, mostly schoolgirls, a hospital official and a medical group said. At least 10 people were wounded in the strike, according to Dr Musa al-Majeri, director of the Douiem Hospital, the nearest major medical facility to the village. Al-Majeri told The Associated Press that three girls suffered serious injuries; two of them underwent surgeries at the hospital while the third was evacuated to the capital, Khartoum. The war-tracking Sudan



Pezeshkian, the son of President Masoud Pezeshkian, wrote: "I heard news about Mr Mojtaba being

injured. I asked friends who were in contact. They said, thank God, he is healthy and there is no problem." Israeli

intelligence assessment indicates Iran's new top leader wounded at start of war Israel believes Iran's new



al countries are not an enemy of Iran, and the Iranians are not understanding that idea." Meanwhile, Qatar issued a warning to the public on Wednesday morning of a

possible Iranian attack. An Associated Press journalist in Qatar heard explosions as air defences intercepted incoming fire over Doha, the country's Capital.

US-ISRAELI VIOLATE LAW: MELONI
Rome: Italian Premier Giorgia Meloni, a close ally of US President Donald Trump, said the US-Israeli attacks violate international law. Meloni, in an address to the Italian Senate on Wednesday, described a broader international crisis "in which threats are becoming increasingly terrifying and unilateral interventions outside the confines of international law are multiplying". She said the "the American and Israeli intervention against the Iranian regime" should be understood as part of that broader crisis.



Doctors Network reported the strike first. It said the dead included two teachers and a health care worker. The group said there was no military presence in the village.

Both the medical group and al-Majeri blamed the paramilitary Rapid Support

Forces for the strike. The RSF didn't respond to a request for comment.

The strike in the village of Shukeiri in the White Nile province was the latest deadly attack in Sudan's nearly three-year war. Sudan slid into chaos in April 2023 when a power struggle

between the military and the RSF exploded into open fighting in Khartoum and elsewhere in the country. The devastating war has killed more than 40,000 people, according to UN figures, but aid groups say that is an undercount and the true number could be

Sri Lanka court orders handover of Iranian sailors' bodies

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

A Sri Lankan court on Wednesday ordered that the bodies of 84 Iranian sailors killed in a US attack on an Iranian vessel off the island nation's coast be handed over to Iran's embassy.

Currently, the bodies are stored in two freezer containers in Galle National Hospital. Galle Chief Magistrate Sameera Dodangoda ordered the director of the hospital to handover the bodies to the Iranian embassy.

The order was issued following a request by the Galle Harbour Police.

Last week on Wednesday, Sri Lanka said it had recov-



ered 84 bodies of Iranian sailors after the US submarine attack sank the Iranian frigate IRIS Dena off Galle on the island's southern coast.

The ship was returning to Iran from Visakhapatnam, India, where it had participated in a naval fleet review

exercise. The bodies were brought to Galle National Hospital in Karapitiya along with 32 survivors last Thursday. The Sri Lankan Government had earlier said the bodies would be kept in the country until the situation improved to

Iran war becomes contest of who can take most pain

JON GAMBRELL ■ Dubai

The war on Iran, for all its complexity and global effects, boils down to a single question: Who can take the pain the longest?

A surge in oil prices points to what may be Iran's most effective weapon and the United States' biggest vulnerability in continuing the campaign: Damaging the world economy.

A sharp rise in gas prices has rattled consumers and financial markets, and international travel and shipping have been severely disrupted. US President Donald Trump appears aware of the

danger. As oil jumped to nearly USD 120 a barrel on Monday, the highest since 2022, he suggested the war would be "short-term." That helped reassure markets, and the price eased to around USD 90 — even as Trump, nearly in the same breath, vowed to keep up the war and the punishment on Iran.

On the other side, Iran has to endure a near-constant stream of American and Israeli airstrikes it can't defend against. So far, the Islamic Republic has been able to keep its leadership and military cohesive and in control. The Iranian public, which already rose up



People take cover in an underground bomb shelter as air raid sirens warn of incoming Iranian missile strike, in Ramat Gan, Israel

against its theocracy in nationwide protests in January, still boils in anger but has stayed home as they try to survive the heavy bombardment. Security forces have been on the street every day to ensure no anti-

supreme leader, Ayatollah Motjaba Khamenei, was wounded during the start of the war.

That's according to an Israeli intelligence official and a reservist with knowledge of the situation. They spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to discuss the matter with the media. They gave no details on the nature of the injuries.

Lebanon must act against Hezbollah

Ambassador Danny Danon said Israel always prefers diplomacy and talks with the Lebanese government will continue, "but now they have to choose to actually confront Hezbollah — they have to

stop Hezbollah."

"They have to choose — either they confront Hezbollah or they let us do it," he said. "There is no other option." Danon was asked by UN reporters ahead of an emergency meeting of the U.N. Security Council meeting on Lebanon how long its military operation would last. "As long as there will be a threat against us, we will operate," he replied. Lebanon's cash-strapped military, backed by the U.S. and other governments, has been deploying in recent months across southern Lebanon where Hezbollah has a strong military presence, but it's unclear if they are able or willing to disarm the Iran-backed militant group.

Putin speaks with UAE leader

Russia's President Putin spoke about the war on Wednesday with the UAE president, Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan. The Kremlin said in a readout that the leaders "continued their exchange of views on the dangerously deteriorating situation in the Middle East, which has grave consequences for Iran and the Arab countries."

In his second call with Al Nahyan since the start of the Iran war, Putin emphasized "the need to stop the further escalation of the conflict and settle it through talks." He also thanked Al Nahyan for offering assistance and support to Russian citizens in the UAE.

Russian FM Lavrov, Jaishankar discuss West Asia situation

VINAY SHUKLA ■ Moscow

Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov and External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar held a telephonic conversation on Wednesday during which they discussed the situation in West Asia.

"The two ministers exchanged views on the situation surrounding Iran, calling for its rapid normalisation," the Russian foreign ministry said on its web portal.

"They emphasised their support for the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) and BRICS contribution to efforts to de-escalate the situation and create conditions for achieving a sustainable settlement based on a balance of the legitimate interests of all parties," it added.

Iran, a member of the SCO and BRICS, has been under joint US and Israeli attack for 12 days after its Supreme Leader, Syed Ali Khamenei, and several top commanders



were killed on the first day of the strike on February 28. Tehran's retaliatory strikes at US bases in Gulf countries had caused serious damage to civilian and energy infrastructure in the nations considered strategic partners, both by New Delhi and Moscow. (PTI)

UN warns of higher food prices, cost-of-living



YOSHITA SINGH ■ United Nations

The United Nations has warned of significant risks to global trade and development, including higher food prices and cost-of-living, if the Strait of Hormuz is closed amid the West Asia conflict.

The UN Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD) said in a report Tuesday that the ongoing military escalation in the region due to the US-Israeli strikes on Iran and retaliation by Tehran has disrupted shipping flows through the Strait of Hormuz, one of the world's most critical maritime chokepoints. The narrow passage carries around a quarter of global seaborne oil trade and significant volumes of liquefied natural gas and fertilisers.

"The resulting ripple effects go far beyond the region, affecting energy markets, maritime transport and global supply chains," the report said.

"Higher energy, fertiliser and transport costs — including freight rates, bunker fuel prices and insurance premi-

ums — may increase food costs and intensify cost-of-living pressures, particularly for the most vulnerable," it said.

Stephane Dujarric, Spokesman for UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres, said at the daily press briefing that UNCTAD's economic analysis on the potential impact of a closure of the Strait of Hormuz highlights "significant risks to global trade and development".

The UNCTAD report stressed that disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz underscore the "vulnerability" of critical maritime chokepoints to geopolitical tensions and their potential to transmit shocks across supply chains and commodity markets.

It further noted that reducing risks to global trade and development, including environmental risks, requires de-escalation and safeguarding maritime transport, ports and seafarers, and other civilian infrastructure, while maintaining secure trade corridors in line with international law and freedom of navigation. (PTI)

and critical water works. And Israel, while boasting of inflicting heavy damage on Iran's missile program and other military targets, continues to be targeted by increasingly sophisticated Iranian missiles that send a buckshot-like bouquet of high explosives raining down on its cities.

Frequent air-raid sirens have disrupted daily life, closed schools and work-places and created a tense atmosphere across the region. No off-ramps seen in fighting There's no immediate end to the war in sight — nor in the rhetoric coming from both America and Iran, whose bad blood extends

back decades to the 1979 Islamic Revolution and the US Embassy hostage crisis.

"We've already won in many ways, but we haven't won enough," Trump said in a speech Monday in Doral, Florida. "We go forward, more determined than ever to achieve ultimate victory that will end this long-running danger once and for all." Iranian Foreign Ministry official Kazem Gharibabadi offered a mirror image comment from Tehran, boasting that the Islamic Republic had rejected contacts about a ceasefire that he said had come from China, France, Russia and others. (AP)

Liberals closer to majority Govt in Canada

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Toronto

Another opposition lawmaker in Canada has defected to Prime Minister Mark Carney's governing Liberals, all but assuring he will soon have a majority Government.

Opposition New Democratic interim leader Don Davies said in a statement late Tuesday he was very disappointed Member of Parliament Lori Idlout has decided to join the Liberals.

That puts the Liberals closer to having a majority Government and being able to pass any bill without opposition party support.

Liberal Cabinet minister Sean Fraser welcomed Idlout to the party in a social media post. Three opposition



Prime Minister Mark Carney

Conservative members also defected to Carney's Liberals in recent months.

With another lawmaker decamping from the leftist New Democratic party, the Liberals would have 170 Members of Parliament in the House of Commons. They need 172 to secure a major-

ity Government, which would allow them to unilaterally pass any bill.

A spokeswoman for Carney did not immediately respond to a message seeking comment. A message left at Idlout's office was not immediately returned. Carney has called

special elections for three districts that would give the Liberals a majority Government if his party wins two of them. The prime minister announced March 8 that votes will be cast April 13 in the Toronto-area districts of Scarborough Southwest and University-Rosedale, which are considered safe seats for the Liberals, and in the Montreal-area riding of Terrebonne, which is considered a toss up. The three Conservative Members of Parliament who defected from their party to join the Liberals in recent months were Chris d'Entremont, Michael Ma and Matt Jeneroux.

Jeneroux referenced Carney's speech at the World Economic Forum in Davos as

helping his decision. In the speech, Carney condemned economic coercion by great powers against smaller countries and received widespread praise and attention for his remarks, upstaging US President Donald Trump at the gathering.

Carney has moved the Liberals to the centre since replacing Justin Trudeau as prime minister in 2025 and winning national elections.

"A year after becoming PM, Carney is an enduringly popular politician at home and, especially after his high-profile January 20 Davos speech, an increasingly prominent leader on the world stage," said Daniel Beland, a political science professor at McGill University in Montreal.

South Africa deploys troops to tackle crime

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Johannesburg

Soldiers were deployed on the streets of South Africa's biggest city on Wednesday after the president announced plans last month to use the army to help police fight gang violence and illegal mining.

The soldiers were seen in the Johannesburg suburb of Riverlea in the first major deployment since President Cyril Ramaphosa said in his



annual speech to the nation that organised crime was the greatest threat to South Africa's democracy and economic development.

South Africa's police and the Department of Defence, which oversees the military, did not immediately provide details on the deployment.

Ramaphosa said in a notice to the Speaker of Parliament that 550 soldiers would be involved in an initial deployment in the Gauteng province, which includes Johannesburg, to help combat crime and preserve law and order. That deployment would last until the end of April, he said.

Kilauea volcano erupts, lava fountains soar in Hawaii



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Honolulu

The latest lava-fountaining episode of an erupting Hawaii volcano reached 1,000 feet (300 metres) high on Tuesday, prompting temporary closures at a national park and part of an important highway because of falling glassy volcanic fragments, including ash. Kilauea, on Hawaii's Big Island, has been dazzling residents and visitors for more than a year with an on-and-off eruption that periodically sends fountains of lava soaring into the sky.

The fountaining that began on Tuesday morning marked the eruption's 43rd episode since it began in December 2024. A livestream showed two fountains of bright-red lava and smoke. It is unclear how long the fountaining will

last. Some episodes have lasted a few days and others a few hours. Like other times, the molten rock was confined within Kilauea's summit crater inside Hawaii Volcanoes National Park and has not threatened homes or buildings. But the lava fountains were creating trouble for neighbouring communities and a highway where the volcanic fragments and ash, known as tephra, was falling. The tephra prompted temporary closures at the national park around the summit and a partial closure of Highway 11, an important route around the island, on either side of the park. Hawaii County officials also opened a shelter at a district gymnasium for residents and tourists impacted by the road closure or falling tephra.

American Dara Academy under investigation in Senegal

MARK BANCHEREAU
Dakar (Senegal)

The American Dara Academy in Senegal marketed itself to families in the United States as an affordable boarding school where their children could study the Quran alongside an American curriculum. Parents and families — many with West African roots — sent their children to the school believing it would be a rigorous and affordable religious education.



But the school is being investigated for alleged physical abuses, with hundreds of students withdrawing from the academy and one of two campuses — where most of the alleged abuses took place — now closed, according to an official close to the case.

In accounts shared with The Associated Press, students alleged that supervisors beat disobedient pupils repeatedly in a so-called "magic room." The schoolchildren said they were sometimes ordered to strip to their underwear or be naked and told to squat with their arms extended, gripping heavy rocks. (AP)

UK will publish files about appointment of Epstein friend Mandelson to ambassador post

JILL LAWLESS
London

The British Government said it would publish files related to the appointment of Peter Mandelson as ambassador to the US on Wednesday, as police investigate potential misconduct stemming from the ex-diplomat's ties to the late Jeffrey Epstein.

Lawmakers have forced Prime Minister Keir Starmer's Government to disclose thousands of files about the decision to name Mandelson to the key diplomatic post at the start of US President Donald Trump's



second term, despite a past friendship with the convicted sex offender.

The Government has said the files will show that Mandelson misled officials about the extent of the relationship.

Mandelson, 72, a former

Cabinet minister, ambassador and elder statesman of the governing Labour Party, was arrested February 23 at his London home on suspicion of misconduct in public office. He has been released without bail conditions as the police investiga-

tion continues.

He has previously denied wrongdoing and hasn't been charged. He does not face allegations of sexual misconduct.

Cabinet minister Darren Jones said the "first tranche of documents" will be published Wednesday afternoon. The documents are being published in batches after review by Parliament's Intelligence and Security Committee.

Police have asked the Government not to release files that could compromise their criminal investigation into Mandelson. (AP)

Nepal's RSP leads in proportional representation voting

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kathmandu

The counting of votes under the proportional representation category in Nepal concluded on Wednesday, with the Rastriya Swatantra Party receiving the highest number of votes, according to the Election Commission. The House of Representatives (HoR) in Nepal has a total of 275 seats.

While 165 members are elected through the First Past The Post (FPTP) or direct voting system, 110 members are elected through proportional representation.

"The vote counting concluded. But final results are yet to be published since data entry is still taking place," an EC official said.

According to the latest updates provided by the EC, a total of 1,07,85,876 votes were counted. The Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP)



received 51,57,130 votes, followed by the Nepali Congress, which secured 17,55,872 votes. The CPN-UML secured 14,52,758 votes while the Nepali Communist Party received 809,577 votes. The Shram Sanskriti Party

secured 385,741 votes, and the Rastriya Prajatantra Party 330,268 votes.

The RSP, Nepali Congress, CPN-UML, NCP, Shrama Sanskriti Party and Rastriya Prajatantra Party are likely

to get recognition as national parties. The RSP made history by winning 125 out of 165 seats under direct voting held on March 5. The NC won 18, UML 9, NCP 7, SS 3, RPP 1, Independent 1. The RSP, which bagged the highest number of seats under the direct voting system and the highest number of votes under the proportional representation category, is likely to take its total tally in the 275-member House of Representatives to around 183 seats.

The party has already got a simple majority and is close to a two-thirds majority, which is essential for constitutional amendments.

Now the Election Commission will allocate seats under the PR system to various political parties before submitting the full report to the president, which would take at least one week. Once the list is submitted, the process for the Government formation will start.

Indian charged for defaming minister, promoting racial ill will in Singapore

GURDIP SINGH
Singapore

A Singapore court on Wednesday charged an Indian-origin man with defaming a senior minister and attempting to promote ill feelings between racial groups.

Jay Ish'haq Rajoo, 59, is accused of defaming senior minister Lee Hsien Loong, who is also a former prime minister, in a video posted on social media on August 2023.

He is also charged with attempting to promote feelings of ill will between racial groups through videos posted on social



media, Channel News Asia (CNA) reported.

The case marks the first criminal prosecution under the Protection from Online Falsehoods and Manipulation Act (POFMA) since the law came into

force in 2019.

The next hearing is scheduled for April 8. Individuals convicted of communicating false statements of fact face a fine of up to SGD 50,000 (INR 36,12,577), up to five years' jail, or both. (PTI)

North Korean leader Kim watches cruise missile tests with daughter

HYUNG-JIN KIM
Seoul

North Korean leader Kim Jong Un and his teenage daughter observed tests of strategic cruise missiles fired from a warship, state media reported Wednesday, as North Korea threatened responses to US-South Korean military drills.

Images sent by the Korean Central News Agency showed the two in a conference room looking at a screen showing weapons being fired from the Choe Hyon, a year-old naval destroyer.

Kim Jong Un watched the missiles launches via video



Kim Jong Un and his daughter

on Tuesday and underscored the need to maintain "a powerful and reliable nuclear war deterrent," KCNA reported in a dispatch

that did not mention his daughter. The girl, reportedly named Kim Ju Ae and about 13, has accompanied her father at numerous

prominent events including military parades and weapons launches since late 2022. South Korea's spy agency assessed last month Kim Jong Un was close to designating her as his heir.

KCNA said the missiles hit target islands off North Korea's west coast. It quoted Kim Jong Un as saying the launches were meant to demonstrate the navy's strategic offensive posture and get troops familiarized with weapons firings.

Kim Jong Un observed similar cruise missile launches from the Choe Hyon in person last week, but his daughter was not seen at that appearance. (AP)

Bus fire that killed 6 could have been set deliberately, Swiss police say



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Geneva

Police are investigating whether a bus fire in a town west of the Swiss capital that killed at least six people was started deliberately.

Police spokesperson Frederic Papaux of Fribourg canton, or region, said an unspecified "voluntary act" could have caused the fire Tuesday evening in the town of Kerzers, about 25 km west of Bern.

Five people were also injured in the fire, which for locals echoed a New Year's Eve fire in the Swiss ski resort of Crans-Montana that killed 41 young people.

Christa Bielmann, representing the Fribourg police, told Swiss broadcaster SRF: "There is information circulating that a person poured flammable liquid over themselves on the bus and that this caused the fire.

Japan tsunami disaster: Takaichi pushes more nuclear energy use

MARI YAMAGUCHI
Tokyo

Japan marked the 15th anniversary of the earthquake, tsunami and nuclear disaster on its northeastern coast Wednesday as the Government pushes for more use of atomic energy.

The magnitude 9.0 earthquake and tsunami on March 11, 2011 ravaged parts of the region, caused more than 22,000 deaths and forced nearly half a million people to flee their homes, most of them due to tsunami damage.

Some 1,60,000 people fled their homes in Fukushima because of the radiation



spewed from the tsunami-hit Fukushima Daiichi nuclear power plant. About 26,000 of them haven't returned because they resettled else-

where, their hometowns remain off-limits or they have lingering concerns about radiation.

Japan observed a moment

of silence at 2.46 pm, the moment the quake occurred 15 years earlier.

Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi, at a ceremony in

Fukushima, pledged to do the utmost to accelerate the region's recovery within the next five years and reinforce "the valuable lessons we learned from the huge sacrifice of the disaster."

Takaichi has pushed to accelerate reactor restarts and sought to bolster nuclear power as a stable energy source, in line with the major reversal of policy in 2022 that ended a decade-long nuclear phase-out plan.

Some residents in the tsunami-ravaged areas walked down to the coast early morning to pray for their loved ones and others whose remains are still missing.

More than 1 million homes, offices and schools were damaged or destroyed in the quake and tsunami in Iwate, Miyagi, Fukushima and other coastal areas. Key infrastructure has been rebuilt, but communities and local economies have been slow to recover.

The Fukushima Daiichi plant lost its power and cooling functions, causing meltdowns in three of its six reactors. The three reactors contain at least 880 tons of melted fuel debris, but details of the state inside them are little known due to the still-dangerous radiation levels. Fuller-scale removal of melted fuel

debris has been delayed until 2037 or later. At Unit 1 which just got a new roof, workers will shortly start taking out top-floor debris ahead of the planned spent fuel removal from its cooling pool, which will begin around 2027-2028.

There's also a massive amount of slightly radioactive soil, enough to fill 11 baseball stadiums, from the decontamination efforts across the area.

The Government has pledged to move the soil and has sought to use some for road construction and other public works projects but has faced public resistance. (AP)

The Pieter Principle- Rebuilding Indi-Go



SANJAY LAZAR



Two hours after the Indian Stock exchanges closed on March 10, the Interglobe Board sat down to discuss the letter the Managing Director had received from Pieter Elbers- Ceo Indigo, and within 15 minutes, at 1745 hours the board accepted Elbers resignation, thanked him for his services, and decided that the Founder & Managing Director Rahul Bhatia would take over as interim CEO. The Stock exchanges & Media were informed before 1800 hours.

Rahul Bhatia's carefully worded email to reassure the 37,300 employees of Indigo was sent out and hit almost all the mail boxes by 1815-1820 hours.

In his email to employees Bhatia stated that "Interglobe founded Indigo 22 years ago, with one simple mission... make air travel affordable and accessible for every Indian."

"I join hands with all of you today to ensure that we regain our right of choice with our customers..."
"What happened last December should never have taken place... our customers didn't deserve it and nor did all of you, especially the frontline employees who bore most of the brunt for no fault of theirs." "You are indeed the living spirit of Indigo"

The context and tone of the two-page missive laid bare the recent undercurrents that had beset the once chummy relationship between the Managing Director and the CEO. There was obvious unhappiness over the constant pressure

from Government, since the December Indigo crisis, as the Ministry itself & by extension the DGCA, had come under immense pressure from the PMO, alliance partners and the public for full accountability and transparency.

Sources within Indigo spoke of the gradual distance, that had developed between the CEO and others board level personell, since last December, and things had come to a head with the events of the past few days, with the embarrassment over the international flights due to the Iran war and the restrictions placed on their wet leased wide body aircraft, even though none of that was the CEOs fault. Operationally, the war was causing Indigo to bleed on each international flight.

Sources indicate that both leaders had a pretty cut and dry discussion which pointed the way to the exit, and things were wrapped up in less than 6 hours

on that day.

Indigo had brought Pieter on board to streamline the operations, double revenue by 2030 and transition to a hybrid carrier, with the induction of wide body aircraft, upgrade into the stretch product and rebuild the loyalty program. In many ways, Pieter had achieved a lot of those tasks, but he paid the price for someone else cutting corners at Indigo operations.

Shock waves went through the media; however, this was a development that was inevitable after the December Indigo Crisis for many close Industry watchers. His removal almost 90 days after the crisis, was a bit like closing the stable doors after the horse had bolted.

Perhaps Pieter and Indigo had missed a trick way back in December of not being able to control the media narrative. As an upstanding aviation leader, one almost expected him to offer his res-

METRIC	BEFORE ELBERS	AFTER ELBERS
MARKET CAP	₹85000-90000 Crores	₹168,000 crore
FLEET SIZE	279-300 AIRCRAFT	440 AIRCRAFT
PAX CARRIED ANNUALLY	69 MILLION	112-118 MILLION
PAX LOAD FACTOR	73-75%	84-86%
ASKMS	110-120 BILLION ANN (APRX)	180-200 BILL ANN (EST)
OTP	78-82% TYPICAL RANGE	74-76 POST DISRUPTION
PROFITABILITY	RECOVERING FROM COVID LOSSES	STRONG PROFITS - DECLINE IN 2026

ignation and shoulder responsibility, in the great tradition of other aviation leaders such as Gary Kelly-Southwest, Allen Joyce-Qantas, Dennis Muilenburg-Boeing, Kim E-Bae-Jeju Air; Dave Calhoun-Boeing; Sebastian Mikosz-Kenya Airways or Akbar Al baker of Qatar who offered to step down for the Airbus grounding issue.

I personally would not be surprised if Pieter had offered to quit privately, but the truth will never be known. Had that occurred and Pieter offered to step down, it may have endeared him to the Indian public, the Government and his own board, who would have deflected their own mistakes. Sadly, that didn't happen, and the owners didn't speak up then, and Pieter was left holding the can and apologising to the nation for the Indigo crisis.

So how will history judge Pieter Elbers and his stint at Indigo?

Let's look at how Indigo grew from the day that Pieter Elbers entered Indigo and almost doubled Market Capitlisation, Fleet size increased,

number of passengers up by 50 per cent, Passenger Load factor up by 15 per cent, ASKMS because flat post disruption and it was profitable until the December disruption.

We also examined Indigos performance vis-à-vis global airlines, and found that Elbers had brought Indigo into a unique league. **Globally Indigo is in a league of the best, with an operating margin of 20 per cent-25 per cent** a comparison on par with Ryan Air (20 per cent) and Southwest (8-12 per cent), which is significantly higher than most global airlines. Indigo is also on par with global leaders in terms of weekly ASK capacities, reflecting its massive domestic network

There were some morale issues with the Pilots at Indigo though Senior Pilots stated "Pieter was a nice guy, and has been made the fall guy" others breathed a sigh of relief that this period was over and they could now move on to grow further, the fact is that there is an HR issue which Indigo will have to address quickly to boost morale.

By any matrix, Pieter will go down as one of the more successful Aviation leaders in India, but we also need to look at the hemorrhaging of the last 3 months. During the last 3 months, Indigo has lost approx. 57,0000+ crores of market cap. (Share price on 1/12/26 was 5916, closed on 10/3/26 at 4355) Stock price had plunged 35 per cent since its 52 weeks high and a 4.9 per cent loss of domestic market share. That would have alarmed the MD & the Board, between December and March they lost close to double the market capitalisation that their initial IPO was worth.

REBUILDING INDIGO

Indigo is not broken, merely bruised. It is an Indian brand that stands for excellence globally. Rahul Bhatia the founder & managing Director will have to have all hands on deck, to reorient the Indigo way, back to his own vision. Customer confidence will have to be rebuilt and route rationalisation needs to be implemented. Breakneck growth will have to take a back seat for the next quarter until they stabilise operations, rediscover OTP that made them the first choice.

Indigo will have to reorient a bit to become nimble to cope with international exigencies like the Iran war & should delineate international & domestic operations. Regaining domestic market share is key and passenger focus is important to take on a rejuvenated Air India and Akasa Airlines in the Indian skies as it also flies globally with wide bodies. The market has today greeted the change of guard with cautious optimism, As Rahul Bhatia invokes Bollywood and says "Main Hoon Na", the future beckons.

Sanjay Lazar is CEO Avialaz consultants & an Aviation expert. He is @sjlazars on @x

SMPP secures additional order for 10,000 bullet proof jackets

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Progress on On-Time Execution of 40,000 BPJ Order for Paramilitary Forces. SMPP Limited, a leading Indian manufacturer of advanced ballistic protection systems for soldiers and weapon platforms across land, air, and sea, is progressing with the on-time execution of an order for 40,000 Bullet Proof Jackets (BPJs) for India's paramilitary forces, including the Border Security Force (BSF), Central Industrial Security Force (CISF), and Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB). This order is in addition to the advanced BPJs SMPP supplied to the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) and the Indian Army, designed to offer protection against armor-piercing bullets.

Out of the total order of 40,000 BPJs, approximately 28,000 units have already been delivered successfully. The remaining jackets are scheduled for delivery in the next financial year, in accordance with contractual timelines.

In recognition of SMPP's timely delivery and consistent product quality,



the paramilitary forces placed an additional order for approximately 10,000 Bullet Proof Jackets. With this new order, the cumulative quantity rises to 50,000 units.

SMPP's Bullet Proof Jackets are designed and manufactured in India to meet stringent ballistic and operational requirements. The jackets are engineered to enhance survivability and operational readiness for personnel deployed in challenging and high-risk

environments. Ashish Kansal, CEO of SMPP Limited, said that executing this large order reflects the company's manufacturing strength, robust quality systems, and its deep commitment to safeguarding the lives of those who serve the nation.

He added that the company remains focused on delivering world-class protective solutions that support operational effectiveness while contributing to India's goal of self-reliance in defence manufacturing.

Beyond personal protection systems, SMPP is expanding its capabilities across key defence segments. The company is developing manufacturing capacity for ammunition for 155 mm artillery guns, as well as drones and drone ammunition. These initiatives aim to further strengthen India's indigenous defence manufacturing ecosystem.

Through innovation, manufacturing scale, and consistent execution, SMPP continues to play a vital role in protecting India's security forces while advancing the vision of self-reliance in defence production.

Himanta distributes ₹131 crore to 12,976 Assam entrepreneurs

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Wednesday distributed the second tranche of financial assistance under the Mukhya Mantri Atmanirbhar Asom Abhijan (CMAAA) 1.0, disbursing over ₹131 crore to 12,976 successful entrepreneurs at a function held in Khanapara.

Addressing the gathering, the Chief Minister described the occasion as a decisive moment for the initiative, aimed at transforming Assam's youth into job creators.

He noted that while there is often a perception that Government assistance is under-utilised, many beneficiaries of the first tranche



CM Himanta Biswa Sarma dedicated, launched and laid the foundation for a gamut of major projects worth ₹2,109 crore in Karbi Anglong

have progressed significantly, becoming eligible for bank loans and the Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana.

Highlighting the State's demographic dividend, Sarma remarked that approximately seven lakh youth join the workforce in Assam annually. "If Governments fail to create

employment opportunities beyond Government jobs, unemployment could lead to frustration," he warned, adding that the State has already provided 1.6 lakh Government jobs while exploring alternative avenues.

The Chief Minister emphasised that Assam's economy

has surged from ₹3.5 lakh crore to ₹8.5 lakh crore in five years, bolstered by upcoming projects like the Jagiroad semiconductor facility and the Namrup fertiliser plant. He further announced that the State would bear part of the bank loan interest for entrepreneurs who utilise their capital properly.

Industries, Commerce and Public Enterprises Minister Bimal Borah, MLAs Atul Bora, Ramendra Narayan Kalita, Siddhartha Bhattacharya, Diganta Kalita and Hemanga Thakuria along with Guwahati Mayor Mrigen Sarania, Additional Chief Secretary JB Ekka and several senior officials and dignitaries were present at the programme.

Assam hosts state-level Viksit Bharat Youth Parliament

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

The State Level Viksit Bharat Youth Parliament (VBYP) 2026 was inaugurated on Wednesday at the Assam Legislative Assembly in Dispur, marking a significant platform for the State's young minds to engage in democratic dialogue and public policy.

Organised by Mera Yuva Bharat (MY Bharat), Assam, in collaboration with the National Service Scheme (NSS), the two-day event brings together youth representatives from across the State. Participants, having qualified through rigorous district-level competitions, are presenting their perspectives on the theme, "Union Budget 2026: Strengthening the Indian Youth's Path towards Viksit Bharat 2047."

"The event, scheduled for March 11 and 12, serves as a qualifier for the national stage. According to the organisers, the top three participants from this session will be selected to represent Assam at the upcoming National Level Youth Parliament in New



Delhi. The inaugural session was graced by several dignitaries, including Kausar Jamil Hilaly, Special Secretary to the Government of Assam, Sports & Youth Welfare Department, and Pradip Handique, Joint Secretary, Assam Legislative Assembly Secretariat.

Also present were D Carthigueane, Regional Director of the NSS Regional Directorate, Guwahati; Dinobondhu Saha, Joint Director, MY Bharat; and Jangjilong, Youth Officer, Regional Directorate of NSS, Guwahati.

Indian Potash to revive Badamba Cooperative Sugar Mill in Odisha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Badamba Cooperative Sugar Mill in Odisha, which has remained shut for more than 15 years, is set to be revived, bringing renewed hope to thousands of farmers in the region. Indian Potash Limited (IPL) has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Government of Odisha for modernisation & expansion of Badamba Sugar Mill with an estimated investment to ₹360 crore.

The MoU was signed by Dr PS Gahlaut, Managing Director, Indian Potash Limited, and Rajesh Prabhakar Patil, IAS, Commissioner-cum-Secretary, Department of Cooperation, Government of Odisha in august presence of Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit



Shah. The occasion was graced by the presence of Union Minister of Education, Dharmendra Pradhan; Deputy Chief Minister Odisha, Pravati Parida; Deputy Chief Minister of Odisha, Kanak Vardhan Singh Deo and MP Bhubaneswar Aparajita Sharanagi.

As per the MoU, the

Badamba Cooperative Sugar Mill is expected to commence operation within one year and will have a capacity of 3,500 TCD (tonnes cane per day). It will also consist of a 16 MW co-generation power plant, a 10 tonnes per day Bio-CNG plant, and a state-of-the-art cold storage facility.

The project is expected to

directly benefit around 10,000 farmers of the Badamba Block of Cuttack district by reviving sugarcane cultivation in the State, enhancing farmer income and generating employment in the region.

Based on the successful turnaround of 3 sick sugar mills in Gujarat, IPL now under the guidance of the Union Cooperation Ministry took up the project for the revival of Badamba Cooperative Sugar Mill. It roped in National Federation of Cooperative Sugar Factories Limited and SBI Capital Markets Limited for a detailed technical and financial feasibility study.

As part of the MoU, the Odisha Government will provide 112 acres of land on a long-term lease basis to IPL for the establishment of the mill and associated infrastructure. The revival of the

sugar mill is aimed at improving the income of farmers by promoting sugarcane cultivation, which is increasingly being recognised as an energy crop due to its potential for producing ethanol, power, and bio-fuels. The project is expected to stimulate rural economic activity, generate employment, and encourage farmers in the region to take up sugarcane cultivation once again.

In recent years, IPL has played an important role in the revival of three sick sugar mills in the State of Gujarat, successfully restoring their operations through modernisation and improved management practices. The revival of the Badamba Cooperative Sugar Mill will follow a similar approach, combining technological modernisation with cooperative participation to ensure long-term sustainability.

Garuda Aerospace partners with Airbus Helicopters to acquire Flexrotor drone systems

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Garuda Aerospace has signed a contract with Airbus Helicopters to acquire up to 18 units of the Airbus Flexrotor UAS, marking a major step in the Indian drone company's strategy to expand its global unmanned aerial systems (UAS) leasing and services portfolio.

The agreement will enable Garuda Aerospace to integrate the long-endurance Flexrotor systems into its global fleet and offer them to customers through both dry lease and wet lease operational models. The drones will support a wide range of

civil, industrial, and para-public missions including infrastructure inspection, oil and gas pipeline monitoring, powerline inspection, railway and highway monitoring, disaster response, wildfire surveillance, law enforcement, and search-and-rescue operations.

Speaking on the partnership, Agnishwar Jayaprakash, Founder and CEO of Garuda Aerospace, described the deal as a significant milestone in the company's international expansion strategy.

"Our partnership with Airbus Helicopters to integrate the Flexrotor into our global leasing portfolio marks a major step in scaling our

global drone services," Jayaprakash said. "Having manufactured and sold over 5,000 drones and served more than 500 enterprise and Government clients globally, we are strengthening our product portfolio to deliver high-endurance, mission-critical unmanned solutions for demanding operations worldwide."

Garuda Aerospace currently holds approximately 30 per cent market share in India's agricultural drone segment and has accumulated more than one million cumulative flight hours across its operations in agriculture, defence, and industrial sectors.



According to Olivier Michalon, Executive Vice President for Global Business at Airbus Helicopters, the partnership will help expand the global deployment of the Flexrotor platform.

"We are very proud to partner with Garuda as they have selected the Flexrotor to support the development of their global UAS portfolio," Michalon said.

The Flexrotor is a versatile light tactical unmanned aerial system designed for long-endurance missions and advanced sensor integration. With a maximum takeoff weight of about 25 kilograms (55 pounds), the platform can remain airborne for 12 to

14 hours in typical operational configurations, making it suitable for intelligence, surveillance, monitoring, and data-collection missions across large operational areas. One of the system's key advantages is its expeditionary capability and minimal operational footprint. The drone can autonomously launch and recover from confined land areas or maritime platforms without flight decks, requiring only a 3.7-by-3.7-metre launch and recovery area. Its modular design also enables rapid deployment, allowing the system to transition from transport configuration to operational readi-

ness in less than 30 minutes.

With the addition of the Flexrotor platform, Garuda Aerospace aims to further strengthen its global unmanned aviation ecosystem and enhance its ability to provide high-endurance aerial intelligence and mission support services to industries including energy, infrastructure, agriculture, defence, and public safety.

The partnership represents another milestone for Garuda Aerospace, one of the world's fastest-growing drone technology companies, as it continues expanding its footprint in global drone services and advanced unmanned aviation solutions.

BRIEFLY

Gujarat Giants appoint Sehrawat as head coach ahead of PKL



Former India international Ranbir Singh Sehrawat has been appointed as the head coach of Gujarat Giants ahead of the upcoming season of the Pro Kabaddi League (PKL). Sehrawat brings 11 seasons of PKL experience, including one title and six play-off appearances. An Arjuna Award recipient, Sehrawat has guided Indian Railways to multiple national titles and was part of India's gold medal-winning team at the 1990 Asian Games. Sehrawat is one of the most experienced coaches in the league, having been associated with the PKL since its launch in 2014. As a player, Sehrawat represented India in several international tournaments, including the Asian Kabaddi Championship (1988), the South Asian Games (1989) and the 1990 Asian Games, where he served as vice-captain. Speaking on his appointment, Sehrawat said: "I'm delighted to return to the Pro Kabaddi League and grateful to Adani Sportsline for this opportunity. Gujarat Giants has a strong mix of young talent and experienced players and I look forward to working with the team as we aim for the title."

Mexico grants visas to some Iraq players for World Cup qualifier



Mexico's Ministry of Foreign Affairs has begun granting visas to players from Iraq's national team ahead of the World Cup intercontinental qualifier scheduled March 31 in Monterrey. The Iraqi team is facing logistical issues because of disruptions caused by the Iran war. "On March 8, some players were processed at the Mexican Embassy in Saudi Arabia, and tomorrow other people are scheduled to be processed at the Embassy in Qatar," the Ministry of Foreign Affairs reported in a statement late Monday. The government did not specify the names or how many players were granted visas. Iraq is set to face the winner of the match between Suriname and Bolivia for a spot in the World Cup – to be in the group with France, Norway and Senegal. Mexico, the United States and Canada are co-hosting the World Cup, which begins June 11. Iraq head coach Graham Arnold has asked FIFA to postpone the intercontinental qualifier. With Iraqi airspace closed, Arnold's squad – containing predominantly players from the domestic league – is unable to fully gather. Mexico does not have an embassy in Iraq.

Mandaviya leads push for F1 revival in India, meets FMSCI officials

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Taking another step in his push to revive Formula One in the country, Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya held a meeting with the Federation of Motor Sports Clubs of India (FMSCI) to discuss a framework that would create a "strong pipeline" of drivers and technicians.

The meeting was held in the national capital recently and was also attended by sports secretary Hari Ranjan Rao, joint secretary (sports) Kunal and FMSCI council member Vicky Chandhok among others.

Mandaviya had visited the Buddh International Circuit in Greater Noida, which had

hosted F1 races from 2011 to 2013 before taxation issues caused an abrupt end to the event. "We discussed and look at the possibility of bringing Formula One and MotoGP to India. The ministry is very keen and very clear that since India is the most advancing country in technology, the best sport should come here," Chandhok, who was at the helm of FMSCI when the races were last held, told PTI.

"They wanted to understand the challenges and they wanted to speak to FMSCI and see our organising skills. The minister and the entire ministry are very happy to support us," he added. That Mandaviya is keen to revive the race was

Puligilla, Sherif set for WRC Safari Rally 2026

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Naivasha (Kenya)

Ace Indian rally driver Naveen Puligilla and co-driver Musa Sherif are gearing up for their toughest challenge as they aim to repeat their WRC3 podium finish in the third round of the FIA World Rally Championship (WRC), the iconic WRC Safari Rally Kenya 2026.

The celebrated duo, who secured a podium in their class at the WRC Rally Saudi Arabia last November, will tackle the rough terrains around Naivasha for a third consecutive time when the demanding African event

runs from March 12 to 15.

Fresh from his victory at the Nashik rally that secured him the 3T class National championship title, Hyderabad's Puligilla will compete in the WRC3 category driving a Ford Fiesta Rally3 prepared and serviced by Africa Eco Sports Nairobi.

Seasoned navigator from Kasargod, Sherif, who has over 33 years of rally experience, will handle pace notes for the Indian driver. The pair made history in 2025 by becoming the first Indian duo to score a podium finish in any WRC class when it finished second in WRC3 at Rally Saudi Arabia. Having



experienced the unforgiving African terrain last year, Puligilla and Sherif return

with valuable knowledge and a clear objective, to conquer the fesh-fesh dust, massive

Champions League: Alphonso Davies distraught after injury

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Munich

Alphonso Davies covered his face with his shirt as he left the field with an injury in Bayern Munich's game against Atalanta in the Champions League on Tuesday, raising questions about the Canadian star's availability for the World Cup. That and other injuries to forward Jamal Musiala and goalkeeper Jonas Urbig overshadowed a statement 6-1 win for Bayern and left coach Vincent Kompany facing difficult tactical decisions.

Kompany suggested Davies' injury might be "not so bad" in post-game comments on TV and expressed faith in Bayern's depth.

"It's a shame but I told the guys I have full trust in our



squad," he told broadcaster Prime Video, adding of Davies, "we'll have to get through some games without him." The night started with doubts whether Bayern could get the job done without a fully fit

of his first-choice left back, a key forward and Bayern's top two goalkeepers.

Davies in distress ahead of World Cup: Davies sank into a squatting position on the field after an apparent non-contact injury while playing the ball with Bayern leading 6-0 in the 70th minute. He seemed in distress immediately, covering his face and waving his arms in a gesture of frustration.

Teammates gathered around the Canada left-back to shield him from view before he was helped off the field by Bayern Munich staff, the neck of his shirt pulled up to over his face. Davies seemed to be in tears on the sideline as he was comforted by Kompany.

Davies was a key player for Canada at its return to the

World Cup in 2022 and captained the team at the 2024 Copa America but has struggled with injuries. He didn't play for Bayern until December this season after tearing an ACL in March 2025 in his most recent game for Canada. Canada is co-hosting the World Cup in June and July with the United States and Mexico.

Musiala and Urbig injuries would pose Bayern problems: Bayern was cruising after Musiala scored the sixth goal and it threatened to test the all-time records for biggest wins in Champions League knockout games when Dayot Upamecano headed against the post soon after. The game ended with more concerns for Kompany as Musiala, who only returned to action in January after a

broken leg at last year's Club World Cup, limped off in added time after earlier seemingly struggling with an ankle issue. Kompany had already used all his substitutions so Bayern was down to 10 players when Atalanta launched a counterattack to score a consolation goal.

That came with more pain for Bayern as Urbig, in for injured first-choice goalkeeper Manuel Neuer, collided with Atalanta's Nikola Krstovic and seemed badly shaken as he left the field. The one bright spot was a sign Kane may return soon ahead of Bayern's game against Bayer Leverkusen in the Bundesliga on Saturday. Kane was "very close" to starting against Atalanta, Kompany said, "but then it was 5-0 and he was very far away."

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Iran welcome to compete in US: Trump assures FIFA

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Miami

FIFA said Tuesday night that it anticipates Iran's national team will be allowed to come to the United States, even with war going on between the countries, and compete in the World Cup that begins in about three months.

Iran is scheduled to play in Inglewood, California, against New Zealand on June 15 and Belgium on June 21 before finishing group play against Egypt in Seattle on June 26. The U.S. is hosting the tournament with Canada and Mexico from June 11 to July 19. Iranian officials have suggested recently that its country's participation is in some doubt because of the war. Last week, US President



Donald Trump said "I really don't care" if Iran takes part in the 48-nation tournament.

FIFA President Gianni Infantino said he met with Trump on Tuesday night "to discuss the status of preparations" for the tournament and received assurances that Iran would be permitted to come to the US. "We also

spoke about the current situation in Iran, and the fact that the Iranian team has qualified to participate in the FIFA World Cup 2026," Infantino said in an Instagram post.

"During the discussions, President Trump reiterated that the Iranian team is, of course, welcome to compete in the tournament in the United States."

Infantino has a close relationship with Trump, who was given FIFA's inaugural peace prize — an award that many believe the soccer governing body created with Trump in mind.

Fans from Iran were already banned from entering the US in the first iteration of the travel ban announced by the Trump

administration. "We all need an event like the FIFA World Cup to bring people together now more than ever," Infantino said, adding that he thanks Trump "for his support." Earlier this week, FIFA's World Cup chief operating officer said the tournament is "too big" to be postponed because of global turmoil caused by the US and Israeli war against Iran.

The CEO, Heimo Schirgi, said FIFA continues to closely monitor the Iran war.

"We basically take it day by day and at some stage we will have a resolution," Schirgi said. "And the World Cup will go on obviously, right? The World Cup is too big and we hope that everyone can participate that has qualified."

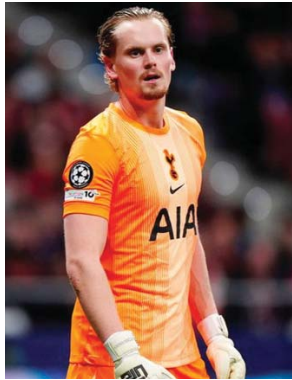
Nightmarish debut for Kinsky

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Madrid

For Tottenham goalkeeper Antonin Kinsky, it was perhaps the most humiliating Champions League debut of all time. Two mis-kicks. Three goals conceded. And substituted inside 17 minutes.

No wonder the 22-year-old Czech player looked inconsolable as he walked down the tunnel at Metropolitano Stadium, with two teammates catching him up to offer their sympathies.

Handed his first start since October and only his third appearance all season, Kinsky endured a nightmarish start to the round-of-16 match at Atletico Madrid, which wound up winning 5-2 on



Tuesday. To begin with, he slipped and botched a clearance in the sixth minute, the ball going straight to an Atletico player and — two passes later — leading to Marcos Llorente slotting past Kinsky to open the scoring. Then, moments after

Antoine Griezmann made it 2-0 for Atletico, Kinsky attempted a first-time pass out of his area with his left foot but mis-kicked again. The ball dribbled into the path of Julian Alvarez, who had the simple task of slotting the ball into an empty net. Tottenham was 3-0 down after 15 minutes and Kinsky lay face down, with both hands on his head. He got up but stayed knelt down, one arm across his knee.

It wasn't long before he was pulled by Igor Tudor, the under-pressure Tottenham interim manager whose bold call to leave out first-choice goalkeeper Guglielmo Vicario had spectacularly backfired.

"It was necessary to do this, preserve the guy and the team," Tudor said.

sions (with FMSCI delegation) focused on creating structured pathways for athletes, engineers, and technical professionals associated with the sport," said a Sports Ministry source.

"Dr Mandaviya called for developing a comprehensive framework that positions motorsports at the intersection of sport and India's rapidly growing automotive and engineering sectors," he added. **Meeting with F1 bosses in pipeline?:** It is also reliably learnt that the FMSCI has offered to facilitate a meeting between Mandaviya and the Formula One management, which is headed by former Ferrari team boss Stefano Domenicali.

India is trying to position itself as a global sporting hub and has already won the 2030 Commonwealth Games hosting rights in Ahmedabad, the city that is also in the race to become an Olympic host in 2036. "Expanding the range of sporting disciplines

and strengthening high-performance ecosystems are key steps," said the ministry source. During the meeting with the FMSCI delegation, the minister also discussed the prospect of building professional racing platforms for greater exposure and opportunities to Indian drivers. "With growing institutional attention and the presence of world-class racing infrastructure, motorsports can gradually regain prominence within India's sporting landscape," said the source, while talking about the minister's vision. The iconic Narain Karthikeyan was India's first Formula One driver and raced for Jordan (2005) and HRT (2011-2012) at the peak of his career.



second leg at Anfield and Barcelona needed Lamine Yamal's penalty with the last kick of the game to rescue a 1-1 draw at Newcastle.

Goals galore: Even without the prolific Kane, Bayern all but sealed its place in the last eight with a dominant win at

Atalanta. England captain Kane has scored 47 goals this season for club and country but was only fit enough to make the bench and in his absence Michael Olise scored twice. Serge Gnabry and Nicolas Jackson each scored and set up goals. Josip

Stanisic and Jamal Musiala were also on target for the German champion. Tottenham endured a nightmare start in Madrid, with backup keeper Antonin Kinsky substituted in the 17th minute after his mis-takes led to two of Atletico's three early goals.

Spurs coach Tudor had opted to leave out first choice Vicario - a decision that backfired spectacularly. Kinsky was making his Champions League debut and his slip and mis-kick in the sixth gave Marcos Llorente the chance to open the scoring.

Antoine Griezmann made it 2-0 for Atletico before Kinsky mis-kicked again and Julian Alvarez slotted into an

empty net. Kinsky looked inconsolable when he was replaced by Vicario, who conceded just five minutes after coming on — Robin Le Normand scoring Atletico's fourth. "We knew how to take advantage of our opponents' mistakes to gain a good lead, and now we go into the second leg with a three-goal advantage," Alvarez said.

Spurs rallied, but it will take an unlikely comeback in the second leg to avoid elimination. "We gave away three goals at the start, and then it became very difficult for us," Tudor said.

According stats provider Opta, this was the first time in Tottenham's history that it has lost six games in a row.

ICC hits back at criticism of team travel arrangements

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Dubai

The ICC on Wednesday expressed sympathy for the international players stranded in India after the T20 World Cup but lambasted “uninformed and unhelpful” suggestions that “anything other than safety” is driving the travel plans that have been thrown haywire by the West Asia conflict.

The war, which began with the American and Israeli bombing of Iran last month, has led to closure of the air space over Gulf, leaving flight schedules in chaos.

The ICC said it empathises with the stranded players, specifically from South Africa and the West Indies, but

“safety, feasibility and welfare” of the teams is being carefully considered while drawing up alternate routes. Giving details of the travel schedule, the ICC said the South African contingent will begin departing for home on Wednesday night and all the members are expected to leave within the next 36 hours. Nine West Indies players have already left, while the remaining 16 have been booked on commercial flights departing India within the next 24 hours, said the ICC. This was after their charter flight scheduled to take off from Kolkata was cancelled due to logistical issues. The ICC drew criticism from former England captain Michael Vaughan and South



African star David Miller insinuated that England players were given better travel arrangements as they were able to leave within a day of their semifinal ouster. Before this, West Indies coach Darren Sammy had expressed frustration at the

lack of updates from the world body. The ICC hit back without naming anyone specifically.

“The ICC rejects any suggestion that these decisions have been driven by anything other than safety, feasibility and welfare. Suggestions other-

wise across a variety of media platforms from people uninformed of the situation are as unhelpful as they are incorrect,” said cricket’s world governing body.

“There is no link between arrangements made in the cases of South Africa and the West Indies and those made previously for England or any other nation, which arose from separate circumstances, routing options and different travel conditions,” it added. West Indies and South Africa played their final games in Kolkata on March 1 and March 4 respectively. The ICC’s airline partner is Emirates and they are unable to operate due to shutdown of the Dubai airspace. “We understand that players,

coaches, support staff and their families who have completed their ICC Men’s T20 World Cup 2026 campaigns are anxious to return home.

“That they have not yet been able to do so is a source of genuine frustration, and the International Cricket Council shares that frustration,” the world body said.

“The delay is the direct result of the ongoing crisis across the Gulf region, which has caused widespread and continuing disruption to international air travel, including airspace closures, missile warnings, re-routing constraints, as well as the cancellation and rescheduling of both commercial and charter flights at short notice,” it added.

PSG president Al-Khelaifi left stranded in Qatar



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Paris

Paris Saint-Germain president Nasser Al-Khelaifi has been left stranded in Qatar amid the war in the Middle East. Al-Khelaifi has not been able to fly out of Doha for more than a week, a person with knowledge of the situation told The Associated Press on Tuesday. The person spoke on the condition on anonymity because they were not authorised to speak publicly.

Flights in and out of the Middle East have been impacted by the Iran war, which began the US and Israeli strikes on February 28. Al-Khelaifi has been trying to return to Paris ahead of PSG’s Champions League round-of-16 match against Chelsea on Wednesday. He was trying to get a flight out of Doha on Tuesday evening or Wednesday morning, the person said.

With only limited space available on commercial flights, passengers have been left waiting until close to takeoff if they have been approved to fly. The ripple

effects of the war have spread across the Middle East and beyond with Iran launching retaliatory strikes in the Gulf states. It has upended travel across the region, stranding hundreds of thousands of people. Airports in the Gulf serve as critical hubs connecting travelers going to Europe, Africa and Asia. Airspace closures have seen many carriers forced to either cancel flights or shift to longer routes.

Last week US citizens described frustrations and growing fear as they encountered closed airports and canceled flights. But there have been signs that flight disruptions are easing. The British government said Tuesday that the number of commercial flights from the United Arab Emirates to the UK was returning to normal levels. The Foreign Office said 32 flights operated from Dubai to Britain on Monday and another 36 were scheduled Tuesday. The British government has also operated a handful of chartered flights from Oman and Dubai, with more than 45,000 UK citizens returning from the Gulf since the conflict began.

Asian Weightlifting Championships postponed due to West Asia conflict

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

The Asian Weightlifting Championships, scheduled to be held in Ahmedabad in April, has been postponed to May due to the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

The continental event, originally slated for April 1 to 10, has been pushed back by over a month and will now be held from May 12 to 17.

The Asian Weightlifting Federation (AWF) said the rescheduling was done to ensure the “safe and smooth participation” of all delegations. “Due to the current situation affecting the Middle



East and the Gulf region, the 2026 AWF Asian Senior Weightlifting Championships have been rescheduled,” the AWF said in a statement.

“In order to ensure the safe and smooth participation of all delegations, the

competition will now take place from 12 to 17 May 2026,” the statement added.

The ongoing Middle East conflict that began with US and Israeli strikes on Iran has led to the closure of airspace across parts of the Gulf region.

Sabalenka credits her new dog with providing mental health support

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Indian Wells (USA)

Aryna Sabalenka credits her new puppy, Ash, with providing “mental health support” as she continues to rack up victories and maintain her standing as the top-ranked player in women’s tennis.

Sabalenka brought her Cavalier King Charles Spaniel to a post-match interview on the Tennis Channel following her round-of-16 victory over Naomi Osaka on Wednesday at the BNP Paribas Open.

“I feel like I’m much more settled, calm, more in control,” Sabalenka, who has



a history of emotional, on-court outbursts, said while Tennis Channel commentators held and petted her dog. “Whenever I feel like going crazy on my team, I just pet Ash and I feel better.”

Sabalenka, who also recently announced her engagement to Brazilian businessman Georgios Frangulis, shared news of

her puppy in a social media post last week, introducing Ash as a “new addition” to Team Tiger, her support team of coaches, trainers and other staff.

She spoke more about Ash following her 6-2, 6-4 victory over Osaka. Sabalenka said she had a deal with coach Anton Dubrov that if she won last year’s US Open, she would get a dog.

She also considered getting a Dachshund, but decided on a spaniel because “my mom had a spaniel and I loved that dog,” adding that spaniels make good “family dogs.”

Babar Azam opts out of Pakistan’s National T20 Championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Karachi

Former Pakistan captain and batting star Babar Azam has opted out of the National T20 Championship to focus on correcting the “flaws in his technique” ahead of the Pakistan Super League starting March 26.

Dropped from the away one-day series against Bangladesh after a forgettable T20 World Cup, Babar’s name was included in the Lahore Whites squad for the National T20 Championship currently underway in Peshawar. But it has emerged that he will not take part in the domestic



competition and is instead working with some coaches on his batting.

There is no word on who these coaches are but a

source close to the Pakistan Cricket Board said Babar and the team management had decided he should work on his “batting technique flaws” instead of playing in the national event.

Babar will appear in the PSL 11 for Peshawar Zalmi and open the batting for them.

The batter, who was once ranked top in the ICC charts in all formats, has struggled to repeat his old form since 2024 and was dropped from the final Super Eight match against Sri Lanka in the T20 World Cup that India won.

He has not played any domestic competition since 2020 aside from the PSL.

World Cup winning India receive ₹25 crore as prize money

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Dubai

Champions India received 2,639,423 (approx ₹25 crore), the biggest share from the prize money pool after winning the men’s T20 World Cup at home as the ICC on Wednesday announced the distribution of a record USD 11.25 million players’ prize fund following the tournament’s conclusion.

India beat New Zealand by a comprehensive 96-run margin to lift their second successive trophy.

The total purse reflects the significant increase in ICC tournament prize money introduced in 2024, aimed at boosting financial rewards for players and supporting the global growth of cricket.



Runners-up New Zealand national cricket team earned USD 1,422,692 (₹13 crore approx), while semi-finalists South Africa and England received INR 9.24 crore and

USD 8.96 crore respectively. Among other top finishers, West Indies cricket team were awarded USD 538,269, while Pakistan team which played all its matches in Sri

Lanka received USD 522,692. Further down the distribution list, Zimbabwe national cricket team were allocated USD 491,538 and Sri Lanka received USD 475,962. The

group of Afghanistan, Australia and United States which was eliminated at the Super 8s stage each earned USD 309,808. Meanwhile, Scotland received USD 278,654, and Ireland took home USD 271,731. Four more teams – Italy, Netherlands, United Arab Emirates and Nepal – each received USD 256,154. Finally, Canada, Namibia and Oman were each awarded USD 225,000.

The ICC said the prize-money distribution highlights its ongoing effort to increase financial incentives for players and strengthen cricket’s development across its member nations participating in global tournaments and supporting the growth of the game across its member nations.

ICC T20I rankings: Abhishek-Kishan make it 1-2 in batting

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Dubai

Swashbuckler Ishan Kishan rode on his superb T20 World Cup campaign to move up to a career-high second spot, trailing top-ranked Abhishek Sharma by a mere four points in the latest ICC list for T20I batters published on Wednesday.

Abhishek held on to his lead at the top following his quick-fire half-century against New Zealand in the T20 World Cup final, while fellow left-hander Ishan Kishan is now his closest rival after he moved up two places to second overall after his 317



runs in the tournament.

Kishan (871 points) earned a new career-high rating to trail Abhishek (875 points) by just four rating points,



while New Zealander Tim Seifert (up four places to sixth) and England’s Jacob Bethell (up 17 rungs to 16th) also improved to the best

marks of their career following some dominant knocks during the T20 World Cup.

However, there was a change in the T20I bowlers’ ranking list, with India spinner Varun Chakravarthy losing the premier position to Afghanistan spinner Rashid Khan following the completion of the global event.

Chakravarthy (740 points), whose mystery was solved by most of the top global batters, is now second to Rashid (753), whose team Afghanistan exited the tournament at the group league stage. Chakravarthy dropped to second as Rashid claimed the No.1 ranking despite not

playing any matches over the last week, while Adil Rashid (up one spot to fourth), Jasprit Bumrah (up one place to sixth) and Axar Patel (up six slots to 17th) were rewarded for some decent efforts during the T20 World Cup with some eye-catching gains.

The race at the top of the rankings for T20I all-rounders also remained tight, with Zimbabwe captain Sikandar Raza and India star Hardik Pandya obtaining new career-high ratings this week while occupying the top two spots in the category. Shivam Dube, who was ninth, has dropped two places to be 11th in the latest list.

Bhambri-Goransson pair reaches Indian Wells quarterfinals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Indian Wells (USA)

India’s top doubles player Yuki Bhambri and his partner Goran Goransson advanced to the quarterfinals of the men’s doubles event at the Indian Wells Masters after registering a straight-set win over the pair of Sander Arends and Jiri Lehecka.

Bhambri and Goransson produced a solid performance to defeat Arends and Lehecka 6-4 6-4 in the pre-quarterfinal clash that lasted



one hour and 14 minutes. They did not face any break point in the match and broke their rivals twice.

The Indo-Swedish pair maintained control through most of the match, securing a crucial break in each set to

seal the contest in straight sets. Bhambri and Goransson will take on Alexander Erler of Austria and Andrea Vavassori from Italy in the last-eight stage of the prestigious ATP Masters 1000 tournament.

Most of Iranian women’s soccer team leaves Australia after declining last-minute airport asylum offers

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Gold Coast

The Iranian women’s soccer team left Australia minus seven of its members after tearful protests of their departure outside Sydney Airport and frantic final efforts inside the terminal by Australian officials, who sought to ensure the women understood they were being offered asylum.

As the team’s flight time drew nearer and they passed through security late Tuesday, each woman was taken aside to meet alone with officials who explained

through interpreters that they could choose not to return to Iran.

Seven women ultimately accepted humanitarian visas allowing them to remain permanently in Australia after what Australian Home Affairs Minister Tony Burke described as “emotional” meetings. One has since changed her mind, underscoring the tense and precarious nature of their decisions. “In Australia, people are able to change their mind,” said Burke, who had hours earlier posted photos of the seven women granted humanitarian visas to his

social media accounts, their identities clearly visible.

Asylum drama captured national attention: It was a dramatic conclusion to an episode that has gripped Australia since the Iranian team’s first game at the Asian Cup soccer tournament, when they remained silent during their national anthem. The players sang the anthem before subsequent games and haven’t publicly disclosed their views or explained their actions.

Their silence was cast as a gesture of defiance or protest by some, and an act of mourning by others.



“When those players were silent at the start of their first match in Australia, that silence was heard as a roar all

around the world,” Burke said. “We responded by saying, the invitation is there. In Australia you can be safe.”

The team arrived in Australia last month, before the Iran war began February 28. Iran was knocked out of the tournament over the weekend and the squad faced the prospect of returning to a country under bombardment.

The women’s fate captured international attention as Iranian Australian groups warned they could face dire consequences from Iran’s theocratic government for failing to sing the anthem, even as the players remained silent on the gesture’s meaning or their own concerns about returning. There

was further outrage in Australia on Wednesday after news outlets published a photo that appeared to show a woman being led by the wrist by a teammate to the bus bound for the airport, another squad member’s hand at her shoulder.

US President Donald Trump waded into the matter Monday, criticizing the Australian government for not offering the women asylum. It emerged the next day that discussions between Australian officials and the women had already been unfolding privately.

Meanwhile, an Iranian offi-

cial rejected suggestions that the women weren’t safe to go home. “Iran welcomes its children with open arms and the government guarantees their security,” Iranian first Vice President Mohammad Reza Aref said Tuesday.

Iranian state TV said the country’s football federation had asked international soccer bodies to review what it called Trump’s “direct political interference in football,” warning such remarks could disrupt the 2026 World Cup.

Australian officials have sought to assure the public that the women were given every opportunity to stay.